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CHAPTER I

The House of Condolence

By half past eight the drawing room had already been corrected for grief. The coloured cushions had been removed. The brighter rug had been turned so the faded side faced up. The blue glass vase on the sideboard stood empty because Maryam's mother had said, from the sofa and without opening her eyes properly, that fresh flowers looked festive. The curtains were half-drawn against a pale Jerusalem morning that might have belonged to any other day in Qatamon had one not known that Uncle Yusef was lying no longer in his flat but in the mortuary room at the church, waiting to be prayed over, handled, buried, spoken of, and sorted.

Maryam stood in the doorway for a moment before going in, not because she was overcome but because the house had already ceased to be private. That happened quickly in a condolence house. A room in which one had eaten, quarrelled, read letters, or scolded a child the previous week became public property as soon as the first caller crossed the threshold. Cups bred on every surface. Women entered the kitchen and opened cupboards they had never opened before. One's own tiredness became almost indecent, as though fatigue were a form of selfishness.

She was wearing the dark grey dress she had put aside after Aunt Salwa's funeral rather than the black, which was too shaped through the waist and had a neckline she no longer trusted under the inspection of older women. The grey was

not flattering, which on such a morning counted in its favour. While she fastened it she had remembered, with immediate annoyance at herself, that Uncle Yusef had once told her grey improved her because it forced the face to do the work. She could not decide whether the memory constituted affection. As she had buttoned the collar she had noticed, with disgust and accuracy, that even the unflattering dress made her look composed. She had thought, for one wretched instant, that people would say she wore sorrow with dignity, and then had hated herself for thinking of how she might be seen before the day had properly begun. But hating herself had not altered the fall of the skirt. Vanity did not vanish because it was despised; it merely learned better manners.

Leila sat on the carpet near the sofa with a pack of cards that had once belonged to Yusef, building a crooked little house out of them with the concentration children reserved for games they believed secretly serious. One card kept sliding out of place. She pushed it back, frowned, and then saw her mother.

"Must I stay downstairs?" she asked.

"For now."

"Will everybody cry?"

"Some will."

"Will you?"

Maryam bent to lift the loose cards before someone stepped on them. "Not in front of everyone."

Leila accepted this as a practical arrangement rather than a revelation. "Amina says I must keep my shoes on."

"That is because Amina is wise."

Leila looked down at her own feet, one shoe buckled and one lying beside her like a small declaration of resistance. "I do not like wise people."

Maryam straightened the child's stocking and fastened the second shoe. Behind them, from the back of the house, came the sounds of labour already under way: cupboard doors, running water, crockery being lifted more quickly than was safe. Amina had arrived late by no more than twenty minutes, and even that had been enough for Maryam's mother to say from the sofa that people's habits went to pieces the moment the city turned troublesome. Amina had not replied. She had gone straight to the kitchen with her scarf still half-pinned and begun boiling water with the speed of someone who knew the house would punish her for every lost minute even if nobody raised a hand. She never wasted an answer when work could be used as an answer instead.

Uncle Yusef had died the previous evening just after seven. The porter's son from his building had gone up with a bag of oranges and found the door not properly shut. A chair had been tipped over near the writing desk. One slipper lay in the passage and the other in the sitting room. Maryam had not seen the body. Hanna had. He had gone at once when the message came and had come back an hour later carrying Yusef's spectacles, the key to the flat, and the look he wore whenever practical matters had begun ordering

themselves behind his eyes.

"A stroke, most likely," he had said in their bedroom while she took off the blue earrings she suddenly felt ashamed of. "The doctor came. He had not been long dead."

"Was anyone with him?"

"No."

That answer had remained with her. Not the stroke. Not the doctor. The no.

Yusef had lived alone for eleven years, since his wife's death, and had done so with the irritated independence of a man who considered company both necessary and overrated. He read in three languages and kept important documents in none of the places sensible people kept them. He fed Leila sweets before supper and argued with priests without ceasing to think of himself as devout. He once told Maryam that tidy drawers were proof of a limited moral imagination, which she had laughed at more than the remark deserved because it had been one of the few times in recent years that she had been honestly amused in his presence. When she was fourteen she had returned a book to his flat and found him at the desk with three letters open before him in three languages. He had tapped the English one and said, "Civilisation is a conspiracy of letters written by people who never have to open them." Then he had given her coffee far too sweet because, he said, only children and optimists deserved that much sugar. For years she associated the flat with that illicit coffee and with the deeper illicitness of being spoken to as if one might already possess a mind.

Now he was dead, and the first visitors had not yet arrived, and already the day belonged more to coffee, chairs, and protocols than to the fact itself.

Amina came in carrying a tray of glasses still damp from washing. Her apron had been tied on crookedly. A strand of hair stuck to her cheek. She set the tray down and looked around the room with the appraising glance of a woman who knew that whatever the family had decided about mourning, it would be her back that carried it.

"The coffee is enough until noon if the first wave is not too great," she said. "After that we will need the better tin."

Maryam frowned. "Why not the ordinary one?"

"Your aunt sent it next door before I arrived. They were short."

"My aunt sent our coffee next door?"

"For the soul of the deceased, apparently." Amina picked up a glass and held it to the light, checking for smears. "It seems coffee travels well between houses when souls are concerned."

Leila said, "How much coffee does a soul need?"

"An indecent amount," Amina said.

Maryam nearly smiled and did not. "Use the reserve tin."

Amina's face altered very slightly. The reserve tin was for

feast days, priests, or people her mother wished to impress. "As you wish."

"What about sugar?"

"We have enough sugar if the ladies mourn modestly."

A moment later Hanna came in carrying two folding chairs under one arm and a notebook in his hand. He had taken off his hat because he knew Maryam's mother disliked hats indoors, but the mark of the band was still pressed faintly into his hair. His tie was straight. His face looked composed in the way it always did when he was most tired.

"The chairs from Nabil are broken," he said, setting the usable pair against the wall. "Samir will bring more from the club before eleven."

He looked at Leila. "No running today."

"I know."

"You may know after I have finished speaking."

Leila looked down.

Maryam felt the familiar inward tightening. Hanna was not cruel with the child. He was simply exact, and exactness in him often felt colder than anger in other people.

"She has been very good," Maryam said.

"I am glad to hear it." He turned to Amina. "The ice is on

its way. Keep one basin in the back room. If the men remain after the burial we will need more water. And ask the boy to fetch another packet of cigarettes."

"You do not smoke," Maryam said.

"The men do."

Amina nodded and went out. Hanna looked at Maryam then, though not for long. "The undertaker may need proof of the family plot. Your uncle appears to have kept the relevant papers in at least four places, none of them obvious."

"Must that be dealt with today?"

"It must be begun today."

There it was already: the intrusion of the unromantic. Yusef had not been dead twelve hours and the world was already asking for receipts.

A knock sounded at the front door — three brisk raps, the knock of someone who knew she was expected to be admitted — and the day began.

The first women arrived in pairs, which was somehow more oppressive than if they had come one by one. A single visitor might enter as herself. Two entered as condolence embodied: one speaking, the other nodding, both scented with powder and damp wool. They kissed Maryam on both cheeks, lowered themselves into chairs, accepted coffee, and began sorting Yusef into the approved categories of the dead. A good man, difficult but kind. A man of books,

impossible with practical matters. Lonely at the end, but perhaps that had suited him. Sharp-tongued, but soft-hearted. One never really knew such men.

Maryam listened and inclined her head at the right moments and thought that death did not merely close a life; it edited it. Whole sections were cut for tone. Other sections were softened until they became almost false. No one said he could be rude for sport, or that he held on to letters and grievances equally, or that he had once insulted a bishop over dessert. Yet these things had belonged to him as much as his tenderness with Leila or his habit of arriving with oranges.

Her mother received the women as though condolence were a rank to be conferred and properly borne. She did not rise. She let them come to her, press her fingers, and tell her that God gave and took according to mysteries no one could question. From time to time she laid two fingers against her temple and closed her eyes — not theatrically exactly, but with the grave self-command of a woman who had decided that visible strength might be mistaken for indifference. Maryam knew the gesture well. It meant her mother had chosen fragility as her most dignified form of control.

By ten o'clock there were already too many cups in the room and too many sentences being repeated as though repetition turned them into truth. Leila had been sent upstairs once and had come down twice. The second time she sat on the arm of Maryam's chair and whispered, too audibly, "Why is everyone saying he loved children when he was rude to Uncle Fawzi?"

"Because this is not the day to inventory everything," Maryam murmured.

"It seems the best day. He cannot interrupt."

Before Maryam could answer, Father Elias arrived. He wore his ordinary black coat rather than ceremonial dress, which somehow made him seem more human and more clerical at once. He smelled faintly of tobacco and rain.

"Your uncle had a restless mind," he said to Maryam after paying his respects to her mother. "That is often mistaken for impiety by those with calmer ones."

It was the kindest thing anyone had yet said.

"He liked to provoke people," Maryam answered.

"Only those who needed provoking."

She almost smiled. He lowered his voice. "The city is awkward today. Some people may be late. Do not take offence at absences."

"Was there trouble?"

"A lorry stopped. A road watched. Men made nervous. It is enough these days."

He moved away to speak with Hanna, and Maryam stood a moment with the phrase in her mind. This was how the city entered houses now. Not in speeches. In altered expectations. Someone might not come. A servant might be delayed. A driver might take the longer road. Ordinary

life had begun carrying precautions inside it like hidden seams.

In the kitchen the real day was taking place. Amina had committed the onions to the pot. Aunt Widad sat at the table with a list on her lap and the expression of a woman determined to defeat chaos by accounting for it. The errand boy was shelling pistachios as though the task personally insulted him. Maryam had taken Leila there on the pretext of feeding her because there was nowhere else in a condolence house to put a child except directly in the path of labour.

Leila, seated on a low stool with bread and butter because Amina did not believe in discussing death on an empty stomach, said, "Uncle Yusef said Aunt Widad arranged drawers the way generals arrange borders."

For a second the kitchen froze. Even Aunt Widad had to look down to hide the movement at the corner of her mouth.

"There you are," Aunt Widad said, recovering. "Your mother has eaten nothing, which is foolish, and the undertaker requires the cemetery receipt. Did Yusef keep it in that hideous leather case?"

"The hideous leather case contains theatre programmes, two tax notices, one photograph of a woman no one can identify, and a tram ticket from God knows when."

"Which woman?"

"I have no idea. The point is that there is no logic."

"There is always a logic," Aunt Widad said, tapping the pencil against the page. "Only some men are too vain to make it visible."

This was one of Aunt Widad's ruling convictions, alongside the belief that grief should be expressed in a controlled key and that servants invariably heard more than was good for them. To watch her at that table with her lists and pencil was to see one version of love performed as management so steadily that it became indistinguishable from necessity. If she could total the bread and account for missing cutlery, she did not have to stand still before the fact that Yusef, who had tormented her over trifles for twenty years and then brought her apricots without ever admitting it was an apology, was gone.

The burial took place under a sky that threatened rain without committing itself. By the time the procession formed, the undertaker had arrived late, the committee man had forgotten the smaller wreath, a cousin from Baq'a had been delayed by some inspection or some driver's fear of inspection, and even the priest had the expression of a man already calculating how long he might stay before another grief required him.

At the cemetery gate, just as Hanna had anticipated, there was a question about the family plot papers. The clerk, a stooped man with the grave anxiety of minor authority, turned the pages of a ledger and said there ought to be a supplementary notation after the death of Maryam's grandfather, in whose name the plot had originally been registered. Hanna produced receipts, a parish acknowledgment, and a letter with an old church stamp.

The clerk said yes, but the supplementary notation. Father Elias said the dead would not improve by waiting while the ledger was admired. The clerk reddened.

Hanna did not raise his voice. He never did when it mattered. He pointed to a line on a receipt and said, "This is the parish acknowledgment when my wife's grandfather died. This receipt shows payment for maintenance of the same plot four years later. If you require the additional notation in the register, it will be found. If you need to satisfy yourself that we are not attempting to bury a family member in somebody else's ground, you are already satisfied."

The clerk looked at Father Elias, who declined to rescue him. A moment later he closed the ledger and said there was, of course, no difficulty.

There never was one, Maryam thought. There was only the theatre of one.

She watched Hanna return the papers to the envelope and felt, not for the first time, both gratitude and irritation. He was better than most men at making institutions behave, and he did it without pride because for him it was simply part of being a competent adult. He understood bureaucracies in the way some men understood horses: by instinct sharpened through attention. He knew when another man's insistence came from rule and when it came from fear of appearing lax. She had never loved this quality in him. She had relied on it more times than she could remember.

The burial itself was mercifully short. Earth, prayer, the

priest's voice, women shifting their weight on uneven ground. Maryam had expected some inward rupture proportionate to the fact of Yusef entering the earth. What came instead was smaller and more exact: his spectacles were still at home on the sideboard. No one would now remember properly how much cardamom he liked in his coffee or how badly he filed anything that mattered. The world did not halt. It only incorporated the loss into a series of tasks.

On the drive back Hanna leaned forward and said quietly to the driver, "Take the longer way," before they had fully reached the knot of men and the lorry blocking half the road.

"Was that necessary?" Maryam asked.

"Yes."

"You did not even look."

"I had looked already."

That answer irritated her and reassured her in the same instant.

When they returned, the house was full again. That was perhaps the worst thing about a condolence day: one's own grief never remained long enough in a room to settle before more people arrived carrying theirs, or what they called theirs, and changed the air again. Amina moved through it with the flattened expression of someone who had ceased expecting the day to end at any reasonable hour. By late afternoon the front room smelled of damp

coats, coffee, tobacco, and the onions Amina had committed to the pot because grief on an empty stomach began to look indecent.

In the lull between callers Maryam stood alone at the window and watched a British lorry move slowly uphill. Two boys stopped to stare at it and then moved on. A woman crossed herself before entering the house opposite. Farther down, someone was quarrelling with a driver in tones of ordinary irritation. The city was maintaining itself through trivial arguments, as though refusing to surrender the right to annoyance might keep more frightening things at bay.

By evening the house had altered for the third time. Morning had been preparation, afternoon endurance, evening was the work left after grief had gone home to eat. The room was no longer crowded but marked by occupation. Cups stood in little constellations where conversations had ended badly or well. Ash had fallen on the turned rug despite convictions about women who mourned properly. Two spoons were missing. Someone had left a black glove on the sideboard beside Yusef's spectacles. Maryam's mother had retired to bed with the exhausted grandeur of a monarch after public duty. Leila had fallen asleep on a blanket in Maryam's room after resisting sleep as if it were an argument she could win. Aunt Widad still sat at the dining table with the accounts for bread, ice, lentils, cigarettes, sugar, and candles.

"We are short four spoons," she said.

"We are short an uncle as well," Maryam answered.

"That cannot be entered as an expense."

"It will be anyway."

Aunt Widad set down her pencil. "You are tired."

"Yes."

"That is when people become clever in unhelpful ways."

This was perhaps one of the differences between the women in her family and the women in her kitchen: her aunt said the same things Amina did, only dressed in judgment where Amina simply put bread on the plate.

Hanna came in carrying the borrowed condolence mats rolled under one arm. "Nabil will collect these in the morning," he said.

"Four spoons," Aunt Widad repeated.

"Then we have fed the poor more thoroughly than intended."

He set the mats down, picked up Yusef's spectacles from the sideboard, considered them as if he might clean them, and then put them back untouched. That small unfinished motion struck Maryam more sharply than any open show of grief would have done. Hanna was not demonstrative, but feeling sometimes became visible in him precisely because it had to cross so much discipline before appearing at all. He had respected Yusef in the way men sometimes respect those who would not have made their lives easier but made them sharper.

"The porter's son will sleep in the flat tonight," he said. "It seemed wiser than leaving it entirely empty on the first night."

"Wise," Aunt Widad said. "Did you tell him not to touch the desk?"

"I told him not to touch anything he was not eating."

That earned the first brief real laughter of the day.

Later, when Aunt Widad had gone home and Amina had wrapped the remaining lentils and rice into smaller dishes because she would not see good food wasted merely because educated people were tired, Hanna spread the contents of Yusef's leather case across the dining table.

He did it with a method Maryam found almost offensive. Death ought to create disorder. One resented any man who could stack it.

There were the theatre programmes from the 1920s. Two tax notices. A postcard from Alexandria on which Yusef had written only, The fish is still better here. There were parish receipts, none bearing the precise year they most needed. There was the photograph of the unknown woman in an extravagant hat. There were letters from a bank written in English and a small tied packet of papers in French which looked, to Maryam, like the residue of some old tenancy matter or compensation claim.

"Did he understand any of these?" she asked.

"He understood enough to be annoyed by them," Hanna said.

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

He had removed his tie and rolled his sleeves. He looked like a man at honest work, which perhaps explained some of the irritation Maryam always felt before he had even spoken.

"This can wait until morning," she said.

"Some of it can."

"You have been saying that all day."

"Because it remains true."

She picked up the photograph of the unknown woman and turned it over. Nothing on the back. No name. No date. No place. "It is not respectful."

"What is not?"

"This." She gestured at the papers, the case, the table. "He is barely buried."

"If I leave a municipal notice unanswered, the municipality will not become more reverent because your uncle is dead."

She looked down. He was right, which did not improve the

answer.

There were also, he told her, papers in the flat itself: in the desk, beneath it, in drawers, in books. The porter's son had reported that when they righted the chair, a sheaf had slid under the table and another had fallen from a drawer.

"Please do not describe the room," Maryam said.

"I was describing the papers."

"You know what I mean."

He did know, which was why he paused before saying only, "I know."

She picked up one of the English bank letters, then one of the French papers, then set both down. "I can translate some of it."

"Some," he said.

She heard in that the precise measure of her limits and disliked him for being accurate.

"What are we actually looking for?" she asked.

"Anything that tells us what he owned, what he owed, what was owed him, what he promised, and what he neglected to arrange."

"You make him sound impossible."

"He was impossible in many of the ways men become

charming only because they are not one's husband."

The sentence was so dry she looked up sharply. He was not trying to be funny. He was simply, for one unguarded moment, telling the truth as he saw it.

"And if he had been your husband?" she asked.

"I would have put his papers in order while he was alive."

That was Hanna entire. Love, to him, was often indistinguishable from prevention.

From the kitchen came the sound of a cup breaking. Amina did not curse, which meant she was too tired for curses. Upstairs Leila turned in her sleep and asked for water without waking. The house had become small again.

"We will need help," Hanna said at last, sorting the English letters into one pile and the French papers into another.

"From whom?"

"There is a man I know."

"From your office?"

"No. A school originally. He does translation work now as well. Petitions, letters, forms, tenancy matters. Nabil used him once and said he was exact."

"A stranger at the flat?"

"Not tonight. Tomorrow perhaps. If we cannot make sense

of all this first."

Maryam looked down at the papers. The thought of an outsider moving through Yusef's disorder felt like another small violence. Yet the alternative was worse: that the disorder should remain unsorted, endless, humiliating, and active.

"What is his name?" she asked.

Hanna gathered the French papers into a tighter stack before answering.

"Tariq," he said. "Tariq al-Khatib."

The name meant nothing to her, which perhaps was why it stayed in the room.

"Tariq al-Khatib," she repeated, searching for a face from weddings, school events, church halls, offices, and finding none.

"He is Muslim?" she asked, and hated the narrowness of the question even as she asked it.

"Yes."

"And that troubles no one?"

"Nabil is troubled by tenants who do not pay and roofs that leak. He has a useful sense of proportion."

She might have argued. She did not. The photograph of the unknown woman still lay between the bank letters and the

receipts as though she, too, were waiting to see what the family would do next.

In the hall Amina stood tying on her scarf, ready at last to leave. "I may be later tomorrow," she said. "If the road by the lower gardens is watched again, I will have to come round."

"Come when you can," Maryam said.

Amina's eyes flicked once to the sorted papers on the table. "Do not leave the front window unlatched. The catch is loose."

Then she was gone, and the house was quiet enough at last to hear the rain.

Maryam remained at the table after Hanna had gone upstairs. The room smelled of coffee gone stale and rain on stone. Yusef's spectacles still lay beside the empty blue vase. The key to his flat sat in her handbag, heavier than its size justified. On the table were all the things that had survived him badly: receipts, tax notices, bank letters, theatre programmes, an unidentified woman's face, and the first practical shape of the days ahead.

She thought of Yusef sitting at that desk with his three open letters, speaking to her as though intelligence were not an inconvenience in a daughter. She thought of the flat she had not yet entered since his death — the narrow sofa, the books in double rows, the single pillow indented beyond recovery. A life arranged to look sufficient because no one else had been allowed fully inside it.

Death, she thought, had not created grandeur. It had created work. And somewhere just beyond the circle of family, church, cousins, aunt, porter's son, and municipal clerk, there was now a man whose name meant nothing and would tomorrow begin meaning something.

Tariq al-Khatib.

Upstairs Leila slept. In the kitchen the last spoon was placed in the last drawer. Rain touched the shutters with more certainty now. And on the table, in ordered little piles, lay the first evidence that whatever sorrow the day had granted them, tomorrow would belong to papers.

CHAPTER II

Uncle Yusef's Flat

The house, the morning after a condolence, always looked faintly ashamed of itself.

The borrowed chairs were still where exhaustion had left them. Cups stood in the drawing room in little groups, some empty, some with a skin of coffee gone cold and grey. The turned rug had collected ash despite everything Maryam's mother believed about women who mourned properly. In the hall an umbrella with a silver handle leaned against the wall with the calm entitlement of an object convinced it belonged there. The curtains were half drawn. The house had not yet decided whether it remained in grief or was merely continuing.

Maryam came downstairs later than she would ordinarily have allowed herself, not because she had overslept but because Leila had kept her awake with wakeful questions asked out of the dark in a voice already thick with sleep.

"Will he know where we put him?"

"No."

"Then how will he find us?"

"He does not need to."

"That seems rude."

By the fourth or fifth question Maryam had stopped answering and begun smoothing the child's hair until both of them had fallen asleep from the sheer fatigue of being alive after burial.

Now Leila sat at the breakfast table in her nightdress with one stocking on and one off, watching Amina butter bread with the concentration children brought to small acts of injustice.

"You said we were not going to church," she announced when Maryam entered.

"We are not."

"Then why must I wear the better stockings?"

"Because you are staying here," Amina said before Maryam could answer, "and I will not have you greeting

respectable ladies in stockings that make the house look abandoned."
Leila accepted bread with gloom. "Where are you going?"
"To your uncle's flat."
"I want to come."
"No."
"Why?"
"Because there will be dust, papers, your Aunt Widad, and no patience anywhere."
"I could help with dust."
"You could help dust become worse," Amina said.
Maryam sat, though she did not want breakfast. Her mother had sent word through the closed bedroom door that she was too tired to go to the flat and too tired to receive anyone before noon, which meant in practice that she would receive anyone who arrived and complain afterwards of her weakness. Aunt Widad, by contrast, had already been heard in the passage asking whether the leather case had been tied back up after last night and whether Hanna had remembered to bring string. She spoke of string the way generals spoke of flank positions.
Hanna came in as Maryam lifted her cup. He had shaved already and changed into a fresh shirt; only the slight greyness under his eyes admitted he had slept badly. He carried Yusef's key and a folded sheet of paper.
"Nabil's man will come at half past ten," he said.
"That soon?"
"If we wait, the papers will remain papers. If we begin, some of them may become answers."
"And Leila?"
"Amina."
Amina, without turning from the stove, said, "Unless the city decides otherwise."
This was how people spoke now. Roads, visits, the time of arrival of milk, whether a servant could cross from one quarter to another — all rested under the broad and imprecise sovereignty of whether the city decided otherwise.

They left Leila with Amina, who stood in the doorway as they went with her sleeves rolled and a dishcloth over one shoulder like a soldier's sash. Leila stood behind her in better stockings than she deserved.

"Bring me something that was his," she called.

"There is nothing there you need," Maryam said.

"That seems unfair," Leila replied, and the door shut on the rest.

They went on foot because the flat lay near enough and because walking still preserved the fiction that the city belonged to those who moved through it. Qatamon looked both ordinary and slightly thinned, as if part of its attention were elsewhere. A milk cart stood outside the Abu-Rashids' wall. Two schoolboys kicked a stone rather than a ball because stones remained available when balls disappeared into gardens or windows. A woman in a navy coat carried bread under her arm and nodded to Aunt Widad, who had fallen into step beside them on the corner, without slowing. There was no spectacle to the street, nothing a stranger might have named crisis. Only a faint withdrawal of ease. People looked up sooner at unfamiliar engines. Men stood a little longer at corners talking.

Maryam kept pace beside Hanna and thought, not for the first time, that marriage produced strange forms of intimacy and strange forms of ignorance. She knew the exact shape of his shoulder under three of his jackets, the order in which he buttoned cuffs, the smell of tobacco that clung to him only after business dinners because he did not smoke and always returned mildly disapproving of those who did. She did not know what he had felt when he entered Yusef's flat the previous evening and found the chair overturned and the body not yet fully cold. One could live beside a man for years and still not know whether silence in him was absence or concealment.

Uncle Yusef's building stood on a street that would once have seemed merely quiet and now seemed watchful. The porter's son was sitting on the bottom step with a newspaper open on his knee and leapt up at once.

"I slept there, as you said. In the passage. The cat objected."
"The cat?" Maryam repeated.
"The late master fed a grey one. It came through the kitchen window and behaved as though I was the intruder."
"There is always a cat with men who live alone," Aunt Widad said darkly, as if such arrangements encouraged one another.
Hanna took out the key. Maryam looked up at the windows of the flat and had the sudden plain thought that a place could become strange in one day without anything inside it having moved.
The smell met them on the landing before the room itself did. Not decay, not yet, but the particular smell of a place inhabited by one person whose habits had not been corrected by anyone else: books, old tobacco, coffee grounds, dust warming slowly in a room kept too long closed, and something faintly medicinal from the bottle the doctor must have left uncapped. When Hanna opened the door fully the smell came out into the stairwell with the intimacy of a secret overheard.
The flat was exactly and not at all as she remembered it. The same narrow passage, too crowded with umbrella stand, coat pegs, and newspapers. The same sitting room with the sofa beneath the window, its cover gone shiny where Yusef had sat reading. Books in double rows, old receipts marking places in them, a brass lamp with a shade permanently listing to one side. On the low table beside the armchair sat an ashtray with two cigarette ends, though Yusef rarely smoked unless someone particularly foolish had visited. In the grate lay the grey remains of a fire too small to have been worth the ash. But all of it had altered by being ownerless. Yesterday the room had belonged to a difficult, solitary man. Today it had become evidence. Nothing in it had been arranged for posterity. That was its mercy. Death had found it mid-sentence.
Maryam crossed to the desk and touched the edge of the blotter. The leather was cracked where Yusef had rested

his wrist for years. Beside it lay a half-sheet in his hand containing only four words and a number: Ask Nabil re water.

"Do not begin by touching everything," said Hanna.

"I touched the edge of a blotter."

"That is how people begin touching everything."

He opened the windows one by one. Light came in reluctantly, showing not revelation but more dust. In the bedroom the bed had been remade badly — one corner of the blanket tucked with conscientiousness, the other hanging free. On the chair lay yesterday's jacket with one orange pip dried to the cuff. An empty spectacles case on the chest of drawers. A bottle of hair tonic. Cuff links in a saucer. The sort of objects that suggested not character but maintenance. One forgot, until rooms like this, how much of a person was simply the work of continuation.

There were oranges in the kitchen beside the sink, eight of them, one already softening. Yusef had gone up the previous evening with oranges and died before managing them. The fact seemed so petty that it hurt more than larger facts.

When she returned to the sitting room, Aunt Widad had stationed herself at the round table and begun making piles according to a system she had invented in the last thirty seconds and would defend like canon law. Hanna had gone straight to the desk. Papers were on the floor beneath it, and a drawer hung half open. There were envelopes, letters in English, typed pages in French, two account books, a biscuit tin full of receipts mixed with theatre stubs and visiting cards. On the chair lay Yusef's jacket, carefully folded by someone else. He had never folded jackets.

Maryam went to the bookshelf before she meant to. Between a French grammar and a volume of sermons she found a tram ticket still serving as a marker. The sight of it irritated her more than it sorrowed her. The dead left behind such useless little continuities.

"Do not begin with the books," said Hanna without turning.

"I was not beginning."
"You were standing exactly like someone about to begin."
A knock sounded at the open door.
Maryam turned too quickly. A man she had never seen stood on the landing with a hat in one hand and a leather satchel in the other. He was not handsome in any easy way. His face was too spare, the lines of it held close, as if excess in him had long ago been forced inward. His coat was good but worn at the cuffs. His collar was clean. He had the look of a man who took trouble with himself not from vanity but from some refusal to let neglect do its usual work.
"Hanna Bey," he said. His voice was lower than she had expected. Not rich. Simply controlled.
"Mr al-Khatib. Thank you for coming."
Maryam knew at once, with that odd little inward movement by which the mind fits a name to a body, that this was Tariq. The name had sat all night in the house without an image attached to it. Now it had a body and a manner, and both complicated things rather than clarifying them. Nothing in him asked for favour. Nothing in him performed humility for the household into which he had stepped.
Aunt Widad said, "You are very kind."
"It is not kindness," he answered, and then, seeing the sentence land harder than politeness preferred, added, "Your kinsman is known to Mr Nabil. He spoke warmly."
This was almost certainly not true. Nabil did not speak warmly of anybody whose roof leaked or whose claims kept him from luncheon. But the phrase served.
Hanna made the introductions. "My wife, Maryam. My aunt by marriage, Widad Hanania."
Tariq inclined his head to each of them. His courtesy was exact but lacked the faint softening men often brought into rooms like this when faced with women they assumed needed gentleness. Maryam noticed the absence at once.
He set down the satchel, removed his coat, and went to the desk without asking leave. Not rudely. Merely as a man who knew why he had been called. He looked before touching anything. That, Maryam noticed, was the first

sign of competence in almost any field: the refusal to move until the thing had been properly seen.

"These on the floor were dislodged yesterday?" he asked.

"So Elias says."

He touched the half-open drawer with two fingers, as though testing not its weight but the truthfulness of its appearance. Then he looked at the piles Aunt Widad had made.

"With your permission," he said, "I would first separate by source rather than by apparent subject. Men like your uncle often hide their subject under the wrong heading, but they are more faithful to the origin of a paper than to its function."

"And how do you know that?" Aunt Widad asked.

He glanced at the biscuit tin. "Because he kept parish receipts with tax notices and theatre programmes, but all three are still folded according to whoever sent them, not according to what they mean. That is an administrative conscience, however bad the filing."

Maryam looked at him properly then. Not in interest, not yet, but in the way one looked at a person who had said something so exact that one's own thoughts suddenly appeared slovenly by comparison.

Hanna said, "Do whatever makes them intelligible."

"That may take time."

"We have some."

Tariq rolled back his cuffs one by one. The inner wrist of one sleeve had been patched neatly enough that the patch had almost become part of the cloth. He drew the nearest bundle towards him, opened the blue account book, and read two lines in silence.

"Your uncle wrote English figures as if he disapproved of them," he said.

Even Hanna smiled.

From there the work became oddly absorbing. Tariq sorted not by tidiness but by pressure: what would cause trouble first if left unanswered, what concerned money already moving, what could wait, what could not. The bank letters and insurance papers he placed to the left. Parish receipts

and cemetery matters to the centre. French pages and municipal notices to the right. Yusef's own notes he left in a pile of their own because, he said, men like your uncle often told the truth in irritation but never in order.

Maryam translated where asked, though not as often as she expected. Tariq's French was better than hers, or perhaps only less school-shaped. He did not translate aloud every line to display possession of it. He read, paused, and said things like, "This is a tenancy dispute that predates the war and never understood it had ended," or, "This appears to be water damage complicated by wounded pride."

Once he turned a page towards her and put his finger on a line in the margin. "Is that your uncle's hand or the clerk's?"

She leaned over the desk. "My uncle's. He is calling the man a donkey, but politely."

"Can one insult politely in French?"

"One can insult beautifully in French."

He glanced up. "And in Arabic?"

"In Arabic one need not pretend beauty is the point."

The smallest shift at the corner of his mouth acknowledged the line and then vanished. He returned to the page without surprise or praise, and that, more than any compliment would have done, let Maryam feel the odd steadiness of being used accurately. Most men who discovered a woman knew French treated the fact either as an adornment or an error. Tariq treated it as one more available instrument on the table, neither more nor less remarkable than Hanna's eye for receipts or Aunt Widad's for missing spoons.

At the third English bank letter he tapped one line with his pencil. "If not answered within thirty days, the account may be frozen pending formal confirmation of holder identity. Since the holder is dead, identity is no longer his best feature."

Maryam took the paper from him. Yusef dead, Yusef buried, Yusef mourned, and meanwhile a bank prepared

to continue the relationship only if he proved himself in writing.

"Bureaucracy," Tariq said, as if answering a thought she had not spoken, "does not object to death. It objects to incomplete death."

She looked up before she meant to. For one second she was not the keeper of her uncle's papers or Hanna's wife. She was simply someone who had heard the sentence she herself would have wanted to say had she trusted a room to receive it.

Hanna, who trusted sentences less than outcomes, made a note in his book.

The Armenian tenant arrived before noon. He was shorter than Maryam had expected, with the offended briskness of a man who had practised respectability too carefully to be denied by death. He removed his hat, held it with both hands, and said he regretted intruding under such sad circumstances but his trunks contained winter cloth, which if left in a damp room would mildew beyond redemption.

Hanna handled him. Of course he did. But Tariq's presence altered the handling. Where Hanna managed the practical dignity of the conversation, Tariq quietly extracted the terms: three trunks and a crate, stored since October, paid in cash to the deceased, unwitnessed. A folded receipt more legible than any in the flat emerged from the Armenian's inner pocket, and the matter moved at once from rhetoric to paper. The trunks, Hanna said, might remain until week's end. The Armenian relaxed, thanked them all, and then apologised to Maryam for mentioning mildew in front of a lady.

When he had gone, Aunt Widad said, "He wanted to seize the moment."

"He wanted his cloth," said Hanna.

"Men's motives are always smaller than women permit them to be," said Tariq, still looking at the receipt.

Maryam had to lower her eyes then because the sentence struck too close to laughter.

By the time the light began flattening, the room had altered without becoming cleaner. There were now tied bundles on the table, labelled stacks by the desk, a separate pile for papers needing formal reply, and one depressing heap of bills whose importance death had not improved. The flat no longer looked like a private man's interruption. It looked like a small office assembled inside the remains of one.

Hanna gathered the most urgent papers into the leather case. "Tomorrow I will take the bank letters and the certificate question to the office. After that, there is my sister's rent matter."

"Must that be tomorrow as well?" Maryam asked.

"It has already waited."

He said it without complaint, as a man stated weather. The sister's needs, the bank's requirements, the parish records, the insurance inquiry — all of them queued in him with the same orderly patience he brought to claims at work. She sometimes wondered whether he experienced obligation as weight or as architecture.

Tariq began gathering his notebook and spectacles. "I can return tomorrow. After one — I must stop at the school first."

That was the first mention of his other life. Maryam realised, with a small surprise, that until then she had not thought of him as existing outside this room. The reminder that he belonged elsewhere — pupils, lessons, another building in another quarter — made him at once more ordinary and more difficult to place.

Aunt Widad said, "Bring better string if you come through the market."

Tariq looked at the tied packets. "That is the first practical order I have heard all day."

"It is the only kind worth giving."

He inclined his head. "Then I will obey it."

On the landing, because the stair was narrow and the others were ahead, Maryam and Tariq found themselves level for one moment.

"You knew the room well?" he asked.

It was such a small question that she nearly answered with the small lie. Instead she said, "Well enough to know what is missing when strangers put things in order."

He accepted that without softening it. "Order is often a form of theft," he said. "Sometimes a necessary one."

Then Aunt Widad called from below that the landing light was indeed unreliable and that everyone with functioning legs ought to use them before Providence withdrew the rest, and the moment ended exactly before it could become one.

On the walk home, Aunt Widad asked over her shoulder, "What do you think of him?"

Maryam said, "He is exact."

"That is not a character judgement."

"It is enough for a day."

Hanna, without turning, said, "It is more than enough for most days."

At the house they found three women had called and gone, one priest had left a note, and Leila had made Amina read aloud from a geography primer because apparently mourning suspended ordinary lessons only for adults. "Did you bring me something that was his?" Leila demanded.

"No," said Maryam.

"That is mean."

"It is sensible," said Hanna.

Leila looked to Amina for justice. Amina, peeling potatoes with the brisk vindication of a woman whose afternoon had been harder than theirs, said, "If you want something of his, keep the card pack and stop asking."

That night Maryam stood in the dining room with the lamp lowered and looked at the topmost page in the packet Hanna had tied. Beneath it, half visible, lay the lines Yusef had copied from the French novel he had loved enough to transcribe rather than trust himself to remember. She did not untie the string. She only stood with her fingers on it, thinking of the flat's single pillow, the oranges softening by the sink, the cracked blotter, and a man rolling back patched cuffs before sorting chaos into sources.

She blew out the lamp and left the packets where they were. The work had ceased to be one visit. Yusef's life would take longer to put in order than any of them had yet admitted. And whatever else tomorrow required — claims, certificates, a clerk at the bank, a road taken the longer way — the flat would go on needing them, and Tariq would return to it carrying better string and another morning's teaching behind him.

That was enough to know for now. More than enough, perhaps, for a day in which nothing had happened except usefulness and paper.

CHAPTER III

Claims

Hanna had left before the second kettle boiled.
Maryam knew it at once from the arrangement he had left behind: the cup on the table with coffee not entirely finished, the crust of bread on the small plate, the butter knife laid beside it in a line too straight to have been accidental, and the blue file tied with string where Uncle Yusef's packet had lain the night before. Even in haste Hanna contrived to make haste look orderly. Maryam sometimes found this reassuring and sometimes exhausting.
Amina, standing over the stove with the expression of a woman injured by weather and human appetite alike, said, "He took no breakfast. Coffee standing up. Two mouthfuls of bread. Then he went."
"He said he had the office first."
"He said many things. Men say work first as if the body does not notice being neglected."
Leila, in one stocking and no shoes, had climbed onto Hanna's chair and was tracing the embossed pattern on his leather case with one finger. "Does that one contain sad papers or boring papers?"
"They are often the same papers," Maryam said.
"That seems unfair."
"Most systems are."
Leila considered this with the seriousness children reserved for the more unnecessary cruelties of adult life. "He promised to come back before luncheon."
"When?"
"Before he left."
"That is not when. That is where."
Leila frowned, aware she had erred but not yet convinced language ought to punish her for it. "Do people still have to work after a funeral?"
"Yes."
"That seems rude."

"It may be rude. It remains true."

Amina set the kettle down harder than she needed to. "If little ladies are going to ask philosophy before breakfast, they may at least put both stockings on."

On the table, beneath the string of the blue file, Maryam found the note he had left.

Maryam,

If you can, come after one. Huda will be less agitated if there is another woman in the room. The landlord is due at two, and she has persuaded herself that men speaking in low voices over paper means eviction. There is also the matter of the ceiling.

H.

No endearment, no apology for the instruction, and no explanation beyond the practical one. That, too, was Hanna: to make a request as though usefulness were the most ordinary thing in the world and therefore owed.

Her mother, who disliked being reminded that other households' troubles continued during her own, tapped the note with one lacquered nail. "She always becomes dramatic over rooms. Even before her husband died she treated every crack in a wall as though the British had laid the mortar personally."

"Huda lives under a leaking pipe," said Maryam.

"She lives under insufficient income, which is a different weather entirely."

Aunt Widad, who had arrived in time to hear only the final sentence and therefore chose at once to disagree with its tone, said, "And what do you imagine insufficient income does to a widow's nerve? It makes her hear rain as prophecy."

Maryam folded the note again. "I will go after luncheon."

Amina nodded as if she had settled the matter herself. "Then eat first. People who go to other people's disasters on tea alone return with headaches and self-pity."

The morning resumed the ordinary injured rhythm of a household returning from public sorrow to private repair. Amina counted spoons and found one still missing. The condolence mats were rolled and tied. Maryam's mother

came down in a wrapper of mauve silk and faint resentment and announced that grief sat not only in the heart but in the nerves. Aunt Widad declared that sympathy had impoverished the pantry. By half past eleven the house had resumed its usual family argument over what had been consumed and which relative had gone home with the better umbrella.

"Hanna should not spend the whole day on other people's roofs and rent," her mother said. "Your uncle has not been dead two days."

"Huda is not other people," said Aunt Widad.

"She may be his sister, but the flat and its papers concern this house directly."

Maryam said nothing. Her mother loved rank because it arranged the world into concentric duties with herself at the centre of the nearest one. Hanna's sister, married years before into a less comfortable life and widowed within it, had never fit neatly into those circles. She was family, but not central family; pitiable, but not convenient. Maryam knew this and was ashamed by how much of it she had absorbed.

She left after one, walking because the distance did not justify a car and because the city, for the moment, still offered the illusion of ordinary passage. The streets between their house and Huda's quarter altered less by architecture than by means. In Qatamon the fronts still held. Even houses falling into gentler decline managed curtains, polished knockers, the fiction that disorder had chosen not to enter. By the time Maryam reached the narrower street where Huda lived, the fiction had thinned. Laundry crossed above the lane. A basket of cabbages stood outside a greengrocer's as if the world could still be negotiated through vegetables and weighing scales. Two little boys threw bottle caps against a wall marked with old damp.

Huda's building was not poor, exactly. It was a building that had resigned itself before its inhabitants did. The stair smelled of soap, onions, and one persistent drain.

Huda opened the door before Maryam had properly knocked, as if she had been listening for the steps. "You came," she said, and then seemed embarrassed by the nakedness of the sentence. "Of course you came. Come in. The kettle has boiled itself stupid twice already."

The room was small and clean and tired. The curtains had been washed so often the pattern had almost left them. The carpet had once been red. A blanket had been folded over the sofa arm not to look poor but to keep it from becoming poorer. On the wall above the back room, a dark stain spread across the plaster with the soft-edged patience of something that had all the time in the world.

Maryam took off her coat and felt the old involuntary tightening in herself, the one she despised. Rooms like this — where every object had to justify its place, where care was visible because want was close enough to bruise it — always exposed something ugly in her. Pity and superiority often shared a wall.

"When did it begin?" she asked.

"After the last rains. First a stain. Then powder falling near Ibrahim's pillow. Then the landlord promising to send a man and sending no one." Huda poured tea into narrow glasses, her hands moving quickly because stillness made her more transparent than she liked. "Hanna came yesterday evening, looked up, and became very quiet."

That was another way of saying he had begun making arrangements.

"Everyone says I should move," Huda said. "Move where? On what money? With what advance rent? Widows are told to move as though we travel like hats."

The sentence pricked Maryam because the thought had crossed her mind. Not as contempt, not even quite as judgement, but as arithmetic. Huda saw enough in her face and said, more gently, "It is not wickedness. It is only that women who have never had to calculate every room think in larger units."

She sat down again and folded her hands around the glass. "Do you know what widowhood is mostly made of? It is not grief, after the first months. Grief becomes part of the

wallpaper. Widowhood is made of being addressed by men who think you are suddenly a bad risk and by women who think you are suddenly available for every weary kindness. 'Come to luncheon.' 'Take my old curtains.' 'Have you considered moving nearer your family?' One becomes public in the most tedious possible way."

From the back room came the sound of Ibrahim reciting something under his breath. Maryam had met the boy at Christmas and forgotten him in the way one forgot children who stood politely in doorways and resembled photographs of their fathers not yet old enough to hurt.

Before Maryam could answer, the door below banged and a man's tread sounded on the stair. Huda set her glass down too quickly. Tea spilled into the saucer.

It was Hanna, carrying the blue file under one arm and Ibrahim at his side. Behind them came Mr Halabi, the landlord — careful beard, careful shoes, the practised respectability of a man who considered his own decency an asset from which others benefited.

"What exactly is the complaint?" he asked before he was properly inside, as though having named it complaint he might reduce its force.

Hanna prevented the argument from becoming circular by putting the blue file on the table and opening it as though the file itself possessed more authority than indignation. He had written the dates on which the porter had been told, the date Huda had spoken to the landlord's wife, the date of visible seepage, the names of the insurer and mason, and the clause under which repairs affecting habitability could not be indefinitely postponed. He laid the pages out one by one, not for drama but because sequence was his native language.

"You have been busy," said Halabi.

"I dislike repeated conversations when one will do."

There was no heat in Hanna's voice. That was what made it difficult to oppose. Men who raised their voices could be answered with more voice. Men who remained precise in other people's rooms had to be refuted by fact.

"The question," said Halabi, "is security. Your sister pays month to month."
"She pays every month."
"That is not the point."
"It is always the point."
"A widow alone in uncertain times—"
"In uncertain times," Hanna said, "you want more than punctual rent. You want assurance that if she leaves you may still claim something before everyone begins claiming from everyone else."
There it was, not politics exactly, but the edge of the city entering through property and fear. Huda looked down. Halabi said nothing for two seconds too long.
Maryam watched her husband then as if from a slight distance. He did not speak warmly. He did not play the outraged brother. He simply made space around Huda in which the landlord could not crowd her without becoming visibly mean. It was a form of protection too dry to look like one unless one watched closely.
The discussion lasted twenty minutes. A mason would come the next morning. The insurer's surveyor within two days. No increase to the rent before quarter's end. Hanna would receive a copy of the surveyor's report. Halabi wanted it noted that the problem might not have been visible to him earlier. Hanna allowed the phrase visible to him and conceded nothing else.
When the landlord left, Huda remained seated for several seconds as though movement might dissolve the agreement. Then she said, very quietly, "If he had his way, I would have apologised for the ceiling."
"He did not have his way," said Hanna.
He was already gathering the papers back into order. "Move the bed from the wall tonight. And the cabinet."
"I cannot move them alone."
"You are not being asked to."
He and Ibrahim shifted the bed together, scraping wood over tile. The movement exposed a darker run of damp lower down the wall. Huda made a small sound in her throat.

"It looks worse now," she said.
"No," Hanna answered. "It looks visible."
He pulled the cabinet clear as well, then crouched to check the skirting board. In the narrow room his shirt pulled across his shoulders. Ibrahim copied each gesture half a second late, eager to be useful and just old enough not to be sent away. When the bed and cabinet had been moved, Hanna said, "If anything comes down tonight, it will hit the chair."
"That is not comforting," said Huda.
"It is not meant to be. It is a chair."
Ibrahim, who had stood in the doorway throughout with one sock on and the other in his hand, said, "Can I still put my books by the wall?"
"No," said Huda at once.
"You may put them on the chair," Hanna said. "And if the surveyor comes tomorrow, do not improve the story. Tell it as it happened."
The boy nodded solemnly, absorbing this as law. There was, Maryam thought, something almost tender in the way Hanna spoke to boys: not softer than with adults, but more direct, as if he respected in them the possibility of plain instruction being enough.
While Huda was in the kitchen rinsing glasses, Maryam saw the folded receipt tucked under the sugar bowl. She should not have looked. She looked. The school fees had been paid two days earlier in Hanna's hand. Not a great sum. Not a small one either.
Huda came back and saw at once what Maryam had seen. "He should have told you," she said, and then, because honesty was easier in small rooms, added, "No. That is not true. If he had told you, it would have become a conversation. He prefers receipts."
It stung because it was true. Maryam would have turned it into one — not from meanness, perhaps not even from self-defence, but because she had grown too used to reading Hanna's practical loyalty as if it were a climate rather than a series of acts. One did not admire weather. One complained or adapted.

On the walk home she said, "You might have told me."
"About what?"
She gave him the look he deserved.
He went two more steps before answering. "It did not concern you."
"Your sister does not concern me?"
"The fees concerned her and the school. If I told you every sum I settled for every relative, we would never speak of anything else."
It was not quite the truth. But neither was it a lie. His feeling for money was never greedy and never ostentatious. It was structural. A sum paid was a wall kept standing. A fee covered was a future made slightly less damaged.
"She said you left the receipt under the sugar bowl."
He glanced at her briefly. "That was where she would find it."
"And where I would not?"
"If I wanted you not to find it, I would have put it somewhere more imaginative."
There it was again: the irritating accuracy that left no clean place for resentment.
They walked on. A delivery cart passed under canvas. Two girls in school coats shared one umbrella and still found reason to laugh before the corner took them. Farther up, a British jeep stood outside a building while two soldiers smoked with the blank detachment of men to whom every street was temporary. The city maintained its double aspect: ordinary enough to force one to keep buying bread, altered enough that every ordinary thing felt provisional.
At the house they found Aunt Widad and Maryam's mother in the drawing room discussing whether one ought to send proper thanks to those who had attended the burial or whether thanks would make a transaction of grief. Leila was sitting on the bottom stair with Yusef's card pack, building something that might have been a house and might have been a ruin and was, in either case, collapsing.
"Did you bring me something?" she asked at once.
"No," said Maryam.

"Did the ceiling fall?"
"No."
"Then nothing interesting happened."
Amina appeared from the kitchen carrying a spoon she had evidently just found. "One," she said, holding it up. "Under the sideboard. That still leaves three unaccounted for and my faith in the parish permanently reduced."
Hanna set down first the blue file, then Uncle Yusef's packet. Not one before the other. Not with more care for one than the other. That, Maryam thought, was perhaps the truest thing about him: he did not rank claims by sentiment. The widow's ceiling, the boy's fees, the dead man's papers, the cemetery notation, the Armenian's trunks, Leila's stockings, her mother's tea — he moved among them all as though order were the only justice available in a disordered world.
It ought perhaps to have moved her more cleanly than it did. Instead she felt the familiar mixture: gratitude, irritation, admiration, fatigue. No one of them ever arrived alone.
That evening he untied Yusef's packet again. The same papers, the same columns of figures in his hand. He pushed one of the French pages towards her. "This note in the margin — his?"
She leaned over. "His. He is calling the clerk a donkey, but with grammar."
"That may help."
"It never helped him."
He made a small mark in his notes. "No. But it may help us."
On the sideboard Yusef's spectacles still waited. Outside the rain had begun again. The house had gone quiet enough to hear a child being called in from the lane.
Maryam put her hand on the French pages and thought that the work had already changed shape. It was no longer one visit to one flat after one funeral. It had become sequence. Another return. Another packet. Another hour at the table, perhaps with Tariq al-Khatib again at the

desk, translating Yusef's disorder into categories the living could survive.

When she went upstairs later, leaving Hanna at the table with the lamp making a hard yellow island around his hands, she thought — not with bitterness, not even quite with love, but with the clarity fatigue sometimes grants — that some men made themselves indispensable in order not to have to say who they were when they sat still.

She was not sure whether that was accusation or respect. By morning it would not matter which. The papers would still be downstairs. Huda's ceiling would still be damp. The bank would still require proof of the dead. And the work at the flat, if called for, would bring them all back to that table again.

CHAPTER IV

Mrs Farah

By the first Sunday after Uncle Yusef's burial, the house had already begun the indecent work of looking as though it could continue without him.

The condolence mats were gone. The borrowed chairs had been carried back. The rug had been turned the proper way again. The blue vase held flowers because Maryam's mother had said that a house could not remain corrected for grief indefinitely without beginning to resemble neglect, and neglect, in her view, was not sorrow but slovenliness. Only Yusef's spectacles remained on the sideboard because no one had yet agreed whether removing them would count as tidiness or betrayal.

In the five days since his death, the house had settled into a rhythm that was not yet a habit and no longer an interruption. Hanna had been twice more to the flat and once to his sister's rooms. Tariq al-Khatib had come twice, once with better string as Aunt Widad had demanded, once with a municipal form that required two copies, three signatures, and an intelligence no municipality had yet produced. The Armenian's trunks remained where they were. The bank wanted more proof of death than death itself had thought necessary.

Maryam had spent the same week with the vague and irritating sense that the neighbourhood now saw her through a second layer of glass. Not pity; pity had arrived with the first callers. Something smaller and more persistent. A notice taken. An amendment entered in other people's books. One was now the niece of the dead man in the upper flat, the household through which papers moved, the family whose evenings no longer belonged entirely to itself.

On Sunday morning her mother declared that church was indispensable.

"We are not Latins," she said, fastening her brooch. "We do not disappear into private feeling."

Aunt Widad, who had arrived before nine in a hat too old to be respectable and too well brushed to be called shabby, said, "No. We disappear into church coffee and complain of it afterwards. It is our more ancient rite."

Maryam, pinning Leila's collar while the child twisted as though proper clothing were a personal injury, said nothing. Sunday after bereavement required attendance not because faith demanded it but because absence would create its own commentary. In neighbourhoods like theirs, one was seen at church even when one was not looked at. That was the difference between piety and parish life.

Leila said, "Must I come this time?"

"Yes."

"I came for the funeral."

"That was the burial."

"It had church."

"Today also has church."

"Church is repetitive."

"That is one of its points," said Aunt Widad.

The service passed as such services did: not quickly, not slowly, but with the curious collapse of time that happened when words known by heart were spoken over lives one did not yet know how to continue. The familiar phrases did not comfort Maryam; they merely refused to flatter the novelty of her grief. God had heard too many names, too many prayers for the newly dead, to be made dramatic by one more. There was a kind of rough mercy in that impersonality.

Leila spent the first part examining the saints with the suspicious concentration she reserved for painted adults who appeared both important and inaccessible. At one point she whispered, too audibly, "Why do they all look as though they know a secret and do not approve of it?"

"Hush," Maryam murmured.

"Do saints mind children?"

"Not if children mind saints first."

"That seems like a poor arrangement."

Hanna, a little forward among the men, did not turn, but she saw his shoulders shift. He had heard. Whether he was

suppressing amusement or the desire to exercise authority in a building that belonged, for once, to a higher management than his own, she could not tell. With him the two often shared a border.

Maryam found herself looking not at the icon screen but at the backs of heads, at the tilt of Mrs Farah's hat three rows ahead, at the way Father Elias paused before the longer prayer, at the child who had fallen asleep against his grandmother's side, at the hand with which Hanna steadied Leila when the child swayed from boredom and then removed his hand at once as though even protection should not become conspicuous. She thought, not for the first time, that parish life trained the body in humility and the mind in surveillance. One knelt, crossed oneself, accepted the kiss of peace, all while seeing who had come late, whose daughter had changed her hat, which widow had stopped wearing her ring too soon, which family now occupied the pew where the Jiryeses had once sat before leaving for Beirut and calling it temporary.

Outside, after the final blessing, the courtyard became what it always became on Sundays: a market of manners. One could not cross from the door to the gate in a straight line without consenting to seem monstrous. Women arranged themselves into clusters according to kinship, appetite, and old grievances. Men formed looser groups, as though politics, business, and municipal complaints all belonged to one large masculine subject from which women were regrettably excluded.

Three women stopped Maryam within as many yards. None asked directly about Yusef. One asked after her mother's nerves. Another after Leila's sleep. A third wanted to know whether the cemetery matter had settled itself, as though such things naturally did if left in sufficient proximity to priests.

Mrs Farah approached not like an enemy but like weather. There was nothing in her manner to justify offence. She simply moved through other people's lives with an attention that made privacy feel self-indulgent. She wore dark silk and a spray of violets pinned a little too close to

her shoulder and carried a small prayer book she had almost certainly not opened again after leaving the pew.
"My dear," she said to Maryam's mother, and then to Aunt Widad, "Thursday was very well done. So many people. One could see he was cherished, whatever one says about difficult men."
"He had his qualities," said Aunt Widad.
"And his papers, apparently," said Mrs Farah lightly. "You are fortunate that that translator gentleman has been so useful. He seems almost one of the family already."
Maryam was near enough to hear and far enough to pretend she had not. She bent towards Leila, who was trying to determine whether the widow Elias's handbag might contain sweets. Mrs Farah continued, still in the same harmless tone.
"I saw him leaving rather late one evening. Poor Amina was still carrying tea at dusk. It is a mercy when competent help appears at the proper time."
There it was. No accusation. No sharpened pause. Nothing except observation in the same register one might use to note that the Karabets had repainted their shutters or that the butcher's new apprentice was clumsy with string. That was what made it land. Warning implied danger. Observation implied record.
Maryam kept her face still. Her mother made the small sound she made when a truth and a displeasure arrived together. Aunt Widad said, "He is exact."
"Exactness is a blessing in men and a burden in women," said Mrs Farah. "That is how one knows God was in a complicated mood when He made us."
Two women laughed. Mrs Farah pressed one more condolence into the conversation, touched Maryam's sleeve with fingers always cooler than the weather required, and moved on towards another cluster.
Only after she had gone did Aunt Widad say, in a tone pitched just inside humour, "You see? We have discovered competence and now the quarter will never let us forget it."
Maryam kept her eyes on Leila, who had finished investigating the widow Elias's handbag and was now

rubbing sugar from the sweet she had found onto the rail of the church steps with devotional concentration. She wiped the rail with her glove, more sharply than the action required.

A little later, when her mother had been manoeuvred as far as the gate and Aunt Widad had been captured by someone else's difficulty, Maryam heard her name in a voice she liked before she fully recognised it.

Nawal Khoury stood just beyond the church wall in a hat that would have looked too jaunty on another woman and on Nawal looked merely like a refusal to surrender entirely to widowhood, or whatever half-condition she now occupied between widow, sister, aunt, and independent nuisance. She was perhaps ten years older than Maryam and had the sort of face on which fatigue turned first into candour rather than complaint.

"You are impossible to catch," Nawal said. "I had to wait until God had had His portion of you."

Maryam kissed her lightly. "You were away Thursday."

"My cousin's boy had a fever, and his mother received it as a personal attack from heaven." Nawal looked at her properly then. "How are you?"

There was something about the way Nawal asked ordinary questions that made ordinary answers impossible. Not because she demanded honesty theatrically. Because she had the irritating gift of hearing arrangement inside arranged sentences.

"Tired," Maryam said.

"Good. Tiredness is at least true."

They moved aside to let two men pass. Nawal's gloves were old and beautifully kept. The seam on the right thumb had been repaired so carefully it looked original until one saw it.

"I kept meaning to come yesterday," she said, "but my sister insisted on feeding every relation she possesses and three she does not. One should never allow bad timing to marry family duty. They produce whole litters of obligation."

Maryam smiled. She always smiled more easily with Nawal than with women who asked less effort of her. Perhaps because Nawal did not present herself as a moral success.
"I am at the Semiramis for another week at least," Nawal went on. "Aunt Salma has taken rooms there while her brother's people from Jaffa decide whether property papers are still a form of reality or only of hope. She dislikes hotels, hotel food, hotel widows, and me. Come one afternoon and save us both."
"You are staying there?"
"Do not sound as if I have joined a touring company. Simply come. Around four. Before supper and before Aunt Salma begins explaining why girls who read novels lose whatever small chance they had of good judgement."
Years earlier, after Leila's birth, when half the women Maryam knew had descended on her room carrying broth, advice, and improved versions of pity, Nawal alone had said, "You look as though everyone has been congratulating you into exhaustion," and then removed two over-scented bouquets without asking because the child had begun sneezing. Maryam had loved her a little for that and mistrusted herself for loving anyone on such practical grounds.
"I will come," Maryam said, and meant it in the clean uncomplicated way one meant a thing still far enough away not to require moral force.
"Good," said Nawal. "If you delay, I shall count it as vanity and not misfortune."
"That is an unkind way to secure a visit."
"It is an efficient one."
Leila appeared at Maryam's side as if conjured. "Who is she?"
"This is Mrs Khoury."
"I know that. Who is she really?"
Nawal laughed, not loudly but with genuine pleasure. "A scandalous woman with an excellent jam cupboard."
"What makes you scandalous?" Leila asked.
"Persistence," said Nawal.
"That does not sound scandalous."

"No. That is why it works."
From the gate her mother signalled. "Wednesday or Thursday," Nawal said. "Before you vanish into papers again."
"I will come."
"Come before dusk if you can. My sister becomes virtuous after dark and impossible before supper."
On the walk home, with her mother in front and Aunt Widad beside them recounting how Mrs Farah's daughter had once nearly lost an engagement through nothing worse than badly timed honesty, the remark returned to Maryam not as insult but as enclosure. The translator gentleman. Almost one of the family already. Amina carrying tea at dusk. Nothing false in any of it. Nothing one could publicly resent. The neighbourhood had simply recorded what it saw, and the record, once entered, did not require malice to do its work.
Her mother said nothing about it on the walk. That was worse. Silence in her never meant the subject was closed. It meant the subject had been filed for better conditions.
At luncheon the conditions arrived. Hanna had joined them after speaking with Father Elias by the gate. He ate as he always did in working weeks: with the concentration of a man to whom food was fuel. Her mother waited until the lentils were served, then said, with the precision of someone who had rehearsed the approach during the entire walk home and the better part of one sherry, "He should not remain there in the evening."
Hanna did not look up. "Who?"
"The translator gentleman. Mrs Farah saw him leaving after seven."
"He was there because the municipal copy arrived after office hours."
"Municipal copies do not improve by moonlight."
Aunt Widad set down her fork. "The point is simple. The work remains necessary. The hour requires managing."
Hanna nodded once. "Then I will manage the hour."

It was not indignation. Not defence. Merely acceptance that a new fact had entered the problem and therefore procedure would alter.
"What does that mean?" her mother asked.
"It means I will not ask him to stay late. If copying must be done after school, it can be done at the stationer's rather than at the flat."
"That is better," her mother said, in the tone of a woman to whom better and pleasant had always been dangerously conflated.
Maryam said nothing. The trouble with her mother was that she could occasionally be right for reasons too mean to endorse and too accurate to dismiss. There was no impropriety in Tariq's work at the flat. There was only the fact of being seen. In places like theirs, one did not wait for impropriety itself. One managed in anticipation of the commentary that might gather around it.
Amina, carrying away the first emptied dish, said under her breath as she passed Maryam, "So now paper will go out walking instead of staying in its proper room."
Maryam should have corrected her. Instead she said, equally low, "Apparently."
The afternoon dissolved into its separate domains. Her mother rested. Aunt Widad went home. Leila built and demolished card houses on the drawing-room carpet until Amina removed her upstairs with a firmness that required no second attempt. Hanna remained at the dining table with Yusef's packet and one lamp lit, making notes in his narrow hand and once or twice reaching for the spectacles on the sideboard as if proximity to the dead man's lenses might improve the legibility of the living problem.
Maryam sat with a mending basket she did not need and did not mend. She sorted handkerchiefs into one pile and socks into another and then looked for a long time at the socks as though classification might improve them. The neighbourhood beyond the shutters resumed its ordinary Sunday sounds: a radio somewhere too loud, boys being called in before supper, a door closing, another opening, a dog objecting to the existence of bicycles. Ordinary life.

That was the phrase everyone used for the thing they were losing without yet admitting it. One clung to it — the phrase and the life — as if both might be preserved by repetition.

After a while Hanna said, without looking up, "Will you go to Mrs Khoury this week?"

"Nawal. Yes."

"Which day?"

"I said Wednesday or Thursday."

"Then choose one before Wednesday becomes Thursday and neither becomes anything."

It was exactly the sort of sentence that would have sounded oppressive from another man and from Hanna emerged merely as the practical translation of time. Yet it irritated her because it was true, and because Nawal's invitation, which had felt so easy to accept under the church wall, already had to pass through the machinery of other obligations before it could become real.

"Wednesday," she said.

He nodded as though a form had been properly completed.

That evening, after Leila had surrendered her cards and her indignation and been carried upstairs by Hanna with the same practical steadiness he brought to every small body and large problem, Maryam stood for a moment at the dining-room window while he bent over Yusef's packet at the table behind her. Outside, the rain had begun again. The neighbourhood was shutting itself down in the usual way: a radio silenced, a shutter drawn, someone calling a child in from the lane. Ordinary life closing its books for the night.

She thought of Mrs Farah's cool fingers on her sleeve. Of the phrase almost one of the family spoken in the same tone one might use to note that a shutter had been repainted. Of her mother's silence on the walk home, which was never silence but only patience in better clothes. Of Aunt Widad saying at luncheon, as if it were merely practical: the hour requires managing.

And of Nawal, touching her wrist in the church yard, saying come before you vanish.

Wednesday. She meant it. That was always the trouble with failures of attention. One usually meant them until something smaller and more immediate took the place where intention had been.

CHAPTER V

Papers and Pretexts

On Monday morning the house resumed itself with an indecency that would have offended Maryam less if it had not been so necessary.

The condolence mats were gone. The borrowed chairs had been returned. The blue vase held flowers again because her mother had said a house could not remain arranged for grief indefinitely without beginning to resemble neglect. Only Yusef's spectacles remained on the sideboard, because no one could decide whether removing them would count as tidiness or betrayal.

The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was domestic. One went back to breakfast.

Leila refused egg on the principle that mourning had already imposed enough discipline without further assistance from poultry. Amina put the plate in front of her again. Her mother, still in her wrapper, said that children heard too much when left at table after nine. Aunt Widad, who had arrived before breakfast carrying her handbag of papers, receipts, and emergency notions, replied that people heard too little everywhere else.

Hanna came in with Yusef's leather case under one arm and two tied packets under the other. He set them beside the marmalade as if paper had every right to breakfast.

"These need copying," he said. "One set for the municipality, one for the bank, and one in case either of them develops a taste for repetition."

Her mother looked at the packets as if they had been placed there specifically to affront her. "Must they sit beside the food?"

"They must go somewhere."

"Not beside the marmalade."

"Then after the marmalade."

He untied the upper packet. Maryam saw the municipal form, one of Yusef's receipts, two English letters from the bank, and the typed French pages regarding the lower

room's water damage. The papers had already begun to lose their first shock and acquire instead the exhausted familiarity of an illness one had accepted would not depart merely because one was bored of it.
"Habib will make the copies," Hanna said. "On Jaffa Road."
Her mother put down her spoon. "Why Habib?"
"Because Habib has a machine and carbon paper, and because after yesterday's useful conversation it seems better that copying be done there rather than at the flat after school."
He said it without edge. That was perhaps what most infuriated people when Hanna was right. He made no performance of victory. He merely altered procedure.
"And who will take them?"
"I must go first to the office and then to Huda's landlord. If I take them, they will sit in my desk until afternoon. Habib said yesterday he could do them by midday if someone brought them before ten." He looked at Maryam. "You can leave them and collect them later."
The sentence sounded simple enough.
"If you are going into town," her mother said at once, "bring back black ribbon. The better kind. And if Habib has mourning envelopes still, two packets."
"I am going for copies, not supplies."
"That is how errands become suspect. They return empty-handed and call it purpose."
Leila said, "Bring me a slate pencil."
"You have two."
"One is short and the other is unjust."
Amina set down the toast rack. "If ladies are making lists, add hooks for the blue dress in the upstairs cupboard. It is hanging by one shoulder like a sinner."
Maryam might have objected. She did not. The packet on the table had already begun attracting cover to itself. Ribbon, envelopes, a slate pencil, hooks. One errand now contained four, which was perhaps what made it respectable. None of them was false. Together they formed a screen.

Hanna retied the string. "Ask for Habib himself. Not the boy with the blotched chin. He charges for mistakes twice."
"Why does everyone in this city answer to the wrong boy first?" Aunt Widad said.
"Because the right man is usually at the back pretending not to listen," said Amina.
Maryam smiled despite herself. Because it had come too easily she lowered her eyes at once to hide it. She was still the niece of the dead man in the upper flat, still the woman whose household had been entered in the quarter's record by Mrs Farah's mild observation. One could not go smiling into Jaffa Road on a Monday morning as though paper and absence had become diverting.
After breakfast Hanna put on his hat in the hall. "When you collect the copies, count them there," he said. "Do not trust bundles tied by any man whose ink gets under his nails."
He left. Amina, already tying her scarf because she meant to go out for lentils, handed Maryam the better umbrella.
"It is not raining," Maryam said.
"It has not yet decided."
Then, lowering her voice: "If paper is going walking, it may as well come home carrying groceries."
"Apparently that is the family doctrine."
"It is not doctrine," said Amina. "It is camouflage."
The word landed too squarely to be comfortable. Before Maryam could answer, Amina was already on the step, pulling her scarf tighter against a wind that had not quite decided whether it belonged to autumn or something harsher.
Jaffa Road was not far enough to justify a car and too far to feel like a household errand only. One had to enter the city for it. That was perhaps why Maryam felt the mild unease proper to any excursion beyond purely domestic boundaries. Not fear. Something smaller and more social. The knowledge that one might be seen by people who did not know why one was there and would therefore improve the reason for themselves.

The morning had not yet settled into heat. Shop shutters were being raised. The tram bell clanged with the impatience of a governess. A boy pushed a handcart of copybooks towards the school quarter. Two British soldiers stood outside a post office smoking with the boredom of men placed in a country too long. At the baker's a woman in a green coat argued over change with such conviction that one might have thought sovereignty hung on the coppers. Men spoke at corners in clusters that looked casual until one noticed how they did not disperse when no transaction required it.

This was what the city had become: ordinary business conducted with a layer of unnecessary attention laid over it like varnish. One still bought bread. One still walked to stationers and offices. One simply did it all as if other eyes had acquired rights in the matter.

Habib's shop stood between a bookseller and a man who repaired fountain pens while pretending to despise anyone who used them. In the window were exercise books, cheap envelopes, black sealing wax, two bottles of violet ink, and a framed certificate from some British supply company that had yellowed without losing its self-importance. Above the door, the sign announced Stationery and Copying in Arabic and English, though time and rain had made the English look doubtful of itself.

Inside, the place smelled of paper, dust, glue, and the metallic heat of the copying machine. Habib himself stood at the counter with a loupe in one eye and a pen behind his ear, smaller than Maryam remembered from schooldays and more irritated-looking. Beside him an apprentice folded foolscap as if each sheet had insulted his mother.

Maryam laid the order note and packet on the counter. "My husband sent these."

Habib took the note first, not the packet. "Ah. Hanna Bey. Death, certificates, municipal copies. A profitable sorrow."

The apprentice looked alarmed. Habib ignored him.

"Will it be by noon?" Maryam asked.

"If the machine behaves. If it does not, by one. If the electricity chooses patriotism rather than function, by two."
He weighed the packet in his hand. "Mr al-Khatib?"
"He is coming."
"He always comes with too much exactness for my liking and too little tolerance for my nephew's hands."
He disappeared behind the curtain with Yusef's papers. The machine's clicking changed, became angrier, and then steadied.
Maryam stood at the side shelf with mourning envelopes in hand and pretended to compare the weight of paper. Two schoolgirls came in for copybooks, speaking in English because the school morning had not yet released them into their first language. A clerk from the Patriarchate arrived with a ledger and left muttering that no one in authority ever read the second copy. The apprentice licked his finger to separate stamps, failed, and licked it again with hopeless persistence.
When the door opened again, she knew before seeing him that it would be Tariq.
He came in without haste, a satchel under one arm and two rolled forms in hand. He wore the same dark coat as at the flat, though with a different shirt, and he had not yet shed the expression of school from his face — the concentration of a man who had spent the morning persuading other people to submit to grammar. He took off his hat when he saw her and paused just long enough for the surprise to register and be mastered.
"I did not know you would be here," he said.
"Neither did I," she answered.
That was true enough to serve.
He set his own forms on the counter. "Habib?"
"In mechanical distress."
"That is his natural habitat."
There was no space in the shop for a conversation that could admit itself. Every sentence had to fit alongside ledgers, schoolboys, and the possibility of interruption.

Oddly, that made speech easier. One did not have to mean more than one said. One merely had to say it exactly.

Habib emerged with one copied sheet held to the light. "The machine has developed religious scruples. Half the stamp disappears in the second copy."

Tariq took the page. "Stamp the first copy and note by hand on the second that the original bore the full seal."

"And when the municipality objects?"

"The municipality will object whether the stamp is whole or pious."

Habib considered this. "You spent too much time among children."

"It has made me empirical."

The sheet went back through the curtain. Habib returned with the parish receipt. "This will be one copy."

"Two," said Maryam, surprising herself. "If one is lost, I will not come back here to grieve over paper."

Tariq looked at her properly then. Not long. Long enough. "Two," he said.

Habib, already writing the number in his book, gave no sign of having witnessed a correction. That was perhaps his greatest professional gift. He treated every customer's self-possession as part of the goods.

While the French pages were copied upstairs, Tariq worked through the insurance sheet at the counter. He unfolded it and laid a finger at the margin.

"Water damage from the ceiling in your uncle's back room," he said. "He had written three letters, none answered. This acknowledgment proves only that someone received the complaint."

"Is that enough?"

"It is more than complaint alone. Less than remedy."

"Which is the natural relation between the two."

His mouth moved at that. Not quite a smile. Not the absence of one either.

She leaned closer to read the English line. The insurance clerk's hand was thin and self-important. Below it, on the French page, Yusef had added a marginal note so sour that even Maryam could recognise its contempt.

"Did you tell Habib to copy even the insult?"
"No. Your husband did. Or rather he instructed that the French pages be copied exactly, which in a man like your uncle includes insult as naturally as punctuation."
"Hanna is very faithful to documents."
"He is faithful to consequences."
That was perhaps the most exact sentence anyone had yet spoken about Hanna in her hearing. It irritated her because it carried both respect and limit without false generosity.
"You say that as though faithfulness to consequences were a species of deficiency."
Tariq folded the page. "No. Only as a species."
A customer entered just then, sparing them any need to answer the answer. The apprentice knocked over a jar of nibs. Habib closed his eyes.
"One day I shall replace every boy in this city with a better table."
"No," said Tariq. "The table would only ask for wages."
Maryam looked away because laughter in a stationer's, like truth in a parlour, carried farther than one intended.
When the French pages came down at last, Habib inspected them, corrected one misplaced accent himself, and stacked the copies with the originals. "All exact. The insult reproduced with respect."
She paid for the copying, ribbon, envelopes, hooks, and the slate pencil that waited best. Tariq paid for exercise books and ink separately. The division, conducted so cleanly in public, seemed itself part of the thing that could not be named. Not intimacy. Not distance. A competence in not obliging one another falsely.
He picked up one of the school copybooks. On the cover was the old line about duty, discipline, and national improvement.
"The Ministry still uses this?" he asked Habib.
"The Ministry uses whatever was printed before it lost its courage."
Maryam took the copybook from his hand. "National improvement through this paper?"

"Perhaps the nation is being held back by poor margins," he said.

Their eyes met then, not because either meant them to but because the sentence had landed between them fully formed and neither could pretend it had not.

She set the copybook down first.

Outside, the pavement was momentarily blocked by a wagon unloading tins. For a few seconds they stood near the shop door watching the negotiation of commerce and obstruction.

"This is an improvement on dusk," Tariq said.

It took her a second to understand he meant the new geography of the papers.

"Yes," she said. "Though it leaves less room for error."

"Public rooms do that."

"And private ones do not?"

He looked at the wagon, not at her. "Private rooms permit invention. Public rooms permit only reputation."

The sentence was too exact to answer lightly. Before she could attempt it, Habib's nephew called that the way was clear, and the moment was forced forward into movement.

"You are returning home?" Tariq asked at the corner.

"Yes."

He hesitated just enough to make the hesitation visible and not enough to require comment. "The post box is two doors down. If you mean to send anything."

She had Nadia's reply still unwritten. He could not know that. The usefulness of the sentence lay precisely in its uselessness. It was public talk. It could not be misunderstood without someone first deciding to misunderstand it.

"I mean to buy stamps first," she said.

"That is the city's way of reminding us that affection requires licensing."

She laughed softly, and he did not look at her long enough for the laugh to feel kept. He inclined his head and went back towards the school quarter with his forms under his arm.

At home her mother asked whether the copies were complete. Amina asked whether the blotched boy had survived. Leila asked whether the translator gentleman had laughed. Maryam answered the first, gave the second enough shape to satisfy the kitchen, and ignored the third. Only after luncheon, when Hanna had gone back to the office with the bank letter and one municipal copy, did Nadia's letter find her alone.

It lay on her dressing table beneath the silver-backed brush, thinner and bluer than the house's own paper. Nadia had always preferred stationery that made itself visible across a room, as if correspondence ought to enter dramatically to compensate for what life denied it.

Maryam sat on the edge of the bed and opened it with the hairpin already in her hand.

Beirut, Nadia wrote, had turned out to be exactly as everyone had promised and not at all as anyone had meant. The flat was smaller than the word flat ought decently to cover. The coffee in the first week had been weak enough to imply a moral defect in the landlord's family. Her husband's cousin, with whom they were staying until matters settled, possessed the touching and destructive belief that any room containing more than two chairs naturally wished to host company. One could still buy proper apricots if one knew which man to flatter and which to ignore. Everywhere there was talk of who had come, who had not yet come, who had come only for a fortnight, and who was already pretending the fortnight had meant something longer.

If matters become too unpleasant, come at once, Nadia wrote. There is no room, naturally, but room is a concept on which civilisation places excessive emphasis. We will stack one another artistically and call it temporary. Everything is temporary. Beirut is tiresome but civilised, which at present feels like praise. Bring papers first and silver second. Leave sentimental objects to those with larger luggage and weaker sense.

The tone was brisk, managerial, faintly pleased with its own resilience, and beneath all that something else

Maryam did not yet want to name. Nadia had always made discomfort sound like anecdote until the anecdote revealed, by accident, the shape beneath it. Even now there were slips in the gaiety: a line about children underfoot written too sharply, a remark about borrowed rooms that had not quite disguised the humiliation of dependence, a small gap before the sentence insisting everything was temporary.

Maryam read the letter twice and then looked through the window at the Abu-Rashids' washing line, where one white sheet and three little vests moved in thin wind. Beirut. Papers first and silver second. Come at once if matters become too unpleasant, though of course they probably would not. The thought of going seemed at once impossible and available in the false way hotel brochures made elsewhere available: not real enough to choose, only real enough to imagine.

She answered at once because that was what one did with the first letter from elsewhere. One did not leave it. She wrote that they had had a death in the family and the house had been full beyond patience. She wrote that Leila was well, Hanna overworked, her mother grand in grief, Aunt Widad more useful than any government office, which would have offended Aunt Widad and therefore made it true. She wrote that Jerusalem remained itself in most outward ways, that the quarter was still full of women who mistook observation for charity and men who mistook paper for power, that there was no need yet to think of artistic stacking in borrowed rooms. She asked after the weak coffee, the cousin, the apricots, the children overhead. She signed with more warmth than she had felt while reading and sealed the letter before warmth could thin under revision.

Only then did she realise she had written there is no need yet where once she might have written simply there is no need. The small adverb seemed to have entered the sentence without permission. She disliked it enough to consider opening the letter and writing the whole thing

again. She did not. That would have been theatre for an audience of one.

Late in the afternoon, after Hanna had gone back to the office and Aunt Widad had left carrying half the shelled peas because she claimed shelling in one district and cooking in another saved money and kept the mind from politics, Maryam walked up to the flat because Hanna had asked her to bring back the blue account book before evening.

The room was emptier by almost nothing and different by more than that. One chair had been moved to the wall. Two bundles were gone from the round table. The cat was asleep on the bed as if ownerlessness had already taught it the geography of advantage. On the desk lay one blotter, one penknife, and a page in Yusef's hand beginning, as so many of his notes did, with a grievance against a man whose name he had reduced to initials as if even in anger the full identity bored him. At the end he had written in a slant steeper than the rest: They mistake delay for power because they have never had work worth doing.

Maryam sat in his chair and looked at the sentence longer than it deserved. It sounded like him. It sounded also like something the city itself might have written if the city kept a notebook and no fear of libel.

She found the blue account book where Hanna had said it would be, beneath the municipal notices and beside the tin of receipts. As she tied the string again she realised, with some annoyance, that she was now looking at the room partly through Tariq's categories: source, pressure, what mattered first, what could wait, what truth irritation had accidentally preserved. It seemed an intrusion of a particularly elegant kind and therefore harder to resist.

At supper her mother asked whether Nadia sounded comfortable or merely brave. Aunt Widad asked what cousins in Beirut ate and whether landlords there were Levantine or French. Hanna, late again, asked only for the copied packet.

"And?" her mother said, because answers were not answers until shaped for table use.

"She says Beirut is cramped and civilised," Maryam said.
"That sounds worse than Jerusalem," said Aunt Widad.
"It sounds like Beirut," said Hanna, already checking the pages.
"Her advice?" asked Aunt Widad.
"Papers first and silver second."
Her mother looked offended. "Silver? Who takes silver in a crisis?"
"People with silver," said Aunt Widad.
"There is no crisis."
"There is always a crisis somewhere," said Aunt Widad. "The question is whether it has yet learned your address."
Her mother said, "Wednesday, Maryam."
"What about Wednesday?"
"Mrs Khoury. If you are going, go."
"Nawal," Maryam said, because Hanna had looked up. "Her aunt has taken rooms at the Semiramis."
"Which day?"
"Wednesday."
Hanna nodded as though a form had been properly completed. "Then go before dusk."
"Why before dusk?"
"Because after dusk your mother will worry, and before dusk you may still return to this house as though it is a house rather than a public institution."
"That is not a romantic reason."
"It is not meant to be."
That evening, after the lamps were lit and the house had settled into weekday quiet, Maryam addressed Nadia's envelope and placed it on the hall table so it would not be forgotten in the morning. Then she stood with her hand on the wood and realised she was thinking not of Beirut, nor of weak coffee, nor of Wednesday with Nawal, but of noon at Habib's and the fact that a sentence about paper margins and nations had made her feel, for an instant, less alone in her own exactness.
That was absurd. It was also true.
Upstairs Leila called for water. In the drawing room her mother coughed in the manner that announced

dissatisfaction rather than illness. Amina put away the last cup. Life resumed its innumerable small demands, all of them innocent one by one.

Maryam moved Nadia's letter half an inch straighter on the hall table and thought of Wednesday and of tomorrow, when there would likely be another errand, another packet, another hour shaped by house, flat, street, paper, and the exact man moving between them. The two future claims sat side by side in her mind, equally manageable, equally ordinary.

CHAPTER VI

The Radio

By the end of November, Uncle Yusef's papers had ceased to behave like grief and begun behaving like work.

This was in some ways a relief and in some ways an insult. During the first weeks after a death, disorder could still borrow a little dignity from feeling. A pair of spectacles left on the sideboard might be called tenderness. A packet of receipts on the dining table might be called continuation. By the time autumn had hardened towards winter, however, the same spectacles had become something people dusted round, and the receipts had begun travelling from flat to stationer's, from stationer's to house, from house back to office, gathering stamps, annotations, and the exhausted familiarity of a problem no longer dramatic enough to excuse itself.

The leather case lived more often on the dining table now than in the sideboard. The Armenian had removed his trunks after two more receipts and one more objection. The bank still required proof of death from men who were clearly incapable of appearing in person. The water-damage dispute in the lower room had multiplied into a second clerk and a blue-ribboned file. Tariq al-Khatib had, by degrees, become one of those names spoken in the house without preliminaries. He was no longer the translator gentleman except in her mother's more brittle moods. He was simply Tariq, which was not intimacy, only usage. Still, names altered by usage. So did rooms.

After Mrs Farah's remark, Hanna had done exactly what he said he would do. Work that might once have stretched untidily into dusk at Uncle Yusef's flat now found its way, by bundles and pretexts, into public rooms: Habib's counter, the school office, the dining table beneath the lamp. No one had declared this an arrangement. It had become one all the same. Maryam noticed, and because she noticed, thought more often than she wished about how little in Qatamon required outright prohibition.

Timing altered, doors remained open, one errand acquired another companion, and private life adjusted itself under the weight of other people's eyes.

Maryam had not meant to learn the shape of his routine. She knew, however, that he arrived most often carrying two things at once, because men who worked for themselves learned early that one errand must carry another. She knew his cuffs were mended neatly enough to resist pity. She knew he read papers first by source and only afterwards by subject. She knew his courtesy altered by fractions according to the room: cooler before her mother, drier with Aunt Widad, almost companionable with Hanna when both men were bent over a form too absurd to command full solemnity. None of this constituted intimacy. It was the sort of knowledge repeated work produced. Yet repeated work, she had begun to understand, could insinuate itself more quietly than overt feeling because it asked to be noticed only in useful pieces.

On Wednesday she had gone to the Semiramis because she had said Wednesday and because a promise once made in their quarter acquired a solidity beyond inclination. Nawal was staying with Aunt Salma in rooms that had the compressed, provisional air of lives not yet willing to call themselves displaced. The visit had been good — good in the way Nawal was good, which meant too perceptive to be entirely comfortable. She had asked about the quarter, about Mrs Farah's remark, and then, with the infuriating plainness that made evasion childish, about him. Maryam had said he was useful. Nawal had said one did not wear gloves like that for accountants. At the door she had said something that stayed: if the quarter has begun talking, that matters; if you have begun thinking, that matters more. Those are different dangers. Maryam had thought about the sentence on the walk home, and then again before bed, and then had stopped thinking about it because thinking about it was itself the proof Nawal had been right.

On the last Saturday of November the air had the cold exactness Jerusalem sometimes produced without warning, as if the stone itself had cooled overnight and were now returning its judgement to anyone foolish enough to touch a railing bare-handed.

Leila, looking out into the pale street before breakfast, announced that the day resembled a doctor.

"Why a doctor?" Maryam asked.

"Because it looks clean and unfriendly."

Amina, carrying tea into the dining room, said, "That is better than most doctors I have met. Drink before it becomes unfriendly as well."

The house was not at ease, though there was no obvious reason a stranger might have named. Saturday had been intended for account books, mending, and perhaps the last box from Uncle Yusef's wardrobe, which Aunt Widad had declared must contain either tax papers or moral compromise because no bachelor kept a locked box for innocent reasons. Instead there was a waiting in the air that moved ahead of explanation. Men had stood longer at corners the evening before. The butcher's boy had carried gossip with his meat and been told twice to shut his mouth. Her mother had gone to bed saying only that America ought not to be trusted with maps because Americans named places after themselves and then expected gratitude.

At breakfast Hanna ate quickly and without comment until the tea had been poured, Leila had rejected one egg on the grounds that sadness had already demanded too much sacrifice from children, and her mother had asked whether Aunt Widad intended to sit all morning over the account book like a tax collector at the gates of hell.

Only then did he say, "The vote is today."

Her mother looked up. "Which vote?"

"The United Nations."

Aunt Widad, shelling peas into a bowl because no serious conversation in her hands ever remained unaccompanied by some lesser form of order, said, "So the gentlemen in New York are awake at last."

"What time?" Maryam asked.
"Not yet. This afternoon perhaps. But the reports will come in fragments first." He glanced towards the drawing room. "We should keep the wireless on."
Her mother made a small dismissive sound. "I dislike hearing foreign men divide cities they could not find on foot."
"You may dislike it more if others hear first," said Hanna.
This was one of his more useful gifts, Maryam thought: he rarely argued with an opinion when the practical consequence of it could be made to do the work instead.
Leila said, "Who is being divided?"
"No one," her mother answered too quickly.
"Then why is everyone talking as if they are cutting a cake?"
Amina put another piece of bread on the table and said, "Because grown people discuss disaster best when it sounds like luncheon."
The wireless had to be coaxed into cooperation. Hanna carried it from the side room to the drawing room because the plug there behaved more faithfully. Its wooden case had a scratch from the year Leila had tried to see whether saints could hear the BBC if the dial was turned hard enough. For some time it produced only static, then the tail end of a dance band, then static again, and finally a voice in Arabic so smooth and self-assured that Maryam mistrusted it before it had delivered anything at all. The room arranged itself around the set with the awkwardness of people pretending not to concede its authority.
Her mother remained in the high-backed chair with her hands folded over a handkerchief she was not using. Aunt Widad took the edge of the sofa, still shelling peas into her apron because a hand once set to work would not surrender itself to politics. Leila was placed on the rug with copybooks on the strict condition that she ask no questions while the announcer spoke, a condition she violated within three minutes and then continued violating with enough regularity that it ceased to be scandalous and became simply part of the room's rhythm. Only Amina moved as

usual. She laid out cups, fetched bread, opened and shut doors, and let the wireless speak over her shoulder as though foreign men dividing cities were one more domestic inconvenience, no more dignified than milk boiling over.

The first reports came as reports often did then: incomplete, already shaped by the tone in which they were delivered, and accompanied by opinions too finished to have been formed by facts. The announcer spoke of speeches, proposals, abstentions, numbers. He used the phrase international administration, which made her mother close her eyes. He used the phrase partition, which made Aunt Widad stop shelling peas for the first time in twenty minutes. He used the phrase Jerusalem to be placed under a special regime, which meant less than it should have and more than anyone liked.

"Special to whom?" her mother asked the room.

"Men who do not live here," said Aunt Widad.

Hanna said, "It is only paper yet."

"And paper never becomes anything?" her mother asked.

"Paper becomes trouble when men decide to carry it."

When Tariq arrived he did so at an hour that made him seem both exactly appropriate and socially awkward. He had, Hanna said at once, brought back the corrected municipal copy and the reply from the bank clerk whose nephew he knew through the school. This explanation, furnished before Maryam had even stood, was another of Hanna's forms of care: he always noticed when a room required a reason laid down in advance.

Tariq removed his hat in the hall, greeted her mother and Aunt Widad with the level courtesy Maryam had by now come to recognise in him, and paused when the wireless voice named another vote total. He had not yet sat down. For a second he seemed uncertain whether decency required him to leave the papers, promise to return later, and withdraw from the family's private listening. Then Hanna said, "Stay. The numbers are changing every five minutes. We may as well have witnesses."

So he stayed.

Maryam thought, with annoyance at herself, that she had become aware of his physical presence before he had fully entered the room. Not in any vulgar way. Merely as one became aware of a second exact clock in a room already governed by a first. He wore the same dark coat as on working days and carried under one arm a packet tied with the kind of competent string Aunt Widad respected instinctively. There was chalk dust on one cuff and a line in his forehead that suggested a morning spent speaking more than he liked.

He sat not in the deepest chair but on the straight-backed one near the writing table, which was exactly what he ought to have done and therefore irritated Maryam slightly for reasons that had nothing to do with chairs.

Hanna and Tariq went first through the bank letter because that was the excuse by which Tariq was present and because practical labour remained the family's preferred method of withstanding abstraction. The bank had now advanced from demanding confirmation of Yusef's death to requiring identification of all interested parties, certified copies, and one phrase Hanna mistrusted because it seemed to leave the bank free to invent further appetite later.

"It says pending satisfactory clarification of beneficial entitlement," Hanna read.

"Which means," said Tariq, "that they have not yet decided what they want but mean to sound as though dissatisfaction is already your fault."

"Is there a polite answer to that?"

"No. There is only a correct one. Politeness encourages further ambiguity in men paid to admire it."

Maryam watched the two men over the paper. Hanna's attention moved in straight lines: phrase, consequence, next phrase, next consequence. Tariq's moved differently, less like accounting and more like pressure being translated from one medium into another until it could be carried without leakage. The distinction was not flattering to either man. It simply existed.

Then the announcer gave the final tally, or what sounded final until it might not be: thirty-three in favour, thirteen against, ten abstentions. The figures fell into the room with the dead certainty of numbers read aloud, which is not the same thing as truth but often behaves like it for the first hours.

Her mother stood. Not dramatically. Simply because sitting through the result had become impossible for her body. "They have voted on our city," she said. "How civilised."

Aunt Widad resumed shelling the peas she had long since finished and then realised it only when her hand closed on nothing. Hanna turned the wireless down but did not switch it off. The room, suddenly quieter, seemed both fuller and less inhabited.

No one said anything large. That, Maryam realised, was how fear first entered houses like theirs. Not through shouting or prophecy, but through an odd deficiency of proportion. People asked after roads, office hours, schools, deliveries, cousinly routes, and whether visiting should now be done earlier in the day. They did not yet ask what would happen if the thing on the wireless refused to remain on the wireless.

Hanna fetched the English-language newspaper and spread it on the dining table, weighing the corners with the salt cellar and Yusef's old paperknife. The map was a stranger's idea of land: blocks of grey, hatching, lines bold where the city itself was not. Even the paper smelt foreign.

"So that is us," Aunt Widad said, pointing not to Qatamon but to the vague patch of central Jerusalem left uncoloured. "Neither fish nor Christian."

"International," said her mother.

"Which means fish with documents."

Hanna traced one margin with a finger. "If this is accurate, the office falls here. The school?"

Tariq leaned over the opposite side of the table. The gesture brought him nearer to Maryam than he had yet stood all day, though the table, the paperknife, the salt cellar, and her mother's suspicion still lay between them in

force. "Here," he said, touching the map. "Or rather here if one believes the line understands roads. The road does not care for the line."

Leila slid off her chair and came to peer under his arm. "Why have they left the middle blank?"

"Because they cannot agree how to colour it," said Aunt Widad.

"Then why not leave the whole thing blank until they learn?"

"Because men are ambitious with pencils," said Amina from the doorway.

"What does it mean in practice for Jerusalem to be under a special regime?" Maryam asked.

Her mother gave a little sound. "You ask as if practice will be consulted."

Tariq did not answer at once. He looked at the map the way he looked at papers before deciding where their lies were most efficiently arranged. "In practice, first, very little. Then rumours. Then permits perhaps. Or committees. Or two authorities each waiting for the other to become real." He glanced at Hanna. "Enough to confuse office hours, which may be the true beginning of history."

"Offices are only one part of it," said Hanna.

"Yes," said Tariq. "Schools, routes, deliveries, men who decide after dark that one neighbourhood is suddenly less reachable than it had been at noon."

Leila touched the paperknife. "If the lines change, do we change schools?"

"No," said Maryam too quickly.

Tariq looked down at the child. "Not because of a line on paper."

"Then because of what?"

He considered before answering, and again Maryam saw the thing in him she had begun, unwillingly, to rely on: he gave children the courtesy of not lying where a lie would require stupidity to sustain. "Because of roads," he said. "And grown people becoming frightened in practical ways."

Luncheon was late and badly paced. The lentils had softened too far. The bread had gone dry at the edges while everyone listened to the wireless. Tariq should probably have left before luncheon, and everyone knew it. Yet a morning spent listening in a family drawing room to the division of Jerusalem had loosened ordinary exits. No one quite knew how to recover the right hour for courtesy. So he stayed.

Meals interrupted by larger matters develop their own obstinacy. No one had much appetite, which meant everyone became exacting about the food itself. These were not complaints exactly. They were the ordinary language by which families like theirs went on speaking when the subject in the room was too large to be named at every turn.

Maryam had noticed by now that conversation sharpened when Tariq was present, not because he dazzled people into wit but because exactness invited its own sort of answer. Her mother became more aphoristic, Aunt Widad drier, Hanna more concise, even Leila more intolerably literal. It was as if his refusal to waste a sentence made everyone else hear the waste in theirs and stiffen against it.

That, too, should have been harmless. It was only luncheon in a troubled city. Yet the room had begun behaving like a room in which extra meanings were collecting at the edges of ordinary words.

After the plates were cleared, Aunt Widad insisted on coffee because nations had no right to spoil digestion. Hanna accepted one cup and then rose, but did not leave immediately because the coffee arrived too hot. That too kept Tariq in the room another ten minutes. It was nearly half past two. He had told Khalil after one. He knew this. Maryam saw him glance once towards the hall, where his hat remained on the peg, and then back at the map on the table as if his own sense of timing had been taken into consultation by too many competing authorities. He did not move.

She recognised the gesture because she had made it herself, with Nawal, with letters, with every manageable claim she had ever postponed by sitting still a moment longer than the moment required. The excuse was always reasonable. The radio. The coffee. The map. One more minute. The trouble was that reasonable excuses accumulated into unreasonable time without anyone having to decide.

"Then Khalil will already be waiting," she said.

He looked at her fully then. "Yes."

"And you are late because of the radio?"

He paused just long enough to make the truth visible and not long enough to theatricalise it. "Not only because of the radio."

Then he put on his hat, took the bank letter from the sideboard, and went out after Hanna into the thin cold light.

Maryam stood where she was for another minute. Not because anything had happened that a sensible woman could not account for. Because nothing at all had happened, and the nothing had begun quietly rearranging weight.

Her mother retired for half an hour and did not call it that. Aunt Widad went to the kitchen to tell Amina something severe about lentils and returned having apparently said it to the kettle instead. Leila was sent upstairs for an hour's quiet and asked whether history allowed quiet or only adults. Amina answered that history allowed whatever kitchens could survive.

By late afternoon the wireless still murmured at the lowest volume her mother would tolerate, so that the drawing room seemed to breathe around another room somewhere else. Static moved from station to station like an indiscreet relation arriving ahead of the rest. In the street beyond, another wireless somewhere further down had been turned up and not lowered. The city was beginning the slower work of translating the news into errors.

The front bell rang.

No one moved for one second because every bell under altered conditions becomes a question larger than itself. Amina looked towards the hall. Hanna rose. Before he reached the door, the bell rang again, shorter now, as if its owner disliked drama and intended to be admitted on practical grounds.

It was Khalil Darwish.

Maryam knew it must be him before the name was said because this man entered as outer weather rather than household disturbance. He was broader than Tariq, less carefully arranged, his coat bearing the day's dust in a more public way. He nodded to the room in order of probable seniority, tactful enough to prove he had needed tact all day.

"Forgive the hour," he said to Tariq. "I was told you were here."

"This is Khalil Darwish," said Tariq. "My colleague."

"Missed a title there," said Aunt Widad.

Khalil inclined his head. "I feared to begin too high and never descend."

"That is a promising answer," she said.

He remained standing. "The headmaster wants you tomorrow morning. There are fathers still at the school, and three more notices need copying before church empties men into opinion."

The line might have sounded rehearsed in a man who enjoyed it more. In Khalil it was merely fatigue made articulate. He had spent the afternoon fielding other people's panic while Tariq sat in a drawing room in Qatamon listening to the radio beside a woman whose uncle's papers he had long since ceased to need as pretext. No one in the room said this. No one needed to.

Hanna said, "Sit. At least for tea."

Khalil hesitated only long enough to show that he had intended to go straight back out. Then he accepted, which meant he was more tired than the coat admitted. He took the least comfortable chair without ceremony and kept his notices in hand as though they might otherwise escape.

"What does the school need?" Hanna asked.

"Nothing it does not always need. Paper. Ink. Time. Better fathers." He glanced at the radio. "Tonight it needs to look as though routine still outranks imagination."

"Routine is for peaceful countries," said her mother.

"No," Khalil answered. "Routine is what countries use when peace has failed and breakfast still has to happen."

That, Maryam thought, was the sort of sentence one later attributed to history when in fact it had belonged first to a tired man in a doorway asking for tea.

"Keep that one," said Aunt Widad. "It is better than the radio."

"The radio may remain and do its damage without supervision," said Khalil.

"What sort of notice?" Hanna asked.

"The kind that says nothing untrue and nothing useful. Classes will continue as scheduled. Parents are asked to avoid unnecessary alarm."

"That is longer than a gate deserves," said Tariq.

"It is also shorter than parents deserve."

Amina, from the doorway, spoke before she could stop herself. "Does legal keep buses running?"

Everyone looked at her. She lowered her eyes at once but did not retreat. It was precisely the right question and therefore the sort families like theirs usually preferred not to hear from the person serving tea.

Hanna answered her, not unkindly. "It keeps offices open longer than justice does."

"That is not what I asked."

"No," he said. "I know."

Leila, who had listened with the fierce patience children reserve for conversations they only half understand and therefore mistrust correctly, said, "Can a country move?"

"No," said Hanna.

"Then what are they moving on the radio?"

"Paper," said Aunt Widad.

Leila considered this. "That seems stupid."

"Yes," said Khalil.

The agreement landed too cleanly to be comic.

The talk turned towards the future in forms small enough to hold. Roads. Schools. Offices. Whether servants should go out early for bread on Monday. Whether church would be full. By the time Amina brought bread and olives because long conversation became, in her system, a meal whether the household admitted it or not, the room had ceased listening for revelation. It had begun measuring Monday.

Khalil stood first. "If I do not go now, the headmaster will imagine I have joined a militia or a better school."

Tariq rose at once.

"You are going back tonight?" Hanna asked.

"Only to collect the school stamp and the Arabic register," said Khalil. "If we are to produce nonsense by morning, it may as well look official."

"I will come," said Tariq.

Maryam looked at him before she could stop herself. The movement was small. Not one person in the room missed it except Leila, who was buttering bread with the gravity of treaty work.

"No need," said Khalil. "I can manage."

"Then you would not have come," said Tariq.

That was answer enough. It carried not romance but work: one man recognising when another had asked for help in the only form men like them generally permitted themselves. But it carried something else as well. A debt. Khalil had spent the afternoon alone at the school while parents arrived asking whether Monday could still be trusted, and Tariq had spent it in a drawing room that did not require him. The offer to go back now was not generosity. It was the first small payment on a lateness whose real cost neither man would name.

At the hall table, as coats were taken up and scarves found, Khalil paused by the sideboard where Yusef's spectacles still lay beside the vase.

"The dead are the last to hear news in this house," he said.

"No," said Aunt Widad from behind him. "The dead hear first. They simply no longer waste comment."

He accepted the rebuke as if it were instruction and went out. Tariq followed, then turned back because Amina had called that his scarf remained on the chair. He came two steps into the light of the hall, took it, nodded once to the family, and was gone.

When the door closed, the house did not fall quieter. It merely returned to its own vocabulary.

"I do not like the look of streets after such broadcasts," said her mother.

"Streets always look worse from doorways," Hanna answered.

"That is because doorways know what can be lost."

He did not reply. He went back to the drawing room, turned the radio down until it became only a murmur and not an authority, and sat once more with the bank draft as if sequence could still be drafted by hand.

Later, when Aunt Widad had gone home under protest and Leila had been taken upstairs arguing that nations ought not to interrupt bedtime, Hanna made three brief notes on the bank letter and then conceded that no more clarity could be forced from paper that evening.

"Do not go tomorrow if it feels foolish," he said without looking up.

Maryam knew at once what he meant. "To the hotel?"

"To Mrs Khoury."

"Nawal."

"Yes."

"It would not be foolish."

"No," he said. "Only perhaps crowded. By tomorrow half the quarter will be telephoning or calling on one another in order to turn hearing into knowledge."

"I said I would go."

He nodded, still not looking at her. "Then go. But do not stay after dusk."

It was an ordinary sentence. Protective, practical, mildly irritating. Yet after the evening's noise it sounded almost tender by the standards of marriage.

Maryam went to the hall table to straighten the pile that no longer needed straightening: Nadia's last letter, the

bank draft, Tariq's copied notes, the hotel card tucked beneath a saucer. From upstairs came Leila's voice arguing with Amina about whether countries ought to be allowed to interrupt copybooks. Amina's answer was lost in the floorboards.

She stood a moment with the hotel card in one hand and heard, not from this house but from somewhere two or three houses over, another radio being turned up as if the quarter itself could not bear to receive the evening only once.

She set the hotel card down beside Nadia's letter and, without deciding to, placed it beneath the bank draft rather than above it.

Outside, the neighbourhood went on listening to itself receive the news. Inside, the papers lay where she had left them, one pressure covering another.

CHAPTER VII

The Wrong Reasons

On Sunday the quarter woke before the bells.

The radios had been on too late for anyone to claim surprise in the morning, yet surprise persisted in the form people from Qatamon preferred when reality had behaved badly: not astonishment, exactly, but the determined circulation of interpretation. Voices were already in the street before breakfast. A bread boy shouted twice in the same place because the first answer he received had become a discussion by the time he reached the next gate. Somewhere downhill a wireless was still playing the previous night's report in a room where no one had had the discipline to turn it off. It all gave the neighbourhood the air of having slept in clothes.

Maryam came down to find the hall table transformed from a place for gloves and visiting cards into a kind of domestic frontier post. Nadia's first letter from Beirut lay beside the bank draft. Tariq's corrected notes rested under the saucer. The hotel card from the Semiramis remained where she had left it the night before: half beneath the bank draft, half showing, as if one pressure had not quite succeeded in covering the other.

Her mother was already dressed for church, which in itself meant the day had become larger than piety. On true Sundays she spent the first hour downstairs in wrapper and brooch, issuing judgement with tea. When she dressed before breakfast it meant she intended to be seen thinking correctly.

"We are going early," she said at once. "The church will be intolerable."

"That is not an argument for earliness," said Aunt Widad, who had arrived with the punctuality of a woman to whom other people's crises were invitations. "It is an argument for whisky, and unfortunately the Orthodox have shown no imagination in that regard."

Leila, her collar unfastened and her hair carrying the memory of the pillow with more integrity than any comb had yet managed, said, "Are countries still being divided?"
"Not at table," said her grandmother.
"Then where?"
"In New York, apparently," said Aunt Widad. "Or on radios by men with unsatisfactory voices."
Leila considered this. "Can they not wait until after church?"
"No," said Amina, setting down bread. "Countries have very poor household training."
Hanna came in last, already shaved and tie-fastened, which meant he had worked before breakfast. He carried no packet today, only a small notebook and the expression of a man who had already ordered the day against failure and been informed that failure did not consider itself bound.
"The road by the lower gardens is slower," he said to Amina before sitting. "If you go out later, use the convent side instead."
Her mother said, "No servant should be out later than necessary today."
"No one should be out later than necessary," Hanna answered.
It was not contradiction. It merely widened the category in a way her mother disliked because it prevented her from arranging anxiety by rank.
Maryam broke her bread and kept her eyes on the table. She was supposed to go to the Semiramis that day. Saturday had been lost to the radio and the room and the transformed evening. Sunday remained. Nawal had said come before dusk. Hanna, the night before, had told her not to go if it felt foolish and, when she insisted, had said only: then go, but do not stay after dusk. That sentence had left the responsibility with her, which was not kindness exactly and not unkindness either. It was simply one more instance of Hanna's habit of placing time in her hands as if time were a thing that behaved better when properly allocated.

Aunt Widad buttered toast with unnecessary authority. "Mrs Khoury will be entertaining parliament by noon," she said. "Half the quarter will visit her aunt in the hotel simply to hear itself have views."

Her mother looked at Maryam. "There is no need to go today."

"I said I would go."

"Yes," said her mother, "before last night."

"Last night did not abolish social obligations."

"It complicated them."

Hanna looked once towards the hall table where the hotel card lay under the bank draft. "If you go after church, go directly and come directly back."

"There," said her mother, as if he had at last become useful. "Even Hanna says so."

"What I say," he answered, "is that the city has begun wasting time in groups."

Maryam ought to have said then, clearly enough to be heard by herself as well as by the room, that she would go after church and return before dusk. Instead she drank her tea and let the matter remain among the dishes. It was a small failure of definition, invisible to everyone else because households of that kind lived on postponed clarity. Yet she knew the exact moment in which it had happened: the moment her mother had offered the day as excuse and she had not refused the gift.

The church was fuller than on the previous Sunday and less devout. Devotion was not absent. It had merely been required to stand beside geography and rumour, which were at present louder companions. Father Elias altered the prayers without altering them enough to provoke notice. He invoked peace more than once and wisdom more than anyone present believed governments were likely to accept.

After the blessing the courtyard did what it always did and what, that morning, it seemed almost indecently ready to continue doing: it sorted itself into conversational weather. One could not cross from church door to gate in a straight line unless willing to seem monstrous. Maryam

was stopped first by a widow who wanted to know whether Beirut seemed calmer than Jerusalem. Then by a cousin whose name she had not caught. Then by Mrs Farah, who arrived not like a predator but like a woman perfectly at home with the fact that nothing worth noticing should escape her.

"My dear," she said to Maryam's mother, then at last to Maryam herself. "I hardly slept for people telephoning to repeat what the radio had already made ungentlemanly enough. And hotels must be impossible this morning."

Her mother said at once, "Exactly."

Maryam knew, with the peculiar irritation produced only by being protected in the wrong tone, that the sentence had been offered for her benefit. Hotels must be impossible. Therefore civil women did not go. Therefore no explanation need pass through lips at all; the quarter itself had supplied one. That was the difficulty. No one in Qatamon had to forbid what they could merely arrange into obviousness.

Nawal herself was not there. That mattered more than it should have. Had Nawal appeared in the courtyard, hat tilted, face already alert with amusement at the solemnity around her, the matter might have narrowed into one decent obligation. In her absence it remained distributed across the general intelligence of the quarter, which was a far softer and more effective method of prevention.

On the drive home her mother spoke as though the matter had been settled for anyone still capable of reason. "It would be ridiculous to go to the hotel today."

Hanna, looking out of the window as though routes had become a document needing exact reading, said, "By afternoon everyone will be calling there who does not need to, simply to convert hearing into attendance."

There it was again: another reason, perfectly decent, practically framed, carrying no accusation and therefore harder to resist than accusation would have been. Maryam said nothing. That silence, she knew, was already a choice.

At luncheon the house filled in the way houses did when public events turned drawing rooms into annexes of the

city. Her mother received callers who did not sit long but spoke as though brevity required compensation in certainty. Men came with newspapers folded into quarters, speaking in the singular about Arabs, Jews, Englishmen, or the United Nations with the confidence of people who had never had to manage a servant or a fever by committee. Women came with the more dangerous ease of those who claimed only to be hearing what other women had heard. Maryam's mother received them from the long sofa as though she had personally warned the world against the consequences of foreign arbitration and was now too tired by vindication to rise. Hanna, when he was in the room, stripped away whatever was loudest and asked what roads had been watched, whether the post had come, which office had remained open, and why the butcher's boy claimed flour would rise before morning. People left him both frustrated and better informed. At some point, without formal decision, it became too late to go to the hotel and still arrive there as a friend rather than a woman making a symbolic appearance after the useful hours of friendship were over.

What made the hour pass so efficiently was not pressure in the dramatic sense but sequence. A caller was announced. Coffee had to be poured. Leila needed her copybook found. Her mother developed a headache convenient enough to be genuine. Maryam might still have risen in the middle of all this, taken hat and gloves, and said she was calling at the Semiramis. No one would have barred the door. But the whole structure of a house like theirs was designed to make self-directed motion feel slightly theatrical unless justified by unanimity. If one left during callers, one appeared impatient. If one left while one's husband had only just come in, one appeared unhousewifely. If one left while one's mother was holding her head and receiving sympathy, one appeared cold. Respectability did not imprison by walls. It imprisoned by making every exit available only at the cost of becoming a type. Maryam knew that, had always known it, and had used the same

system to judge other women often enough to make innocence impossible.

By four o'clock the light had turned that pale gold which in Jerusalem could make stone look briefly forgiven. The hotel card remained beneath the bank draft.

Her mother, after the last of the noon callers had gone, had asked with her eyes still closed, "Did you send word to Mrs Khoury?"

"Not yet."

"That is something less than something."

The sentence was not rebuke exactly. In her mother's mouth it was merely the observation that standards had been measured and found to exist below the line she had drawn for them. Even so, Maryam felt the irritation of having the note acknowledged at all. A promise made and broken was tolerable while it remained between women. Once it entered family notice, it acquired moral edges not wholly her own.

Amina came through carrying folded napkins.

"You have not gone," she said, not inquisitively.

"It became difficult."

"In this house everything becomes difficult if left till afternoon."

Maryam did not answer. Amina moved on. She had not said more than the sentence warranted. Yet the effect was irritatingly similar to being answered by conscience, which was precisely how Maryam refused to think of her. Amina was not conscience. Amina was labour, timing, cleared surfaces, the person who knew whether a tray had been set for three or four and whether a woman had truly been prevented from going somewhere or had merely failed to go.

By dusk Maryam had still not written a note. This, later, would trouble her more than the missed visit itself. One postponed; people did; life asked for postponement hourly. But the note — the decent, minimal, ordinary repair — would have cost almost nothing. She sat at the little table in the morning room and began: My dear Nawal, forgive me. Yesterday became impossible in the

most ordinary and therefore most oppressive way — She stopped. The sentence was true and already looked false. It dressed failure in decent cloth and invited admiration for the cut. She tore it up, folded the scraps once and then once more, and began again.

My dear Nawal, forgive me. With the vote yesterday and everyone in the house listening and speculating, the afternoon escaped me. I should have sent word earlier. If you are still there on Thursday, may I come then, at the same hour?

She read the note twice. It was not a lie. It was only not the whole truth. The afternoon had not escaped her; she had let it be taken from her in pieces small enough to look blameless. There was a difference. She folded the note anyway, sealed it, and addressed it to the Semiramis in the neat convent hand she disliked in herself because it made even apology look educated.

What disturbed her was not simply that she had not gone. It was that some small part of her had been relieved not to go, and had accepted the quarter's excuse with gratitude. Not because she disliked Nawal. The opposite. Nawal had the dangerous gift of making a person feel seen at exactly the level where self-deceptions still hoped to survive as nuance. To see her again, so soon after the radio, would have meant being looked at by the only woman in Maryam's circle whose intelligence she trusted not to mistake politeness for depth. Nawal had a way of making delay sound less like burden than like preference. Maryam did not want to be read so clearly on a Sunday when the city itself had begun reading everyone aloud.

There were, after all, excellent reasons not to trust hotel afternoons under altered political weather. Hotels made gossip efficient. Corridors lengthened small observations into reputational fact. The whole quarter had already decided that the Semiramis would spend the day hosting people who wanted to be able to say they had been there. All of that was true.

That was the first wrong reason.

The note went out with Elias' younger brother before the lamps were lit. Maryam watched him from the window for no reason she could have defended. He trotted rather than walked, one hand on his cap because the wind kept lifting it. For a moment she envied the simplicity of a life in which notes were carried, not composed.

The second wrong reason arrived on Monday morning dressed as paper.

A schoolboy from Khalil Darwish's quarter came to the door with a folded note and the embarrassed gravity of one entrusted with material too adult for his age but too minor for ceremony. The note was from Tariq. Not familiar. Not indirect. Merely exact.

Two school notices and one revised English circular need fair copies by tomorrow noon if possible. The headmaster distrusts the first phrasing and Khalil distrusts the headmaster. The bank draft can wait until Tuesday.

Maryam read that final line twice. It was a kindness of the smallest, most actionable variety: he had removed one piece of pressure without making a drama of having done so.

Hanna read the note when she handed it across the table. "He is right. The bank draft can wait. The school circular is the more immediate nuisance." He looked at Maryam. "You have Leila's exercise books still to buy. And your mother needs thread. If you take the marked sheet to Habib first thing tomorrow, you can collect the copies by noon and bring them to the school."

The sentence was practical, unornamented, entirely legitimate. That was precisely why the small movement inside her was so annoying.

Monday afternoon, before the errand could arrive to justify itself, the house exposed something else. After luncheon Maryam remained downstairs with Leila's blue frock across her lap and a needle she had no real need to be using. The hem was sound. A button at the back had been loose since the week before, but not so loose that it explained the afternoon. She sat in the drawing room near the hall and near the table where the packets usually

arrived, telling herself she ought not to be upstairs if school papers came or if Hanna sent some instruction by boy. She listened, without appearing to listen, for the gate.
Amina, passing through with the tea tray, said, "If you are mending that dress by duty alone, it will resent you."
"The button is loose."
"The button has been loose since Wednesday."
"Then I am a woman of unusual patience."
Amina lifted the tray. "No. Only of selective urgency."
By five o'clock she had sewn the same inch of hem twice, unpicked it once, and learned something she disliked learning: that his absence from the house altered its arrangement more visibly to her than it had any right to. The fact was too small to admit and too clean to ignore.
On Tuesday morning she left the house with the marked circular, Leila's exercise books on a list, and the small collection of errands that made the trip respectable. The streets below Qatamon had changed not in shape but in attention. More heads remained turned after greetings were completed. More men spoke in twos and threes with the compressed animation of people who had discovered that public events improved their sense of personal relevance.
At the boys' school the gate stood open, though not in welcome. Fathers were lingering under the pretext of escorting children further than children required escort. A porter with a broom stood near the entrance performing the useless labour institutions assign to frightened mornings: making order visible where no real order could yet be guaranteed.
Khalil Darwish stood just inside with a sheaf of papers and the face of a man who had slept no more than duty considered sufficient. "You have saved us from original composition," he said when he saw the envelope. "The headmaster has spent the morning writing as if Empire still reads us for style."
A boy tried to leave by the gate carrying another boy's ruler in plain sight. Khalil caught him by the shoulder without looking and returned both boy and ruler to the corridor

with the absent exactness of a man performing a movement long since stripped of drama.

He opened the marked copy and his face improved. "This at least sounds like adults addressing adults."

A father at the gate interrupted to ask whether classes would be held through the week. Khalil answered with a patience so exact it almost qualified as contempt. "We are open today. We are open tomorrow unless tomorrow objects. If tomorrow objects, we will let you know in a form more reliable than corridor prophecy."

Tariq emerged from the corridor carrying a stack of exercise books under one arm and a fountain pen uncapped in the other hand, as though the morning had interrupted him in the middle of ruling entire generations by margin. He stopped when he saw her, not dramatically, only long enough for recognition to separate itself from routine.

"You brought the condemned version."

"Khalil said the headmaster distrusted the first phrasing."

"The headmaster distrusts all phrasing that does not sound like the Foreign Office suffering politely."

He unfolded the circular on the ledge by the gate. The English copy had been crossed through and amended in two hands: the headmaster's heavier one and Tariq's smaller, more economical corrections. "The problem is that it sounds as though the school intends to punish fear for bad manners."

"What does the Arabic say?" Maryam asked.

Khalil answered. "More or less: do not spread confusion and send the children as usual unless told otherwise."

"Then the English wants less schoolmaster and more Arabic."

Tariq looked at her properly. "Go on."

She heard, in the quietness of the invitation, the thing that had already begun passing between them more often than any overt warmth: the assumption of use. No scene, no declaration, only the ordinary and therefore dangerous pleasure of being asked to make something exact.

"Parents are asked to rely on official notices from the school and to send pupils as usual unless informed otherwise."

Khalil's face changed first. "Yes. That sounds as though the children belong to sentences rather than to a magistrate."

Tariq read the line once, then again. "Yes."

He did not say clever or good or better. He only said yes, and because he did the line felt more exact than it would have after fuller approval.

At the door, while Khalil went back to the school with the circulars, Tariq asked with complete surface innocence, "Did you make it to the hotel yesterday?"

"No," said Maryam. "The day was crowded."

It was not a lie. It was also not the whole of it.

He nodded once. "Sunday has become unreliable."

The answer seemed to leave him neither relieved nor disappointed, which made it harder rather than easier to bear. Relief or disappointment would have belonged to a clearer world. What passed over his face instead was the quick acceptance of another fact to be carried alongside the rest.

"Will you go today?" he asked.

"I do not know."

He looked at her for a moment, then at the packet in her hands. "Then do not let the city turn one postponement into a habit. It has an appetite for that."

The sentence landed harder than if he had said something warmer. Perhaps because it carried neither special claim nor protective softness. It sounded like advice given to an equal, which was precisely why it moved too far inward.

When she returned, the house was quieter than on Sunday but not steadier. Amina took the parcels from her hand, separated groceries from paper without consulting labels, and said, "Mrs Khoury's porter came."

Maryam turned too fast. "When?"

"At noon. A card."

The card lay on the hall table beside Nadia's letter. The same decorative hand. Mrs Khoury regrets missing you yesterday. Tuesday or Wednesday afternoon would be

better. Aunt Salma insists. Nothing accusatory. Nothing wounded. That, too, was part of what made postponement so morally convenient before it turned lethal. The world so often accepted delay in language gentle enough to help one continue.

At tea Hanna came in and wanted first the school copies, then the bank figure. When Maryam told him the phrase in the notice had been altered, he read the line and said, "Good." The approval from Hanna and from Tariq did not sound alike. Hanna approved outcomes. Tariq approved exactness as if exactness itself were a moral obligation. That difference troubled her more than it should have.

When the lamps were lit and Leila had been sent upstairs, Maryam stood at the hall table once more. Nadia's letter from Beirut. The bank draft. Nawal's card. The corrected school circular copied now in clean type. The table had become, without anyone's consent, the place where the novel of her days was being poorly but unmistakably serialised.

She could still go on Wednesday. Nothing had been destroyed. Nawal was alive in a hotel room with Aunt Salma and tea and hotel chairs and likely a judgement already prepared about the people now suddenly making visits with patriotic expressions. The visit had not yet become loss. That was what made the card feel heavier than paper ought. If some external force had made the visit impossible, the matter would have become history at once. Instead it remained choice, and choice was the medium in which she trusted herself least.

From the drawing room came the small scratch of Hanna's pen over the bank draft. From the kitchen came the china-sound that meant Amina was stacking cups for morning. Maryam placed Nawal's card beside the bank draft, then moved it away from the bank draft, then placed it back again, irritated by her own hands as if they belonged to someone less educated in consequence than she had imagined herself to be.

That movement was small enough to be called nothing. It was also, she knew with a clarity too cold to be

melodramatic, the first inward act she could not pretend was accidental.

On Wednesday, she told herself, she would go.

The sentence comforted her less than it should have. It sounded not like intention but like another instalment in a debt already learning how to grow.

CHAPTER VIII

Amina Covers

The second letter from Beirut arrived with a different address and a thinner hand.

Maryam saw that before she broke the seal. The envelope itself was bluer than the paper Nadia had first used and cheaper by the look of it, though Nadia had managed, by the angle of the writing and the firmness of the downstrokes, to make even borrowed stationery appear to have opinions. The new address was in Ashrafieh rather than in the quarter near the sea named in the first letter. A different cousin, then. A different flat. A different arrangement for saying temporary with a face meant to survive being watched.

It came down in the post with two circulars for Hanna, an account from the grocer which Aunt Widad said had been inflated by optimism, and a church notice asking for subscriptions in aid of families recently arrived from elsewhere and not yet properly distributed among relatives. The city had begun receiving itself in pieces.

The house itself had altered again since the vote. It was not merely that the wireless had been on too late on Saturday and too early on Sunday, or that men now paused outside gates with newspapers folded under their arms as though carrying proof of themselves. It was that every flat surface had begun attracting papers that once kept to their own jurisdictions. Church notices. Office circulars. School sheets. Addresses in Beirut. Receipts from Habib's. One no longer laid a glove down without first moving some smaller piece of evidence about the future.

Her mother, who believed no morning ought to become morally serious before coffee, said, "If that is from Beirut, open it before the tea goes cold. Otherwise one has to spend the whole meal pretending one does not want to know."

Aunt Widad, already there and slicing bread with the air of a woman whose right to breakfast in other people's houses

had been sanctified by age, said, "If it is bad news, tea cannot help it. If it is bearable news, tea will not mind waiting."
Leila said, "If it is from Beirut, ask whether they have better cakes than here."
"Everything outside Jerusalem is judged first by cakes," said Amina from the sideboard.
"Then Jerusalem should be pleased," Leila answered.
Maryam opened the letter with the hairpin she had left beside her cup. The first letter had made hardship sound like inconvenience arranged by taste. This one did not sound panicked; Nadia would rather have been found dead among camphor than panicked. But the tone had shifted. The gaiety had thinned into management. There was less on coffee and more on beds. Less on apricots and more on storage. The address, the cousin, the passage, the child in the passage — all of it said what the sentences refused to. Room had become a negotiation. Dependence had moved from anecdote into floor plan.
Bring papers first and silver second, Nadia wrote again. Do not bring books unless they are necessary to your soul or your vanity, and be honest enough to distinguish between the two. My husband still says this will settle. He now says it with the look of a man asking the weather to admire him. If matters become too unpleasant, come. We will stack one another by kinship and call it temporary. Everyone here calls everything temporary, which is the surest sign that some of it is not.
Hanna read it standing up. He never read family letters for pleasure and never pretended otherwise. He read them for consequence.
"She should keep every receipt," he said when he reached the second page.
"That is what you have taken from all this?" her mother asked.
"It is one of the things."
"There are always papers with you."
"There are always people who regret not having kept them," said Aunt Widad.

Leila, who had extracted the word silver before anyone could redirect her, asked, "Why silver second?"
"Because silver can be sold later," said Amina.
"Then why not bring it first?"
"Because papers get you across doors before silver does."
The child absorbed this gravely. "Do countries ask for papers too?"
"Only countries that want to pretend they are offices," said Aunt Widad.
Hanna folded the letter again and set it by Maryam's plate. "Answer her today."
"As advice or as instruction?"
"As fact. The later the reply, the more room she has to imagine what has not yet happened here."
That, Maryam thought, was exactly the kind of kindness Hanna was capable of: not softening a burden but placing it in the correct order so damage did not enlarge in the wrong direction. It annoyed her that such kindness was real. It annoyed her more that she relied on it.
The day did not immediately turn difficult. That was what made the later difficulty useful. There was washing to be sent, one woman from the church committee who called and stayed too long, and a note from Hanna's office asking that the bank draft be sent over before three. Maryam sat in the morning room and wrote Nadia a reply she disliked before it was half done. It was brief, tactful, and almost empty. It told Nadia that all remained outwardly manageable, that the city was tense but still itself, and that affection remained. She knew, as she sanded the page, that she had underpaid the truth. But a fuller letter would have required her to decide what the truth was, and she was not prepared to give the morning that much authority.
On the hall table Nawal's card from the Semiramis still lay beneath the pin tray. Leila had been coughing earlier in the week, which had disposed of Wednesday. Thursday had gone to the parish committee and the bank draft. The promise made under the church wall, extended once and postponed twice, had now been rescheduled so often that each new date arrived carrying the weight of all the ones

before it. Nawal's second invitation — Tuesday or Wednesday afternoon would be better, Aunt Salma insists — had not been answered with a visit, only with another note promising another day. The card seemed no larger than before and more visible. Maryam had begun to understand that postponement did not shrink obligation. It merely allowed obligation to acquire interest.

After luncheon her mother said, "If you are going to post that and fetch the copied parish sheet from Habib's, go before the light goes poor."

Her mother added the mourning ribbon to the list because no errand crossing Jaffa Road should return morally naked. Amina added lamp wicks. Leila wanted a green pencil. The packet thus entered town sufficiently armoured by plural purpose to satisfy the household gods.

The afternoon had the strange suspended quality Jerusalem now acquired after lunch: streets not quiet, exactly, but listening to themselves. Men paused outside shops with newspapers folded in half. A lorry stood too long at one corner while three people discussed whether the road below the convent was quicker or merely less watched. Maryam walked with the letter in her glove and the ribbon list in her bag and told herself she was only going to Habib's.

Habib's was half stationer's, half copyist's, and wholly proud of both occupations. It smelled of paper, gum, dust warmed by glass, and the faint iron scent of the copying machine when it had been run too hard. Habib himself stood behind the counter reading an invoice as though it had insulted his ancestors.

"You again," he said. "The quarter is keeping me in mourning and municipality at once. Neither pays well."

"I came for the parish receipt copy."

"Not ready."

"It was to be ready by noon."

"It was ready to be ready by noon," he said. "Then the seal blurred."

She ought perhaps to have been irritated. Instead she felt only the small inward release of having been given time by

something outside herself. She said she would wait. He nodded as if she had sensibly acknowledged an arrangement existing prior to both of them.

She had been standing there perhaps four minutes when Tariq came in.

He stopped no more than a fraction when he saw her, then set down a rolled sheet and asked for six copies of the school circular, one on better paper if any remained. Habib's nephew said better paper had become philosophical, meaning it could be discussed but not relied upon. Tariq accepted this with the same expression he had brought to Yusef's desk: not patience, exactly, but the refusal to waste emotion on facts that had no interest in being altered by it.

Maryam ought to have left. The parish copy was still being redone and the letter still needed posting, yet no reason for immediate departure presented itself that did not sound, even in her own head, manufactured. So she remained.

He looked at the envelope without touching it. "Beirut?"

"My cousin. She has moved again."

"Then Beirut has begun behaving like Jerusalem."

"She still writes as though inconvenience were a style."

"That is what people do when they are afraid of becoming burdens before they have formally arrived."

The sentence was not only about Nadia. That had become one of the difficulties between them: remarks travelled with second cargo.

"She says papers first and silver second," Maryam said.

"That is sensible."

"I was hoping you would call it tragic."

"It can be both. But if the road closes, tragic silver remains merely decorative."

Outside, someone splashed through the gutter. Habib's nephew fed the sheet through the copier and it emerged with the seal still too weak. He fed it through again. The rain thickened and thinned by turns against the glass. Maryam stood by the wall and watched the minutes at which an afternoon quietly disqualified itself from being used for anything more elevated than paper.

At one point she said, "Do you ever become tired of words solving nothing?"

Tariq placed the receipt he was holding precisely on the stack before answering. "Words solve very little. They only prevent the wrong thing from being called right."

"That sounds like the schoolmaster's creed."

"It sounds like a man who has spent too long with clerks."

"And if the right thing is impossible?"

He looked at her. There was no one else at the side table then but the two of them and the machine's intermittent metallic complaint.

"Then one must at least stop calling the impossible temporary."

Habib re-entered carrying three small cups of coffee and an opinion about the weather. The break in the air was so abrupt that Maryam nearly thanked him, which would have revealed more than silence. They drank standing at the side table. Habib complained of ink prices. Tariq corrected a figure in the bank draft note Hanna had sent. Maryam found herself speaking too little because speaking the wrong amount seemed suddenly dangerous.

She should have gone then. Instead she stayed while Habib coaxed the machine back into obedience and while Tariq rewrote a school line in his smaller, firmer hand. A clerk from the Patriarchate arrived and began arguing over the price of foolscap with such conviction that one might have thought paper itself a theological matter. Through all of it time went by in pieces too small to accuse.

That was the danger. Had there been one clear extravagance — an invitation, a pause too long, some softness no room could mishear — Maryam would have known what to refuse. But usefulness made its own weather. One stayed to hold a page. One read a line. One waited for a seal to take properly the second time. One remained because leaving in the middle of a task looked theatrical and staying did not. This was how days were stolen in respectable households: not whole, but by quarter-hours too ordinary to be defended against.

When the corrected pages were finally ready, the hour had travelled farther than any errand of that sort had a right to demand. Habib tied the packet, found the mourning ribbon, forgot the lamp wicks, found the lamp wicks, and accused the rain of moral weakness. Tariq put on his coat and said he was walking as far as the tram because he had to leave two forms at the school office.

"You need not," Maryam said at once.

"No," he said. "I do not."

He took up his umbrella anyway.

The walk to the tram stop was short enough to be explained and long enough to alter the blood. They spoke chiefly of safe things: the headmaster's handwriting, Khalil's belief that timetables could shame politics into obedience, whether Habib had charged too much for the ribbon. Such safety was by then one of the least safe parts of speaking to him. Their caution no longer protected innocence; it merely kept desire dressed in clerical clothes. At the tram they paused beneath the shallow awning while two schoolboys argued over fares.

"You are becoming difficult to find," Tariq said.

"I am standing in front of you."

"That is not what I meant."

She ought to have answered lightly. Instead she said, "There is a great deal in the way."

"Yes," he said. "The city has made itself useful to your delays."

"So have children. And relatives. And rain. And municipal receipts."

He did not smile. "That is how habit begins. It acquires helpers."

The tram came. He placed the packet more firmly into her hands as she stepped up, an ordinary practical gesture which became unbearable only because it was ordinary. He did not touch her skin. The pressure of the papers against her glove was enough.

When she reached the house the lamps were already lit. That, more than the rain or the hour, made the return feel wrong. A woman coming back before dusk from Habib's,

from any errand sanctioned by household need, belonged to the day. A woman coming back under lamplight belonged to explanation.

Her mother was in the drawing room with two callers from the parish. Aunt Widad sat opposite her. Before Maryam could speak, Amina came from the dining room carrying the small bowl used for olives and said, in the same tone with which she might have remarked upon weather or bread, "Habib kept her. The machine jammed again and the carbon tore. She has been standing there half the afternoon waiting for the seal not to smear."

Her mother's expression changed from prepared annoyance to the lesser irritation one reserved for tradesmen and paper. "That man will die beneath a mountain of receipts and expect Paradise to sort them."

One of the callers said, "Habib always keeps people too long. He treats paper like a sick relative."

"Yes," said Aunt Widad. "Which is better than the municipality, which treats it like revenge."

Maryam held out the copied sheet and the ribbon because now that Amina had supplied the room with its reason, the objects had to exist visibly inside it. The room took the offered explanation and moved on. Tea was poured. One woman began speaking of an uncle in Jaffa who now slept in his shop. The machinery of afternoon resumed.

There was nothing in Amina's sentence that could be called a lie from outside it. Habib had kept her. Carbon had indeed torn. The seal had indeed smeared. Amina had built the explanation entirely out of materials already available to the house. That was what made it so exact. She had not guessed where Maryam had been. She had only understood, from the hour, the rain on the hem, the packet in her hand, the look with which she entered, what sort of account the room required and supplied it before Maryam's hesitation could produce something worse.

Only when the callers had gone did Amina say, quietly, "Come to the pantry a moment."

Maryam followed because not following would have been visible.

Inside the pantry, where shelves of jam and lentils made a small practical nation immune to rhetoric, Amina took Maryam's right hand without asking, dampened a cloth, and rubbed at the thumb and cuff where the copying ink had left its small dark proof.

"If your mother sees that on the table linen she will speak of it for three days," Amina said.

The stain lightened under the cloth. Only then did Maryam speak.

"You did not need to say that."

"No."

"Then why did you?"

"Because if you had stood there choosing among reasons, your mother would have begun improving them."

That was true enough to sting.

"It was not necessary."

"In this house," Amina said, "many things are not necessary until they become tiresome." She set the cloth down and added, not sharply, "If a room catches on a thing, everything goes slower."

Maryam heard in the sentence no accusation and, because there was none, felt the shame more precisely. Amina had not rescued her out of sympathy, still less out of some romantic interest in the matter. She had protected the room, the tea, the callers, the child, the whole weary machine of afternoon. What had happened was that concealment had dropped a class in the house. Whatever existed between Maryam and the hours she had begun losing was no longer held only in glances, silences, and postponed visits. It was being upheld, corrected, and cleaned by labour beneath her own position. Amina did not need to know where every minute had gone. She knew enough from timing, stain, and the difference between a packet delayed by incompetence and an afternoon elongated by wanting. Not in detail, perhaps, but in kind. That knowledge was not romantic. It was worse. It was practical.

Leila burst in before either woman could improve or worsen the exchange. "May I have the quince now?"

"No," said both women at once.
Leila looked from one to the other. "Then someone is lying."
"Exactly," said Amina, and took the child by the shoulder back towards the kitchen.
Maryam remained where she was for a second longer, her hand still resting on the shelf where the better thread lay. She thought, with a clarity she could not sentimentalise, that the house had now begun to work on behalf of something she had not yet even admitted privately. Not the family, not the quarter, not Hanna, not her mother. The house: tray, kettle, tea, servants' knowledge, the management of hour and explanation. Something had shifted from inward trouble into shared labour. It would have been cleaner, perhaps, had someone accused her. Accusation drew lines. This only smoothed them.
That was what made it dirty. Not romance. Labour.
When Hanna came home he asked first for the receipt, then whether Habib's seal had behaved, then whether the ribbon was the better kind or merely the kind her mother would call better if no one argued. He did not ask whether Maryam had been delayed for any reason beyond the room's accepted one. She almost wished he would. He did not. He simply took the receipt, checked the seal against the light, made a note in his book, and moved on to the next item in the sequence by which he kept the world answerable. Even his grace, she thought, arrived in the form of not asking.
After supper, when Leila had gone up and her mother had retired with a headache she regarded as both symptom and rank, Maryam took Nadia's letter and looked at it again by the dining-room lamp. The reply she had written that morning was still too smooth. She took up the pen and altered one line.
Here all is still manageable in outward ways, she had first written.
Now she wrote: Here all is still manageable in outward ways, which may be the most dangerous form of manageability.

She read the sentence twice. It was better and worse. Better because it admitted something. Worse because it sounded like writing. She left it in and hated herself a little for choosing cadence where candour had briefly appeared.
From the kitchen came the soft sound of cups being stacked. Maryam did not need to turn to know Amina was there, returning things to their places, making the room ready for morning as if nothing in it had shifted by more than an hour and a copied receipt. On the hall table, Nawal's card still waited.
Hanna came in to collect the bank papers. "Will you go tomorrow?"
"To whom?"
"To Mrs Khoury."
"Nawal."
"Yes."
His tone carried neither suspicion nor encouragement. It was simply the practical mind moving one obligation forward once another had consumed the wrong amount of time.
"Yes," she said.
He nodded and went back to the table.
Maryam remained standing with her hand on the short letter to Beirut. She could still tell herself that the day had been taken from her by paper, machine, weather, trams, the city's new appetite for delay. All those things were true enough to bear weight. The trouble was that another truth now sat beneath them like a second sheet under a blurred seal.
She had not wanted the hour to end quickly.
That was small. It was also the first fact in this matter that belonged wholly enough to her to become dangerous.

CHAPTER IX

Semiramis

The explosion came before the house had properly surrendered the night. It did not announce itself first as history. It announced itself as a violent correction to sleep. Glass shivered in its frames. Somewhere downstairs a plate struck another plate with the offended clarity of china moved against its will. Leila cried out once from the room at the back, not yet from fear but from the more childish indignation of being dragged awake by a sound that had no business entering a respectable house before dawn.

Maryam was on her feet before she had fully understood why. The floor was cold enough to send its fact through her slippers. In the corridor the darkness was already altered by movement: a door opened, then another; a strip of lamp from her mother's room; Amina's quicker tread from the servants' side with a shawl dragged around her shoulders and pinned badly at the throat because the hour had not allowed dignity. For one second the whole house seemed to pause in the passage together, listening for the second sound that would declare what category of danger had entered. None came. Only the after-silence remained, unnaturally attentive, as if the neighbourhood itself were holding its breath in the dark.

"What was that?" Leila called, now crying in earnest.

"Nothing that requires crying," her mother answered from behind her half-open door in the tone of a woman who believed order could sometimes be restored by naming it before it existed.

Hanna, already in his shirtsleeves and buttoning his collar as he moved, said, "It was not nothing."

He crossed the hall and opened the front shutter one slat at a time. A draught came in sharp and damp. Somewhere lower in the quarter a dog began barking and was answered at once by another. Then, after the barking, came human sound: a door thrown open too quickly, a

man's voice raised not in speech but in direction, the irregular thud of feet on stone steps. Maryam stood with one hand on the banister and had the irrational thought that the hall table ought not to be there in this light, with its day things waiting in the wrong hour — the bank papers, Nadia's thin blue envelope, Nawal's card half visible where it had slipped from beneath the pin tray. Such objects belonged to delay and sequence. They did not belong in a house that had just been struck awake.

"There has been an explosion," Hanna said.

"A tyre?" her mother said, because domestic life always offered lesser explanations first, not out of foolishness but out of self-defence.

"No."

"Where?"

"I cannot yet tell."

Amina had already gone to Leila. The child's crying softened into the protesting hiccup of someone being lifted and told that the house was still a house. Aunt Widad emerged fastening the belt of her dressing gown and said, "If this is one of those absurd boys with dynamite again, I shall personally write to the governor."

"There is no governor who can help you now," Hanna said.

Her mother, refusing helplessness in a passage, ordered the drawing-room lamp lit. When the telephone finally rang it startled them more than the explosion had because telephones carried intention. Her mother took the call standing, one hand pressed to the table as though receiving bad news required ballast.

"It was the Semiramis," she said when she turned back to the room.

Nothing moved at once. Not because the name required explanation. It required too little. The hotel lay close enough to the quarter's idea of itself that everyone there had some relation to it, however faint: a tea taken on a wet day, a cousin who had lodged an aunt there, a room borrowed because pipes had burst elsewhere. The building had entered the morning as damage.

Maryam heard the sentence and not its meaning. The meaning lagged behind, arriving in pieces that did not wish to fit: Nawal in the little sitting room with the bad chrysanthemums; Aunt Salma at the window; the card on the hall table; Wednesday; tomorrow; before dusk. A person could hear the name of a building and understand immediately what it did to stone. The more difficult thing was understanding what it did to a promise.

By six the house had accepted that it would not return to sleep. Amina had put bread near the stove not because anyone wanted breakfast but because in houses like theirs food was one of the few forms by which alarm could be kept from becoming theatre. Her mother changed into a dark morning dress. Hanna shaved. That, more than anything, told Maryam the day had moved into serious difficulty rather than chaos. If he could still shave, it meant he had not yet given the world authority to cancel sequence altogether.

Her mother telephoned twice and was telephoned three times. Each exchange produced one more fragment and three more questions. The vice-consul had been there. No, perhaps not. An entire wing had come down. No, only the lower rooms. There were dead already. No one knew how many. Aunt Salma might have gone elsewhere after supper. Nawal might not have been in her room. These last two possibilities were offered by no source at all, only by the household's instinctive attempt to place hope where knowledge had not yet hardened enough to forbid it.

Maryam said once, "I will go there."

"No," said her mother.

"Not now," said Hanna.

The difference between the two refusals might have been lost on another person. To her mother it was obviously improper, crowded, impossible in the social sense. To Hanna it was a question of timing and routes, of being in the way of men carrying rubble. His refusal admitted a future in which going might become possible. Her mother's did not.

"I said I would visit today," Maryam answered, and heard at once how inadequate the sentence sounded beside a demolished building.

At breakfast Amina moved in and out with the tea urn, toast, the sugar bowl, an extra cup that no one admitted to wanting and everyone used. Her labour was not faster than usual. It was more exact. When she reached Maryam she set down the cup and, in the same motion, moved Nawal's card from the edge of the sideboard to the safer side of the tray as if she were protecting paper from tea and not recognising that one visible rectangle had become too prominent in the room.

By nine the quarter had entered the second stage of disaster: not event but circulation. News began travelling by the slower, more contaminating routes of social interpretation. Men who had gone to the site returned with dust on their shoes and statements that bore the unmistakeable shape of having improved while spoken. Women telephoned to ask whether the family had heard. Her mother received these calls with a composure that had in it equal parts charity and disgust.

On the hall table lay Nadia's letter, the bank draft, and Nawal's card. For weeks the table had staged the comedy of delay: one thing awaiting answer, another awaiting signature, everything manageable so long as management itself remained the highest local virtue. This morning the arrangement looked not cluttered but accusatory. Maryam picked up the card and read the line she had long since memorised. Tuesday or Wednesday afternoon would be better. Aunt Salma insists.

When Hanna came into the hall she put it down too quickly.

"Can you find out whether she was there?"

He did not pretend not to understand. "I am trying to find out who can currently distinguish the living from the dead without vanity."

"I was to go today," she said, and hated herself for hearing how the sentence still placed her own schedule at the centre of the rubble.

He looked at her then with something that might almost have been softness if it had not been so carefully rationed. "I know."

Those two words made the morning worse. Because if he knew, he knew not only the day's plan but also the pattern that had preceded it: notes, rescheduling, the card passing from pin tray to sideboard and back again. He knew enough to know there had been time. He merely lacked the temperament to make an indictment out of what could still be called sequence.

"Do not go down there until there is some use in it," he said. "Crowds are another form of damage."

The late morning belonged to arrangement. Father Elias asked whether her mother could receive two women who had come from lower down and no longer knew which cousins they were waiting for. Her mother told Amina to put out the less chipped cups. The instruction was neither callous nor absurd. One did not offer bad china to women who had spent the morning under news.

The women arrived in black coats damp at the hem, carrying the smell of wool, cold stone, and dust. There was coffee. There were facts that might become facts. The hotel had partially collapsed. Men were still digging. Aunt Salma had been seen. No one could swear to Nawal.

One caller who genuinely knew one of the dead replaced one who merely knew of them. This altered the quality of the room at once. Even her mother became less composed and more specific.

"She had a brown hat she never pinned properly," her mother said once, half to herself and half to Aunt Widad, when no one had yet spoken of hats at all.

Maryam looked up so fast her neck hurt. It had not occurred to her that her mother, too, had fragments of Nawal stored somewhere unwitnessed. There was no moral in this. It was merely one more insult grief offered to neat self-knowledge: other people had known the dead in ways one had not supervised.

Aunt Widad said, "And she laughed with all her teeth, which sensible girls should not and which only suited her because she had good teeth."

"That is not the point," her mother answered.

"It is a point," Aunt Widad said. "The dead are not improved by being general."

At half past eleven a boy from Khalil Darwish's school came with a folded notice for Hanna and a separate slip in Tariq's hand. The school would close at noon. Tariq's note was shorter still: Roads near the lower quarter are badly crowded. Do not attempt the hotel district unless you have family already there and no one else who can go.

The sentence was entirely proper. It might have been written to any household. Yet it entered Maryam's nerves differently from the rest of the morning's paper. Not tenderness. He was too exact for sentimental leakage, especially in ink. But urgency stripped of surplus language. He had written as one who knew she might still try to turn guilt into action and that action, at the wrong hour, often served only the person performing it.

Her mother saw the note and said, "There. Even the schoolmaster says no."

Maryam folded the slip before anyone could ask to see it again. She disliked that she wanted to keep it not for its instruction but because his hand, entering the house in the middle of the morning's ruin, made the whole disaster bend for one second into personal scale. This too was contamination. Nawal might be beneath a collapsed hotel and still some part of Maryam's inward life insisted on noticing the pressure by which one man formed his letters.

It was during luncheon that the first true certainty arrived, though even then it entered the house wearing the hesitant shoes of report. A cousin of Aunt Widad's sent word that bodies had been brought out and names were beginning to settle. Manuel Allende Salazar. Several from the hotel families. A child. More still under masonry. One woman from the Khoury side believed missing.

More information. As if death were a file.

Maryam put down her fork and found she had been gripping it as though utensils could be made to testify. Khoury could mean cousins, in-laws, a whole Christian geography of names. It could mean Nawal or not Nawal. The room offered that ambiguity as relief. She recognised relief when it was handed to her and despised herself for accepting it even provisionally.

Hanna, who had eaten almost nothing, said, "Until someone names the person, all grief is hypothetical and all panic vanity."

"You speak as though people choose whether panic arrives before precision."

"No. I speak as though precision is still preferable."

"To clerks, perhaps."

"To the living," he said.

After luncheon Maryam carried plates to the sideboard simply because her hands needed instruction. Amina was already there.

"If she is alive, they will know by evening," Amina said. "If she is dead, they will also know by evening."

"That is not help."

"No. But it is probably the day."

The afternoon tightened. Hanna went out and returned with mud on the hem of his trousers and dust on his coat. The road below the convent was heavily blocked. St John's had taken several wounded. When her mother asked whether he had gone as far as the Semiramis he said only, "Near enough to know not to bring women there." He saw Maryam looking at the dust and said, "A window, not blood."

She had not known until then that the mind had placed blood there so readily.

At four a parish list began to circulate, hand-copied badly, corrected in pencil, passed from gate to gate and then indoors as though paper itself conferred legality upon grief. The vice-consul. Two Lorenzos. A child. A woman from the Khoury relation still unconfirmed. Aunt Salma injured. Nawal not yet marked, yet not absent either,

because absence on such lists did not acquit. It merely postponed.

Maryam read the list in the morning room and thought, with the oddly meticulous cruelty grief uses before grief has formally arrived, of each postponement in its own little clothes.

Sunday had not seemed like refusal. It had seemed like weather made social. Her mother had supplied the excuse without quite meaning to: hotels must be impossible today. Mrs Farah had completed the rest by existing in the courtyard with her tone of neighbourly arrangement. Maryam had let the whole quarter perform the refusal for her. The uglier truth was that she had not wanted to sit under Nawal's intelligence on that particular Sunday and have the slight inward alteration in herself read aloud.

Then Tuesday — or what her mind now called Habib's day, though that was unfair to Habib and too generous to herself. There had been papers, rain, the jammed machine, the school circular, Tariq's usefulness. All of that was true. Yet the day had also contained the fact, which only now dared call itself by its plain name, that she had not wanted the hour to end quickly. She had chosen no one. She had merely allowed preference to collaborate with circumstance, which is how respectable lives become morally deformed without ever acquiring the honesty of vice.

Her mother dressed to call on a cousin of the Khourys living two streets over, where women would gather because official knowledge remained late and private endurance could not. Maryam said she would go with her. Her mother refused at once.

"You are known to have been meant there already," she said. "Today your face would ask for comfort when it ought to offer it."

To object would have been to make herself the subject outright.

After her mother had gone, the house thinned. Aunt Widad dozed sitting up. Leila was sent upstairs. Amina lit the

lamps one by one. Their light made the windows into mirrors, and the mirrors doubled the room's fatigue.

When the bell rang again she thought, absurdly, that at last it must be final knowledge. But final knowledge rarely arrives at the dramatic moment. It arrives tired, on the heels of too many lesser visits. This time it was Mrs Farah herself, veiled in black, lips set to condolence rather than curiosity.

"My dear," she said to Aunt Widad first, because Mrs Farah understood precedence even when grief might have excused sloppiness. "I have come from the Khoury cousin's house."

No one invited her to sit. She sat anyway, which under the circumstances was mercy rather than presumption.

"Aunt Salma is alive," she said. "Her arm is broken and there is some cut near the ear. She had gone downstairs for hot water, or so they say."

Maryam felt the room tilt not from relief but from its immediate companion, which is dread narrowed to target.

"And Nawal?" Aunt Widad asked.

Mrs Farah looked briefly at Maryam and then at the tablecloth. "They have found her."

The grammar was enough. Still Maryam heard herself say, "Alive?"

"No."

The house received the word in layers. Aunt Widad crossed herself. Hanna closed his notebook, which he had for some monstrous reason still been holding. From upstairs came Leila's voice singing something to a doll in the unpunctured world of children temporarily spared exact nouns. Amina, from the dining-room doorway, remained entirely still for one breath and then resumed carrying the tea things as though movement itself were the only respect left available.

Nawal was dead.

What made the sentence so intolerable was not that she had feared it and now had it confirmed. It was that the confirmation carried with it, in the same breath, the entire ridiculous ordinary history of not going. Leila's cough. The

parish. The hotel corridor that would be crowded. Sunday turning impossible in groups. Habib's machine. Tuesday becoming Wednesday. Wednesday becoming another note. None of these things disappeared because Nawal had died. They remained, each one still defensible and all of them together obscene.

Her mother made a low sound and crossed herself. Aunt Widad said, "Poor child," which was absurd because Nawal had been older than Maryam and cleverer than most of them, and yet the phrase was not absurd either, because death shrank the dead at once in the mouths of those left speaking. Hanna said, "Who has her family?" which was the first practical question and therefore the least false one.

Father Elias answered. A brother from farther off. The aunt conscious. The church would coordinate. There would be more information by evening.

Maryam sat because she could not remain standing without either performing control or losing it, and both felt vulgar. The cup Amina set by her hand smelt not of comfort but of labour. Coffee was still being made. Cups were still being washed. The quarter's catastrophe had entered the room not by replacing domestic work but by requiring more of it.

Aunt Widad turned first to linen. "Her aunt will need things," she said. "If Aunt Salma has been taken elsewhere there will be no proper nightdress, no comb, nothing but what she has on." Between them they packed a bag of things women required when institutions took them over: linen, soap, comb, hairpins, the little humiliating civilities that allowed a body to remain a person when rooms and men had begun treating it as a problem. The bag went out through Elias, then returned because no one yet knew where it ought to be sent, then went out again with a different address and the priest's name attached. The absurdity of this — soap travelling in uncertain circles while the quarter still argued over numbers — should perhaps have been comic. It was not. It was exactly the

shape of a day in which catastrophe had entered but had not yet settled enough to be efficiently served.

When her mother returned from the Khoury cousin's, dusk had already begun turning the windows into black mirrors. One saw immediately, before she spoke, that the visit had taken something from her. Her hat sat slightly wrong. The gloves had been removed without being properly paired.

"It is confirmed," she said. "Aunt Salma is alive. Bruised and furious. Nawal was in the room. There is no sense in repeating the rest."

Her mother very rarely granted silence the dignity of usefulness. That she did so now gave the house a gravity it had not otherwise been able to find.

Leila came down because children always hear the change in adult air before they hear the words. She entered carrying the doll by one leg and stopped at the door.

"Who is dead?" she asked.

It was Hanna who answered. "Mrs Khoury's niece. The lady who was at the hotel."

"Nawal?"

"Yes."

Leila looked from one face to another, measuring whether the answer required immediate tears. Not finding them already deployed, she adopted the grave expression children use when offered an adult fact they cannot yet sort into their own experience.

"Then you cannot visit tomorrow," she said to Maryam.

The sentence cut more cleanly than any lament. Her mother closed her eyes for one second as if the child had placed a hand exactly on a bruise no one else had yet located. Maryam felt not merely pain but exposure. The whole mechanism of the day, all its concealed and respectable little failures, had been reduced by a child to the bluntest available arithmetic.

"No," Maryam said.

Leila considered. "That is bad."

"Yes," said Hanna, before anyone else could soften it. "It is."

Amina led the child away without adding a moral. Once Leila had gone, the silence returned heavier because it had now acquired language.

Supper was produced all the same. Her mother took two spoonfuls of lentil soup and then began giving instructions: black dress tomorrow, proper calling card, Father Elias to be informed, Aunt Widad to find out whether another tray would be useful. Management was the only shape her care knew how to take once pain exceeded what polished speech could carry.

Hanna ate in near silence. Only once did he speak directly to Maryam.

"You are not to go down alone tomorrow," he said.

"Why would I go alone?"

"Because guilt makes women stupid in particular ways and men polite about it."

Her mother said, "That is a revolting sentence."

"It is still the sentence."

Maryam might ordinarily have answered with coldness. Instead she said, "I know."

He looked up then, briefly. Between them passed something so stripped of ornament it might almost have counted as companionship: not warmth, not forgiveness, only the mutual admission that facts had now outrun the old domestic fictions by which husband and wife could preserve themselves from one another.

After supper Hanna returned to the drawing room and, after a time, closed the bank file and left it shut. That, more than anything else, demonstrated the day's real change. Paper, which until now had survived everything — death, surveillance, weather, cousins in Beirut, school warnings, the vote — had for one evening been defeated by a hotel.

Only later, in the morning room, did Maryam fully begin to grieve. She went there with Nawal's two cards because she could no longer bear to have them lying on the hall table beneath Nadia's letter and the bank draft, as if they still belonged among errands. The room was cold. Nawal's note about undrinkable tea looked suddenly less like wit than like the preserved shell of a voice.

If Wednesday is impossible, come Monday after luncheon. Impossible. The word had been there all along, harmless, social, useful. She sat with the card in her hand and understood with a clarity almost cold enough to be tidy that impossibility was often manufactured after the fact by people who had preferred delay while delay still flattered them.

There was a knock at the half-open door. Not Hanna. Amina.

She held out a handkerchief she had dampened with water. "You have coffee on your cuff."

Maryam looked down. There was indeed a half-moon stain near the wrist.

Amina put the cloth on the little table. "If your mother sees it she will ask whether you have no hands left."

"Let her."

Amina remained where she was. "The quarter is saying more tonight than it knows. It will be worse tomorrow. You should sleep before it worsens."

Maryam almost laughed at the practicality of it. But that was what labour knew: tomorrow's suffering would still require the body that suffered it to carry trays, dress children, hear names, answer knocks, and not forget to send for bread.

"Did you know her?" Maryam asked.

"Mrs Khoury?"

"Nawal."

Amina considered. "I knew her hat."

"What hat?"

"The brown one with the pin she wore crooked. She always adjusted it after she had gone through the gate, not before. Women who do that are usually in a hurry or thinking."

"She was usually both."

Amina nodded once. "Then I knew the hat."

When she had gone, the sentence undid Maryam more thoroughly than the official confirmation had. Not because hats mattered more than names. Because it was the first thing said all day that made Nawal again a specific woman in time rather than one more dead person in a hotel. The

crooked hat, adjusted after the gate. Thinking. In a hurry. Alive enough to do a thing incorrectly because another thing in the mind mattered more.

Maryam bent forward and pressed the cloth against her eyes, not because she had become theatrical enough to need a prop but because grief, when it finally arrived, often did so through tiny exactnesses one had not arranged for.

Hanna found her there later. He did not come in at once. He stood in the doorway, the mannerism of a man who never entered another person's state quickly.

"I had the card," she said.

"Yes."

"I was going to go."

"Yes."

No sympathy in the word. No accusation either. Merely yes — the only answer to a fact that could not be improved.

"I did not go."

"No."

She wanted, with a sudden absurd fury, for him to say something consoling and false: that no one could have known, that Sunday had been crowded, that Monday would not have saved anyone. Instead he remained what he was — a man who did not mend tears by invalidating their cause.

After a moment he said, "The church ladies will come tomorrow whether invited or not. If you do not wish to see them before noon, say so now."

"Before noon," she said.

"Very well."

He left, and she heard him in the passage already translating feeling into household instruction.

She sat at the writing table and pulled towards her a sheet of notepaper. She did not yet know for whom. Yet she uncapped the pen because not writing felt too close to the pattern which had just killed a visit.

My dear —

She stopped. The salutation itself had become unbearable. Dear belonged to the living and to letters that expected answers. She crossed it out so hard the nib tore the paper.

Amina found her there some time later with the black dress brushed and hanging from one finger, the narrow gloves over her wrist, and the hat box balanced against her hip.

"Your mother says the plain one," she said.

She set the dress over the back of the chair. On the table she saw the torn sheet, the card, the open pen. Her eyes rested there no longer than labour permitted. She gathered the spoiled paper, folded it once, and asked, "Is this to be kept?"

"No."

Amina moved to the grate. The paper caught at once because the fire had been banked but not killed.

"The little one is asleep," Amina said. "She asked whether ladies in hotels go to heaven more quickly because they are already dressed."

Maryam gave a sound that might have become a laugh in another house and another century. "And what did you tell her?"

"That heaven has no interest in hats."

This time the laugh did come, brief and disobedient. Amina did not smile in response. She only adjusted the dress so the sleeve would not crease and then, after the smallest pause, moved the black gloves from the chair to the hall table beside the card.

The gesture was practical. Gloves belonged with card, hat, handkerchief, not with wool and firelight. Yet once made, it rearranged the whole little geography of objects. Nawal's invitation lay there still in its decorative hand, no longer awaiting answer; above it now rested the equipment of condolence.

"I will leave the lamp low," Amina said.

When she had gone, the house settled by degrees into the altered quiet that follows the first day on which a neighbourhood understands that its fear was not hysteria after all. Nadia's letter waited beneath the gloves. Tariq's folded note lay to one side. Nawal's card showed by half an inch.

Maryam did not move it.

She stood in the hall a long time, not weeping, only learning the new weight that the simplest future tense could now carry. Tomorrow the black dress. Tomorrow the call. Tomorrow the house of the Khourys. Tomorrow the next school notice, the next bank signature, the next road judged unsafe. None of those tomorrows would again belong to the old category in which the word had been merely spacious.

At last she put out the lamp and went upstairs by memory. In the dark, the hall table remained where it was, holding its small archive of the day: invitation, warning, departure, mourning. But something central had already been withdrawn from the neighbourhood beyond the walls. Not hope. Hope was too theatrical and too available to later writers. What had been withdrawn was the assumption that delay was still a harmless form of good breeding.

The whole quarter had begun, overnight, to organise itself around the knowledge that what one delayed on Monday might by Tuesday belong to the dead.

CHAPTER X

After Semiramis

The day after Semiramis the house resumed itself in the wrong key.

Nothing in it had returned to its place, yet everything had resumed its duty. Cups were washed and set to drain. The front shutters were opened, though not fully. Amina swept the entrance hall with the severity of a woman who knew dust did not mourn and therefore had to be made to leave by hand. Bread was cut. Tea was made. Maryam's mother rose later than usual and announced at once, before anyone else could ask, that she had not slept because women of feeling rarely did after such a day. Aunt Widad answered that women of feeling slept very well once given broth and quiet, and that what had kept the house awake was not feeling but telephones. Her mother called this unkind. Aunt Widad said it was an account.

Under any other circumstances the exchange might have carried the ordinary relief of familiar irritations. This morning it passed over some other, less manageable air. Nobody raised a voice. Nobody said the wrong name in the wrong tone. Yet the room had become more careful than it had been before the explosion, and therefore less honest. People did not now say that so-and-so would come after luncheon. They said, if they were still on that side of town. They did not say the lower roads were awkward. They said one was hearing things. The quarter, which had always lived at least partly by assessment of one another's houses, habits, and failings, was beginning to develop a second language beneath the first, one in which information travelled wrapped in manners.

Between them her mother and Aunt Widad had already converted Nawal's death into a problem of cloth, gloves, card stock, and the order in which one called upon the Khoury relations. Their management was not callous. It was simply the only form in which women of their

generation permitted care to appear once the event itself had exceeded what language could decently hold.

On the sideboard lay the objects the previous night had arranged and then failed to disperse: the black gloves, Nawal's card, the little stack of calling cards, Tariq's folded warning note, Nadia's thin blue letter from Beirut. Before Semiramis, the hall table had been an instrument of postponement. One thing awaited answer, another signature, another errand, all of them manageable so long as the household retained its faith that time was broad and paper could hold it in place. Now each object seemed less like a task than like a witness. Maryam put Nawal's card into the pocket of her coat simply because she could not bear the sight of it lying beneath gloves chosen for the call that should never have had to be made.

Hanna had taken over the end of the dining table nearest the sideboard and made, with envelopes, receipts, and two ledgers, a small administrative country of his own. There was a new quality in the movement now. The categories had become less archival and more immediate. Things no longer lay in neat moral families — bank, cemetery, tenant, office. They lay according to whether they might still be useful if a bank remained open, if a clerk remained at his desk, if one could still reach the municipal office after midday, if one had to send anything by cousin rather than post. The papers were the same papers. The time around them had changed.

One envelope was marked in his small, exact hand: Muna. Another: if needed. Maryam looked at the second.

"What is in 'if needed'?" she asked.

"Cash," he said.

"For what?"

"For needing."

Aunt Widad said, "That is not a category. It is a superstition."

"It is a category if the bank shuts before one's turn."

Her mother closed her eyes. "Must everything at breakfast become an omen?"

"It is not an omen," Hanna said. "It is an envelope."

Leila came down late and asked, before she had reached the table, whether the hotel was still there.
"Part of it," said Hanna.
"Which part?"
"The part not blown up."
"That is not a proper answer."
"It is the answer I have."
Amina came in with the tea tray and, because her labour had become more pressed since the explosion, no longer wasted time setting things down gently. Cups met saucers with more force than civility preferred.
"I went by the lower market," she said as she poured. "Three shops were still shut. At the butcher's they said a cousin's daughter is sleeping in the back room because the family sent the girls away from Musrara for a few nights. One hears the same quarter twice now."
"That has always been true," said Maryam's mother.
"Not like this."
Before he left, the telephone rang. It was his sister. Maryam knew at once from the way he said only her name, not the affectionate title, that it was family and not office. He took the receiver into the hall.
"No, do not come this minute," he said. "I said keep a case ready, not drag the children through noon traffic for the pleasure of my staircase. ... Yes, I know what your landlord thinks. ... No. Not everything. Papers, some linen, what the girls need, and the blue case if it is still under the bed."
He listened for a while and then said more softly, "I know. That is why I am saying it now and not tonight."
When he returned, Maryam pretended to be occupied with the sugar bowl and knew he knew she was pretending.
"She is frightened," she said.
"She is practical enough to call frightened something else."
"And what are you calling it?"
"A blue case with papers in it."
At eleven they went to the Khoury cousin's house.
It stood only a little lower than theirs and yet felt, that morning, to belong to a different jurisdiction of grief. At their own gate the quarter still managed middle-class

reticence: doors half-open, bells rung properly, news carried in folded voices. At the Khourys' there was no such illusion left. Men stood in the road not because they had business there but because there was nowhere else for the agitation to go. Inside came that compound sound by which mourning houses declared themselves long before one crossed the threshold: the clink of cups, the murmur of names, one woman weeping too rhythmically, another answering her too efficiently.

Her mother went in first, card in glove, face set to the correct degree of injured dignity. Aunt Widad followed with the little bag of linen and soap she had assembled at dawn. Maryam came last and had the absurd sensation that the house itself must recognise in her something other than condolences. Houses knew nothing. But guilt disliked anonymity and was always trying to make the world more perceptive than it was.

They were led through to the morning room one by one because the space could not accommodate a whole houseful of care. Aunt Salma sat propped upright on a chaise, one arm in a sling, a strip of white bandage disappearing beneath the hair above one ear. On the small table beside her stood a glass of water in which dust had settled despite the cloth laid over it. That detail undid Maryam more quickly than the bandage. Dust in water. The hotel had entered the room at the level of glass.

Aunt Salma received them with the offended endurance of women who believe suffering is intolerable largely because it has been administered so incompetently. "I look ridiculous," she said. "If one must be blown through a corridor, the least heaven could do is improve the result."

Her mother bent and kissed her. "You look alive."

The room wanted narrative; Aunt Salma would grant only fact. She had gone downstairs because the room-service kettle had a temperament like the British administration. Nawal had remained upstairs because she said she would rather drink cold tea than wear the slippers on the corridor tiles. No one spoke.

Then Aunt Salma looked at Maryam with eyes horribly lucid despite the swelling and the sleeplessness. "You were to come," she said.

There was no accusation in the tone. That was what made it worse. She spoke as one states an item not collected from the stationer or a dress not fetched from the seamstress: an expectation interrupted by later fact.

Maryam answered before she had formed the sentence. "I know."

Aunt Salma gave the smallest nod, as if acknowledging receipt of information she already possessed, and then looked away. Whatever chance there might have been to convert guilt into speech closed there. There was no scene to be had. Only sequence again, monstrous in its ordinariness.

When they rose to go, Aunt Salma opened her eyes again and said to Maryam, "If I had known the hotel would make such a fuss, I should have kept her at home."

Her mother answered for both of them. "It was not your keeping that failed."

Outside, from one higher point Maryam could see, beyond roofs and walls and trees unwilling to participate in history, a pale interruption in the familiar line of the neighbourhood where the hotel had stood. Not ruin exactly. Rather an error in the composition. She turned her head away before her mother could tell her not to stare.

Mrs Farah was coming up the lane with another woman from the parish, both in decent black. In previous weeks the sight of Mrs Farah would have tightened something mean and anticipatory in Maryam. Now the older woman's watchfulness seemed to have been partially nationalised by catastrophe. Surveillance had not disappeared. It had merely found larger objects.

Mrs Farah pressed her lips to Maryam's mother's cheek and then said to Maryam only, "You look tired, habibti. Go home before people start explaining the city to you from the pavement."

It was almost mercy. That, too, felt unsettling.

At home the bank file sat where Hanna had left it in the morning, though a fraction farther from the good lamp, as if even the sideboard had accepted that paper must, for at least a day, show modesty. Leila had been allowed bread and jam in the nursery because downstairs conversations were judged not fit for children. Amina had changed the cloth on the dining table. Someone had delivered a small basket of oranges from an uncle in Baq'a because fruit was one of the few gifts left to people once flowers had become competitive.

Nadia's letter still advised papers first and silver second. Unpleasant. The word lay on the page like something upholstered. She folded the letter back into its thin blue envelope and placed it beside Nawal's card. For the first time the two pieces of paper seemed to belong to the same universe. Before Semiramis, Beirut had been elsewhere and Nawal had been here. After Semiramis, both had begun to occupy the same territory of postponed life.

It was after luncheon, when her mother had at last submitted to a half-hour's lying down, that Hanna returned and said there were still two drawers in Yusef's desk that ought to be cleared before the damp destroyed the rest. The upstairs tenant had left for relatives in Bethlehem. The clerk wanted the French lease translated in full. And Tariq had the duplicate key.

"He can meet there tomorrow at three if the roads remain open enough," Hanna said. "I will join later if I can."

Her mother said at once, "Then it can wait."

"Not indefinitely."

"Everything can wait one day more than you think."

Maryam almost laughed, because no sentence could have been less appropriate to the week they had just endured.

At three the next day the lane to Yusef's building held more people than it ought to have on a weekday afternoon, yet none of them moved quickly. Speed in Jerusalem had become suspicious.

Maryam carried a shopping bag because errands required cover. Inside were lamp wicks, an envelope to be posted, and the little list Aunt Widad had written. Every object in

the bag was real. None of it cancelled the less respectable truth that she was going to the flat because Tariq would be there.

The door was already unlocked. Tariq must have heard her on the landing because he opened it before she knocked.

For one ridiculous second she thought only: he looks tired. Not transformed by catastrophe, not ennobled, not visibly broken. Simply tired in the face, as though sleep had visited him only provisionally and left before dawn finished its work.

"You came."

Even so, she heard behind it the other sentence, the one he did not say: after all this, you came.

"So did you."

"I had the key."

"Useful men always do."

The room beyond seemed at first not altered enough. Yet what had shifted was plain after a second glance. Fewer small things remained. The framed photograph of Yusef's parents was gone. So was the little brass ashtray shaped like a shell. A drawer in the side table had been removed entirely and rested by the wall awaiting some future with fewer contents. Emptiness had begun not by grand subtraction but by the loss of trivial company.

On the round table he had already begun sorting. The categories from the earlier visits had multiplied. Not only bank, church, tenant, and municipal matters, but duplicated copies, things to be sent through relatives, and a new envelope in his hand marked by upper way if needed.

Maryam noticed it before she intended to. The handwriting was smaller than Hanna's and less forceful, but no less exact.

"What is in that one?" she asked.

"Copies of anything not worth losing to a road," Tariq said.

It was a practical answer. There was no reason she should have wanted anything else.

She and Tariq worked without hurry. That was the first great change. Before Semiramis, every hour with him had

contained within it a second invisible hour measuring its own scarcity. Now the hour moved differently. Not slower, exactly. More heavily. Each practical action arrived contaminated by the knowledge that delay had already been proved fatal elsewhere. They sorted nevertheless. One photograph into family. Another into uncertain. A small key into impossible.

After several minutes Tariq said, without lifting his eyes from the papers, "Khalil's brother lost two windows and says this now qualifies him for political wisdom."

"That sounds like a Jerusalem rule."

"It is becoming a Palestinian one."

She almost said Nawal's name and did not. The unsaid sat between them more densely than any spoken grief could have done. He reached for the lower drawer, stopped, and looked at her instead.

"I was sorry about Mrs Khoury's niece."

It was the correct phrase and the wrong scale. That was why it worked. He did not pretend to private claim over Nawal. He named relation and loss in the smallest socially legitimate measure.

"She said I was to come," Maryam answered.

His hand tightened very slightly on the envelopes. "I know."

"How?"

"Because you told me once the invitation had acquired a second date and then a third. Because after that one could infer."

"I did not go," she said.

"No."

There it was again, the terrible usefulness of yes and no between people who had already learnt that explanation would cheapen fact.

He moved to the window and opened the upper half an inch. "After the blast," he said, "everyone became very exact for six hours. Distances, numbers, cousins, routes. Then by evening everyone began lying again because precision was no longer enough to keep fear in order."

"Are you accusing me or the city?"

"The city. You would require more elegance than that."
She turned another photograph over. On the back Yusef had written only June and an address in French. "I think," she said slowly, "that I preferred thinking the city had done the refusing for me."
He shut the window. "Did it?"
"Yes."
"And?"
"And it turns out that still counts as refusal."
"I nearly wrote yesterday," he said.
It arrived not as confession but as fact placed among receipts.
"What stopped you?"
"You would not have needed one more piece of paper from me in a house full of the wrong kind."
That answer was so exact it felt almost indecent. He had understood precisely how his hand on a slip of paper would have entered the room at the wrong scale, bending catastrophe inward towards the personal. She disliked that he had understood. She disliked more that some part of her, lower and less moral than grief, had wanted him to fail in precisely that way.
"I kept your note," she said before prudence intervened.
He looked at her then, properly. "You should not have."
"I know."
"Do you?"
"Yes."
The room held. Nothing happened. Desire after Semiramis had ceased to depend on event. The knowledge that she had kept a note she ought to have discarded, and that he knew both the wrongness and the motive of it, was sufficient to alter the air between desk and mantel.
Footsteps sounded on the landing. It was Hanna.
He entered with his hat in hand and said, "Good. You have not yet set fire to the lease."
"Give us another quarter of an hour," said Tariq.
"You have twenty minutes."
Not because he had counted them, Maryam knew, but because that was how his care arrived: in bounded

extensions that acknowledged desire or fatigue or human need without granting them authority to govern the whole day.

"Can you still meet Khalil at the school before evening?" Hanna asked.

The question altered the room more than any private sentence could have done. It introduced, with total innocence, the existence of a second life measured not by Maryam's nerves or the flat's legitimacy but by another man's timetable.

Tariq answered at once. "I have to. He cannot stay late now. His mother is alone with the younger ones until his sister returns."

"My mother also dislikes late roads," he added.

"Quite right," said Hanna.

There it was again: duty, distributed without rhetoric. Maryam had known, of course, that Tariq possessed a family, a quarter, obligations not waiting politely at the edge of her own narrative. Yet what had passed between them had to date been made possible precisely by how little those obligations had entered the room except as rumour or margin. Now his mother existed not as biographical background but as a fact controlling his hour. A mother ironing while deciding what to carry. Hanna's sister with a blue case if needed. Girls sent to cousins. The practical had ceased to be separate from the fatal.

Hanna began retieing the packets while Tariq gathered his notebook and the copied sheets that belonged to the school rather than to Yusef's dead administration. The three of them stood for a moment in a small ridiculous triangle: husband, wife, lover, all with paper in hand. But there was no grand irony available to the room. Only work, roads, a mother waiting in another quarter, a child at home, and the indecent persistence of mutual recognition among all of it.

On the walk home the bag of lamp wicks seemed suddenly absurdly heavy for its contents. From one gate came the sound of a radio kept low as if volume itself might provoke further damage. At another, a woman was telling someone

over the telephone that her sister had gone to relatives "for a short while," using exactly the tone of people describing an absence already larger than their sentence.

At home Amina took the shopping bag and removed the lamp wicks, the envelope, Aunt Widad's list, and finally the useless little key Maryam had somehow brought back from Yusef's desk without deciding to. She held it up between thumb and forefinger.

"Does it open anything?"

"No one knows."

Amina dropped it into the pin dish beside the hall tray. "Then it will wait with the others."

Maryam stood in the hall looking at the pin dish. Upstairs Leila called for water. In the drawing room her mother began explaining to Aunt Widad why black ribbon had become impossible to buy in proper width.

She took Nawal's card from her pocket and, after a moment, did not put it back on the hall table. Instead she placed it in the drawer of the little escritoire in the morning room, among unanswered letters and envelopes kept because the paper was still good. Not hidden, exactly. Removed from circulation. When she closed the drawer she saw, reflected faintly in the darkened window, not drama, not fate, not the shape of a woman about to make a great decision, but something smaller and therefore more dangerous: a woman still arranging objects correctly while the order that had trained her to do so was beginning to fail in earnest.

That evening, after Leila had finally slept and Hanna had come home later than the soup forgave, Maryam stood for a minute at the nursery door and listened to the child breathe. From the dining room came the faint sound of her husband flattening one last paper with the side of his hand before putting it away. From beyond the shutters came a city learning, room by room, that afterward was not a pause between one event and the next. It was a new climate.

And they had entered it carrying, as people always did, the same small domestic luggage with which they had meant to survive the old one.

CHAPTER XI

Tariq's Mother

By the time Tariq reached the school again the afternoon had already developed that new bad habit by which hours no longer belonged wholly to themselves. A day was no longer school, then home, then evening. It was rumour distributed through sequence. A father arriving at the gate with some piece of information that had improved while being carried. A clerk refusing to stamp a paper because he had heard the municipality might shut early, though no one could say on whose authority. A boy sent home before the lesson finished because his mother had decided that a son under a roof was safer than a son under grammar. Nothing ended when it was supposed to end. Things merely changed jurisdiction.

Khalil had remained in the front office through what ought to have been the last hour, his coat still on because taking it off would have suggested confidence in the shape of the day. The room smelled of wet wool, chalk, cheap ink, and the stale sugar from the tea they had both neglected since noon. A new stack of notices waited to be copied because one father had objected to the phrase routine until further notice on the grounds that routine now constituted a political claim.

"What does he propose?" Tariq asked. "Disorder until further refinement?"

"He proposes that his son be exempt from whatever sentence proves inaccurate by next week."

"Then he should remove the boy from history."

"He has tried. The child keeps coming back through the gate."

Tariq corrected the English line for the third time. He could feel the drag in his own head now, not dramatic enough to call fatigue and not slight enough to ignore. The flat had altered him more than he liked. Not because of Maryam only, though she was there in the pressure of it. Because the room at Yusef's had ceased to be the quiet

annex in which usefulness and concealment could still pretend to belong to separate orders. After Semiramis, everything came into the room carrying its proper weight. Mothers. Roads. Children. Envelopes marked for need. The city had grown tired of letting people visit compartments one by one.

Khalil watched him for a moment, then pushed the smaller of the paraffin tins across the desk. "Take that and go to your mother before dark."

"I had a message at dawn from her neighbour. She asked if I was coming today."

"And you are still here."

"I am here to strengthen the school's prose."

"The school can endure bad prose for one evening. Your mother cannot be expected to reason with dusk."

"She reasons better with it than most men do with noon."

"That is not the point." Khalil looked at him directly. "She said nothing useful. Which from mothers is never a good sign."

Tariq took the paraffin tin, because refusing practical help in the name of male pride was one of the more tiresome ways men disguised fear. As he left, Khalil said, "Do not stop at the lower road if a crowd has formed."

"I know how to recognise a crowd."

"You know how to recognise an argument," Khalil said. "These are no longer always the same thing."

His mother's building had begun, like every building now, to declare its own provisional status by small rearrangements. A folded blanket occupied the cane chair by the window. One small case sat near it as though merely resting between ordinary uses. On the sideboard lay a parcel wrapped in newspaper and tied with shoe ribbon. When he set down the paraffin and paper bag, his mother said at once, "That is not for immediate alarm. It is merely the better preserves, because once one begins thinking of where jars are kept, one realises how many idiotic places one has trusted."

He took off his coat. "Have you eaten?"

"I am not an infant."

"That is not an answer."
"Lentils at noon. Bread at four. Tea was delayed because apparently the nation now moves according to your timetable."
Only then did he see the cup on the table beside her. The old one. Thick china once cream and now the resigned colour of repeated boiling. The chip on the rim had grown broader at one edge and dark with tea where the glaze had gone. He picked it up before sitting.
"This should have been thrown out months ago."
"It still holds tea."
"It also holds your blood if you forget the side."
"My mouth remembers where not to go."
"That is not a defence."
"It is a method. Sit down. You are standing as though you have brought an inspection."
He did not sit at once. He moved first through the room with the familiar irritation of a man who knew the objects too well to leave them as they were and too well to believe that changing them constituted real protection. He checked the window latch. He moved the chair away from the draught. He set the paraffin in the corner where a leak could ruin only one floorboard rather than all of them. This, he knew, soothed her more than his sentences did. Practical action obeyed a grammar she trusted.
Then he put the new cup, still wrapped, on the side table.
"What is that?"
"A replacement."
She narrowed her eyes. "For whom?"
"For the object whose retirement I am announcing tonight."
She opened the parcel at once because curiosity had always outranked indignation in her, and produced a plain white cup with no beauty to it whatsoever.
"It looks municipal," she said.
"It looks incapable of cutting you."
"So do some people. They still manage it."
He took the old mug from her hand. For a second his grip remained around it and something older than annoyance

moved through him. He remembered it on his father's desk in the municipal office when he had once been taken in as a boy to see where stamped paper went after leaving other people's houses. Later, when the handle loosened, the mug had been demoted to the house and then, by some family law no one had written, to Tariq himself during his student years, when tea at midnight had counted as method and deprivation as character. One did not think, in youth, that objects remained because people could not quite spare the cost of replacing them. One imagined continuity where there was often only thrift.

But instead of discarding it he carried it to the kitchen sink and set it by the basin.

On the kitchen table lay a saucepan, half a loaf, the sugar tin, and an envelope weighted under the salt. He knew the hand before reading it. His sister. He brought the envelope back unopened.

His mother opened the letter and read it with the moving lips she would have denied possessing. While she read, he poured the tea and found himself using the new cup for her and the old chipped mug for himself, simply because the old one was there and because reform was usually inflicted first upon the people one loved most.

"She says the girls are well," his mother said. "Her landlord is becoming theatrical. She has packed one case and hidden it from the younger one, who apparently believes trunks are invitations to climb."

"She should have packed two."

"She has not got two that shut."

"I can find one."

"Out of what? The generous ruins of your income?"

There it was, not ingratitude but the daily mathematics by which she defended herself against dependence. One objected to the cost before accepting the help, or else help began to look too much like power.

He went to the bedroom. The sensible coat had been left hanging with its hem brushing the floor. On the dresser lay the small inventory of old age performed without theatre: spectacles in the tin case, keys on black ribbon, the

handkerchief ironed into squares too exact for daily use, the prayer book with the rent receipt serving as marker exactly where he had expected not to find it. He took the receipt out and held it up.
"It was in the prayer book."
"It was near me and therefore safe."
"It was near the Gospel of John and therefore disguised."
He checked the drawer of the little chest where she kept passport, property copy, doctor's certificate, and the letters from his sister tied separately as if offspring deserved their own archive. The passport was there. The property copy was not.
He felt the first cold touch of true anger. "Where is the copy of the deed?"
"With the priest," she said from the doorway behind him.
He turned too fast. "Why is the copy of the deed with a priest?"
"Because Father Boutros said the church safe was drier than my sideboard and because respectable institutions are useful when one has paid respectability for years."
"And you did not think to mention it?"
"You did not ask what I had sent to the church, only whether I had eaten. A mother answers the question presented."
He closed his eyes for one second, not in patience but in the fatigue that stood where shouting might otherwise have stood. When he looked again she had already interpreted the silence correctly and moved half a step towards him.
"It was not reckless," she said. "Three copies were made. One went with Father Boutros, one is with your cousin's husband, and one is in the sewing box because no thief respects darning."
For one instant he nearly laughed. Then the anger dissolved because, absurdly, the arrangement was not wholly foolish. It was merely the city's newest logic translated into maternal form: duplication dispersed through trust rather than system. His mother packed as if survival were an interruption. Hanna packed as if

interruption itself had become administration. She was no less serious for being less systematic.
"Tell me these things."
"I am telling you now."
"After the question."
"Yes," she said. "That is how questions function."
He opened the small case by the chair. Inside lay two blouses, one wool shawl, the leather purse with the faulty clasp, a packet of letters tied with blue thread, the little silver-backed brush that had belonged to her own mother, and, to his weary admiration, a wrapped bundle of tea reserved for Lent and good guests.
"No medicine," he said.
"I have medicine in the kitchen cupboard."
"Then you do not have medicine in the case."
He went to the cupboard himself, found the aspirin tin, the stomach tablets, the vial for her cough, and put half in the case. She watched in silence, which from her did not mean consent. It meant she was judging whether opposition would cost more strength than it pleased her to spend.
When he had finished, she said, "You are becoming like men who fold disaster into corners before it has the decency to arrive."
He knew what she meant. Men like Hanna, though she would not have named him. Men whose answer to uncertainty was envelope, list, key, duplicate, timed return. It occurred to him, with a distaste he could not immediately sort, that he had begun without noticing to resemble precisely the species from which he had once differentiated himself by language.
"I am becoming like someone who prefers corners to panic," he said.
"And what are you becoming besides practical?"
He disliked the question because mothers asked it without having to declare whether they meant politics, love, fatigue, or age.
"Tired," he said.
"That is visible."
"So there is no need to discuss it."

"There is no need to discuss rainfall either. Yet one still prefers a roof."

A knock sounded at the outer door. Not the bell. A knuckle knock, rapid and neighbourly. It was Umm Nabil from the landing below, headscarf crooked with speed and one hand still flour-white from dough.

"My brother is going by car tomorrow if God and the engine permit," she said. "Only to Jericho for now. He says if there are letters for anyone there or in Amman he can take them as far as the bridge."

"At present we are still local enough for the post to pretend to exist," his mother said.

"Yes," Umm Nabil answered, lowering her voice without reducing its urgency. "But one likes alternatives."

When she had gone, his mother remained by the door a second longer than necessary.

"Write your sister another note," he said.

"I wrote her on Monday."

"And now it is not Monday."

But she went to the writing table all the same. He trimmed the lamp while she found paper, and the room settled into one of those domestic conjunctions by which families preserve themselves without declaring sentiment: the mother writing a note she would claim unnecessary, the son holding the lamp globe up to the light to see where soot had gathered, both pretending this was no more than evening.

She stopped writing and said, "How does one word 'reassure' without sounding stupid?"

"One does not use the word. One says something ordinary."

"Ordinary is now indecently difficult."

He wrote two clean lines in the margin for her to scale herself against. We are well. Do not act on rumours. If matters alter, you will hear again. She read them and said, "That sounds exactly like you and not at all like me."

"It sounds like safety."

"It sounds like a clerk with children."

The sentence settled where her best cruelties often settled: not as wound but as recognition. Safety. Clerk. Children. Maryam with the bag of lamp wicks. Hanna with the envelope marked if needed. Himself measuring paraffin, sorting medicine into a case, correcting notices so that panic might at least be bilingual. What, precisely, remained of the man he had imagined when he first began mistaking moral clarity for a future?

His mother saw something land and turned the subject by force. "Take the old mug with you."

"Why would I take your old mug with me?"

"Because if you leave it here I shall continue to use it out of laziness and you will continue to lecture me out of principle. Also, it was your father's office mug before the handle went and then yours when you were studying for examinations and believed tea itself conferred advancement. You may as well take it back."

He wrapped it, because argument would have taken longer than newspaper, and placed it in the satchel between the exercise books and the foolscap.

She watched him do it and then said, with a sudden plainness stripped of her usual defensive embroidery, "Do not stay on the road longer than required just because you are not yet ready to arrive anywhere."

He looked at her at once.

She did not lower her eyes. "A mother need not know the name of a thing to notice its method."

There were many answers available and all of them bad. He chose the only sentence that preserved both truth and uselessness.

"I have a great deal to arrive at, apparently."

"That is what worries me."

When he rose to leave, she let him button his coat before standing. This, in her ceremonial system, was a sign of respect rather than weakness: one did not embrace a man half dressed for the road. She kissed his cheek once, dryly, and then adjusted the scarf at his throat because maternal affection, like most durable affections, preferred disguise.

On the stair he heard her bolt the door at once. That too comforted him more than any spoken reassurance.

The street had thinned while he was upstairs. Not emptied. Merely tightened. At the corner by the baker's, Khalil was waiting with that particular stillness by which men announced they had not been waiting at all.

"I told you to go home," Tariq said.

"I went home. Then I came out again because home had developed opinions."

They walked together as far as the tram stop, though neither intended to take the tram. Company after dark had become an argument one made with the street.

"My brother has moved his wife and daughters to his uncle's for the week," Khalil said.

"For the week."

"For the week," Khalil repeated, both men understanding the sentence's species of dishonesty and the mercy it performed.

When Tariq reached his own room, he unpacked the satchel by habit. Exercise books. Foolscap. Rolled notices. Yusef's copied lease. The small parcel of tea his mother had slipped into the side pocket when he was not looking. And finally the mug, wrapped in yesterday's newspaper whose headlines already belonged to a previous register of alarm. He set the mug on the washstand.

In that room, which held no inheritance and no child and no woman obliged to his return, the chipped thing looked oddly authoritative, as if it had come not from a kitchen but from a system of claims older than the city's current violence. Not memory exactly. Not comfort. More binding than either. Evidence that he, too, belonged to repetition, dependency, and the practical ridiculousness of carrying damaged necessities forward because nobody had had the time, money, or moral clarity to do otherwise.

He washed it out, though it was already clean, and placed it upside down on the folded towel by the basin.

Then he sat at the table and drew the parent circular towards him, but before reading the first line he took from

his coat pocket the duplicate key to Yusef's flat and set it beside the mug.

The two objects looked absurd together: one chipped cup, one correct key. Yet together they seemed to state, more exactly than any sentence he might have written, the new shape of his life. Not one room or one duty, but several, all claiming urgency, none willing to declare itself temporary, and all of them now travelling with him in the same small bag.

He left them there while the lamp burned low.

Outside, somewhere in the quarter beyond his own, a wireless voice entered another room and another and another, not announcing catastrophe exactly but teaching houses how to imagine it.

Inside, the mug dried by the basin and the key waited by the papers.

Neither explained anything. Both had become unavoidable.

CHAPTER XII

Thinning Rooms

The first room to go was the spare room.

Nobody announced this. In houses like theirs rooms did not disappear; they were reclassified. A room ceased to be guest and became practical. A bed ceased to be decorative and became available. A cupboard ceased to be ornamental and became somewhere papers might be hidden from damp, cousins, and curiosity. Catastrophe, when it wanted entry into respectable households, did not begin by carrying sofas into the street. It began by asking whether one really needed so much air around a side table.

Maryam saw the change before breakfast because the door had been left half open and Amina, coming up from the back passage with the coal scuttle, nudged it wider with her foot. The room that had held the better eiderdown, Aunt Widad's occasional indignation, and Leila's proprietary claims upon rainy afternoons now contained Hanna's sister's blue case, a folded camp bed, one basket tied with string, and three bundles of their own linen stacked on the chair by the window. The little escritoire had been moved out to the landing. A grey coat hung over the bedpost. Ibrahim's satchel sat beneath it with one arithmetic book half visible, as though childhood itself had arrived apologetically and meant to take up no more room than necessary.

Maryam stood in the doorway fastening her cuff.

Amina said, from behind her, "Do not look at me as though I invited them. I only made the bed."

"When did this happen?"

"Before six. Hanna Bey came with the case. The boy was asleep against his shoulder like a sack with opinions. Your mother said not to wake the whole house if practical misery could be carried quietly."

"Huda is staying?"

"For a few nights," Amina said in the tone used by those repeating a phrase whose dishonesty they recognised and

honoured for trying. "The mason has still not returned. Also the landlord has discovered that uncertainty may be charged extra."

On the chair lay Huda's brown shawl, carefully darned at one corner, and beside it the little tin in which she kept needles, buttons, black thread, white thread, and the stoic debris of widowhood. The room had altered species in a single morning.

Leila appeared on the landing with one shoe on and one in hand.

"Why is Ibrahim in my rainy room?"

"It is not your rainy room," said Amina.

"It is when it rains."

"It is now your cousin's room until his ceiling remembers Christianity."

Downstairs her mother was already at the breakfast table, properly dressed not because callers were expected but because mornings no longer belonged safely to the family alone. Aunt Widad had taken the marmalade into custody. Hanna stood at the sideboard with his notebook open, making two columns so narrow they looked less like sentences than instructions issued to reluctant facts.

"So," said Aunt Widad when Maryam entered, "we have begun living by annexation."

Her mother said, "We have begun living by family."

"That too. Though family is annexation conducted with soup."

Hanna looked up. "Huda came before dawn. The plaster in the back room is worse, the landlord is pretending weather is a personal preference, and the surveyor has still not returned."

Her mother said, "She could perfectly well have come at nine."

"At nine the street had already begun discussing itself. At six it still had enough shame to mind its own staircases."

He said this without edge. That was almost always Hanna's advantage. Even when he was right he refused the theatre of correctness.

Amina came in with the tea and said, "Civilisation now depends on who still has dry walls."

At breakfast the house reduced itself in small humiliations. Huda had no established place because no one had yet admitted she now required one. Ibrahim's cup had been borrowed from the back shelf and did not match the others. The bread basket had been moved nearer the middle because more hands must now reach it. Nothing dramatic had happened. No cart had unloaded mattresses at the gate. Yet the table had begun to perform arithmetic. Huda came down last with the cheeks of a woman who had slept badly in borrowed space. She had tied her hair with too much care, which meant she was defending dignity through precision.

"You may stay the week," Maryam's mother said at once.

Huda answered at once too. "No. Only until the surveyor comes."

"Yes," said Aunt Widad. "Which is what women say when they expect to remain long enough not to die of damp."

Hanna passed her the jam as if refusing both pity and embarrassment. "Stay until the room is usable or the landlord acquires a conscience. The second is unlikely, so let us proceed on the first assumption."

After breakfast Hanna gathered the bank file, two tied packets from Uncle Yusef's case, and the list he had been compiling before tea.

"I am going to the flat after the office," he said. "The priest wants the devotional books boxed. Elias says the cousin's man will come again for the chest. Tariq is meeting me there."

Then he looked at Maryam. "If you can come after luncheon, come. I do not want the wrong French letter packed with the right piety."

Her mother said, "Must that flat still be attended to as though your uncle were merely late?"

"His papers still behave as though he were."

"It is not healthy."

"No," said Hanna. "It is administrative."

Huda, who had the tact of the newly dependent, said quietly, "You need not bring anything back tonight. The house is already breathing through one nostril."
Aunt Widad glanced towards the stairs. "That is because the other nostril now belongs to family."
When the others had dispersed and the morning broke into its usual smaller claims, Maryam stood in the hall and saw that the house had already narrowed. Huda's blue case was farther in, but Ibrahim's shoes remained by the umbrella stand as if announcing occupation in the least ceremonial manner possible. The corridor no longer offered passage; it negotiated it.
By noon the weather had chosen the meanest possible register: neither rain nor light, only a colourless cold which made every interior look temporary. On the road below the church Maryam passed a handcart piled with middling suitcases — not trunks, not exile made visible, only the sort of luggage bought by families who still intended to return for the better things later. No one stared. This was the new indecency: scenes that would once have gathered commentary now passed as part of the road's furniture.
The sitting room of the flat no longer looked like Yusef's life interrupted. It looked like Yusef's life translated into a smaller language. Two bookcases were half stripped. The little side table under the lamp held only one stack of municipal papers tied in ribbon. The back-room chest was being manoeuvred through the inner doorway by Tariq and Elias when Maryam stepped in.
"Higher," Elias said.
"I would if the laws of weight altered for Christians," Tariq answered.
Maryam moved aside and held the door. "Should I retreat and permit theology to finish the task?"
Tariq looked up at once and the strain went out of his face without leaving softness behind. "No. Only hold the frame before my virtue damages it."
The chest went through, leaving behind cedar, trapped dust, and the stale smell of linen kept too long in closed drawers. Without the armchair, without the chest, with

half the shelves emptied, the flat had lost a category of excuse. Before, one might still have pretended it remained a dead man's administrative inconvenience. Now the room was becoming a place one entered knowingly.

On the window-sill stood a mug that did not belong to Yusef. It was enamel once white and now undecided, chipped at the lip and carrying the sort of ordinary authority only repeated use could confer.

"That is not my uncle's," Maryam said.

"No."

"You have brought your own mug to another man's flat?"

"There were only saucers left."

"That is not a defence. It is a confession of standards."

He shifted a row of books before answering. "The kitchen contained six saucers, three plates, a teapot with political leanings, and one glass too thick for self-respect. I chose continuity."

A mug meant repetition. It meant one had begun providing for a room's deficiencies from one's own diminished store.

On the table lay Hanna's list: church books, account books, desk drawers, linen, journals. Maryam removed her gloves and moved to the lower shelf. "Which books to the church?"

"Everything devotional, anything in Arabic too damp to survive another winter here, and the sermons with your uncle's marginal insults to the Patriarch."

"That seems fair. The church ought to inherit what insulted it."

They began to sort. Prayer books to one chair. Journals and grammars to another. For a few minutes the work itself protected them. That, too, had altered since Semiramis. Before, labour in this room had been camouflage. Now labour and danger had entered the same sentence.

On the mantel the missing ashtray had left a pale circle in the dust. Rooms registered absence with too much patience. They held its outline until someone wiped it away. Several volumes had been taken from the lower

shelf, leaving a gap too tidy to be accidental. The tram ticket still marked Yusef's place in La Bruyère.
"You have not touched that shelf," she said.
"No."
"Why?"
"Because books give the impression of permanence while they are watching everything else leave."
She took one volume out, dusted the top edge with her handkerchief, and put it back. The action was pointless. She knew it while doing it.
From below came the cry of a paraffin seller, then another voice answering from a window with the impatience of a woman who no longer trusted any man to carry exactly what he had announced.
"And what do you object to?" she asked, not knowing entirely where the question had come from.
He was silent a moment. One now heard the difference between answering and choosing an answer.
"Waste," he said at last.
"In fathers?"
"In sentences. In routes. In the amount of life currently being spent explaining obvious things to frightened people who would rather be frightened elegantly."
She ought not to have smiled. It came anyway. He saw it and looked back down at the papers as if courtesy required granting it privacy.
From below came the scrape and complaint that signalled the cousin's man had arrived with a cart. By the time Hanna came in, carrying one envelope and the office smell of cold air and bad wool, the chest had gone and the back room looked one degree barer.
"The surveyor saw Huda's room," Hanna said at once. "Repairs can be done, which is his way of charging hope. So she stays."
"For now," said Maryam.
There was the phrase again, as inevitable now as tea.
Hanna opened the desk drawer and found exactly what Yusef would have hidden from order: theatre programmes, parish notices, one ribbon-tied packet of letters, and loose

paper that had outlived both relevance and embarrassment. He turned the letters in his hand, then offered them across to Maryam.
"These are probably for family rather than storage."
She took the letters and put them in her bag without opening them.
"The devotional books go to the church this evening," Hanna said. "The ledger copies to my office tomorrow. Tariq, can you stay another half hour and finish the journals if I go now?"
"Yes."
"Lock the outer door when you leave. Elias says the bolt holds. I prefer proof."
Maryam said, "It is almost dark."
"Yes," he answered, hearing perhaps that she had meant more and declining, as always, to assist the sentence into existence.
He left with the books and his correct office step, which made even staircases sound procedural.
After he had gone, the room changed again. Not into romance. Into vacancy. A third presence had left, and because it had been the legitimising one, every harmless object acquired a different surface. The tied letters were in her bag. Tariq's mug stood on the sill. The back room had become too visible through the open doorway — stripped of the chest, the rug rolled aside, one pale square on the wall where something had hung for years.
"We should finish," Tariq said.
So they returned to the journals, working faster not from impatience but from the obscure propriety by which people under pressure accelerate harmless tasks in order not to examine why harmless tasks have become difficult. When the last journals had been stacked there was nowhere obvious left to put them. The side table, the chair, the cleared shelf, all now looked temporary in a manner that made temporary arrangements feel dishonest.
Maryam moved to the back-room doorway before she had decided to. Without the chest and with the rug rolled aside, the room showed its dimensions too clearly. One could see

the pale square on the wall. The wardrobe door stood open over two hangers and a trapped smell of cedar. The room no longer pretended to belong to an old bachelor and his paper difficulties.

"Maryam," Tariq said.

He did not often use her name in rooms that could hear it. She turned.

"We should go."

The sentence was right. It was also, she understood, spoken a fraction later than correctness demanded. Not because he was weak. Because he had also understood the room.

In the kitchen he made tea because departing too quickly would have made haste itself into a confession. He brought back the chipped mug for himself and one thick glass for her. The tea was too strong. On the cleared corner of the table lay Yusef's French notebook, the parish receipt, the key ring, and Tariq's mug. There was no impropriety in any of it. That was the danger. A room did not become dangerous only when rules were broken. It became dangerous when rules could still be obeyed and meaning moved anyway.

At the door she checked the windows. On the landing the key turned too easily.

"You are going by the convent side?" he asked.

"Yes."

"So am I."

That could still be said. That was perhaps the last innocence.

They walked as far as the corner by which routes honestly diverged. The cold had sharpened. Houses showed their light reluctantly, as if illumination itself had grown expensive.

"The room looks different every time," Maryam said.

"It is being reduced."

"At home the spare room has gone. At your mother's the front room is occupied. At the flat even the teacups have left."

"The teacups left before the ethics."

She laughed despite herself, softly and only once. He did not look at her while the laugh existed. That restraint made it worse.

At the next corner he said, "Do not come tomorrow if Hanna cannot stay."

"Why?"

"Because the room is now too honest."

Before she could answer he added, "And because rooms this empty encourage people to misunderstand their architecture."

At her gate he inclined his head and went on without turning. Inside, the hallway had narrowed again. Ibrahim's geography book lay open on the landing chair, claiming the furniture with homework. In the dining room Hanna was already back, copying from one ledger into another as though the city's altered acoustics were merely another clerical nuisance.

"You are early," Maryam said.

"No," he answered without looking up. "You are late."

The words landed cleanly because they were true and because he said them in the register of schedule rather than suspicion.

"I stayed to finish the journals."

"Yes. Tariq told me the cousin's man finally accepted the chest."

That small shock — that Tariq had spoken to him after she left, that the two men still inhabited each other's practical world without ceremony — made her set down her gloves more carefully than necessary.

At supper the house performed the arithmetic of reduced space. Ibrahim's elbow and Leila's grievance competed over the same piece of table. Huda apologised for existing by way of helping. Her mother spoke of routes and prices and whose cousin had moved in with whom.

Leila said, "If Ibrahim stays in the rainy room, where shall my doll sleep when it rains?"

"In your room," Maryam said.

"It does not like your room."

"Why?"

"There is too much marriage in it."

For one second nobody moved. Then Aunt Widad laughed so hard she had to put down her spoon. Hanna went briefly still and then resumed slicing bread with the patience of a man who had decided that childhood, like weather, must be survived without rhetoric.

Later, when the children were at last asleep and the house entered the uneasy quiet now called evening, Maryam went upstairs. The spare-room door stood open. Huda had taken the narrow bed and given Ibrahim the camp bed. The blue case was tucked under the window. The room already looked as though it had been occupied for longer than a day, because necessity settled faster than comfort ever did.

In her own room she saw another small reduction. Under the bed, beside the hat boxes, stood a medium case her mother had evidently decided to air and keep ready without yet announcing for what. Readiness had become the household form of prayer. On the dressing table the jewellery drawer no longer closed properly because a bundle of deeds in copied envelopes had been slid beneath the tray. The wardrobe contained the same dresses, the same coats — yet some hidden quota of space had been withdrawn from it, as if every room in the house had been informed that appearance must now make way for contingency.

She sat on the edge of the bed and took Nawal's card from the pocket of the coat she had worn to the Khourys. She placed it in the drawer beside the brush. Then, because the act felt like classification rather than thought, she took it out again and left it on the dressing table. The dead no longer stayed where one put them.

On the chair lay the shawl she had worn to the flat. It smelled faintly of cold stair, strong tea, and dust. She thought of the flat one degree barer than before: the absent chest, the cleared sill, the pale square on the wall, the mug on the windowsill as if somebody had begun, impermissibly, to supply the room from his own reduced life.

The city was not removing rooms. It was removing alibis.
When Hanna came in he loosened his tie and asked only, "Did the journals finish?"
"Yes."
"And the back room?"
"The chest is gone. The wardrobe Saturday."
He nodded, as though two facts properly entered might, for the moment, be borne. Then he said, not looking at her, "I told Tariq not to remain there tomorrow unless I could get there myself."
For one second she thought he had said more than he had. Then the sentence arranged itself into its offered form: practical, correct, about rooms and timing and no more.
"Yes," she said.
He set his cufflinks in the tray. "When rooms grow empty people begin to behave as though emptiness were permission."
It was the sort of sentence he might have spoken about offices, waiting rooms, or archives after luncheon. She could not tell whether he knew what he had said in relation to her, to Tariq, to the flat, to none of these, or merely to rooms as a class of problem. That uncertainty was perhaps his deepest gift to her, and it was not a gift she could use.
"Hanna," she said, and then stopped.
He looked up.
Nothing usable followed. Not because there was nothing true to say. Because truth now arrived divided by circumstance into portions too ugly for speech.
"What?"
"Nothing."
He studied her one second too long for comfort and one second too briefly for certainty. Then he turned down the lamp.
In the dark, the house sounded thinner. Not emptier. Worse than empty. Precisely occupied. The wrong people in the right rooms, the right people in rooms no longer innocent, and every door still closing in the old order while the uses on the other side had already changed.
Maryam lay awake longer than the cold justified.

When she slept, she dreamt not of rubble or roads or hotels, but of walking through a sequence of rooms in which each door opened not onto another chamber but onto a narrower version of the one before.

CHAPTER XIII

The Price of Seeing

By the following Thursday the flat had become a subject at breakfast in the same way weather and illness had once been: not dramatic enough to stop the meal, not minor enough to leave unmentioned. Huda and Ibrahim were still in the spare room. Her mother had begun referring to this as temporary with the fervour of a woman who knew that repetition was often the only furniture available to dignity. Aunt Widad had brought string, labels, and an opinion regarding trunks. In the middle of all this Hanna said, as though reading out a matter no more morally charged than lamp oil, that the wardrobe in Uncle Yusef's back room would finally be taken that afternoon and the last of the church books had to be sorted before Father Elias developed a doctrine concerning delay.

He looked at Maryam only after the sentence had made itself practical. "The family letters are still in your bag, I think. Bring them. I do not want grievance from Cairo packed with devotional material."

Her mother said at once, "Must there still be afternoons at that flat?"

"There must be one more," Hanna answered. "Perhaps two. The cousin's man is coming for the wardrobe. The church porter is coming for the books. The bank file must be copied again because the manager now finds consolation in stamps. If there is anything left to sort after I leave, Tariq can finish it."

The sentence might once have seemed harmless. It did not now. Her mother buttered her bread with a steadier hand

than the occasion deserved. "If there is anything left," she said, "it can wait until daylight and masculine supervision."

"It has already waited for both," said Aunt Widad. "That is why it still exists."

Leila, who had been dipping crusts into coffee no child was supposed to have, looked up and asked whether Uncle Yusef would know where his shirts were once the wardrobe went. Amina, setting down the eggs, said that if the dead knew anything they generally had the decency not to complain. Aunt Widad replied that they complained through cupboards because the living never put things back where they found them.

Maryam lowered her eyes to her plate because breakfast had already done the day's first injury: it had made the flat ordinary again by assigning it a time, a list, and a sequence. That was how this family survived everything. One broke disaster into errands until it could sit beside marmalade without causing scandal. Yet beneath that useful brutality another truth had begun insisting on itself. The room had ceased to be merely Yusef's administrative afterlife. By being emptied, it had become too exposed.

After breakfast the house broke into its smaller states of occupation. Maryam went upstairs for the packet of letters Hanna had mentioned and found, beneath them in her handbag, two notes from Nawal she had not answered.

The upper one had been written before Semiramis and carried the old firm tone of women who believe affection entitles them to timetable other lives: Come on Wednesday if you can. If you cannot, come Thursday. I refuse to be postponed into abstraction. The second was

shorter and more ruinous now that its writer was dead. It had arrived the day before the explosion, folded once, tucked among bills and circulars. I was unkind on Sunday. Come and let me repair it. This quarter gives no notice before it takes offence.

Maryam sat with the note open until the words ceased being language and became only shape. It had happened so quickly that even the dead still wrote in the grammar of next week. She put the paper away, took it out again, then left it on the dressing table because classification had become another form of evasion. Nawal had asked to be seen and now would remain one of the things seen too late. That, perhaps, was the beginning of the chapter's true price: not desire itself, but the fact that delay had already shown what it cost in one direction and still had not cured her in the other.

On the bed lay the blue-grey dress she had worn to the Khourys, already brushed once and needing it again because dust had become the city's only reliable surplus. She did not mean to choose her afternoon clothes with care. This too was one of the lies respectable women told themselves. No woman who intended only to carry family papers, oversee a wardrobe, and return before the light had reason to reject one dress, then another, on grounds so petty they could not be admitted aloud. She settled at last on a dark brown wool that made her look neither young nor defeated.

At eleven Amina came up with the mending basket and paused in the doorway. She saw the open handbag, the letters, the note on the dressing table, and the brown dress laid out for town.

"You are wearing the dark wool again," she said. "Brush it well. That hem shows everything."

"It only shows roads," said Maryam.

"In this city roads and rooms have stopped respecting the difference."

She said it while sorting thread, as if the remark belonged to buttons rather than lives.

The road into town had grown busier without recovering any confidence. Handcarts passed with loads too miscellaneous to signify anything good: bedsteads, sacks of flour, boxes of files, once even a birdcage with no bird in it. Nothing was forbidden yet. Everything was annotated. A woman she knew slightly from church nodded and let her eyes fall at once to the parcel in Maryam's hand, then away with the decent speed of a person who had seen enough to feel both informed and innocent. Errands had become the quarter's last permissible language for private motion. One could still cross from one place to another respectably if carrying paper, ribbon, or someone else's request. To walk for air or thought had acquired something almost disreputable about it.

By the time she reached the flat the day had entered that grim half-light winter afternoons in Jerusalem practised before admitting that evening had already won. The sitting room had become larger by subtraction. The bookcases were nearly bare. The rug had been rolled. The side table had gone. In the back room the wardrobe still stood, but only by temporary mercy.

Hanna took the parcel of labels from her without greeting because greetings in this flat had long ago been demoted by work. Tariq emerged from the back room carrying

devotional books tied in one of Aunt Widad's better lengths of string. He stopped when he saw her, and in that second both of them measured the room against what it now knew.

"You brought the letters?" Hanna asked.

"Yes."

On the window-sill stood the chipped mug that did not belong to Yusef. It had been there since before Semiramis and was by now the most intimate object in the flat precisely because it was so ordinary. A coat might be forgotten anywhere. A mug suggested habit, and habit was bad enough.

For the next hour the room remained safely multiple. The cousin's man and the porter succeeded in getting the wardrobe through the back-room doorway, its departure revealing a pale square on the wall and a quantity of dust which Aunt Widad would have taken as a personal insult. Father Elias found school exercise books among the church material and developed, briefly, a theory about the moral weakness of librarians. Hanna revised lists, tied packets, and held practical misery together by the force of handwriting.

On the little table by Yusef's chair the inventory list still lay where Hanna and Tariq had left it the day before, Hanna's narrow columns crossed now and then by Tariq's darker corrections. One wrote to control. The other to distinguish. The page looked like a debate carried on by decent men in a language papers respected more than households did.

In the lower drawer, opened with the duplicate key, they found letters Yusef had hidden from classification because classification would have required feeling: a sheaf from

Cairo concerning fish knives and dowry silver, two unpaid subscriptions, and a thin packet of family notes tied with ribbon that had once been blue.

She opened one just enough to see that it was from Yusef's sister-in-law and chiefly concerned an argument about cutlery conducted with the solemnity of treaty law.

"What is it?" Tariq asked.

"Apparently my uncle spent six months arguing by post over fish knives."

"That is how one knows a civilisation has once existed."

"No," she said. "That is how one knows a family has."

Tariq took the next letter from her hand, read the opening line, and returned it at once because its French contained too much kinship to be traversed by a man who was neither family nor priest. That, too, was part of what made him dangerous. He knew the shape of limits without requiring them to be explained in the terms of class or delicacy. The knowledge itself felt too close.

By half past five Father Elias had gone with the first stack of books, the porter with him, and the cousin's man had made two journeys down the stairs with wardrobe pieces and muttered theological pessimism on each return. At last Hanna took up his coat and the bank file and said, "I must see the surveyor and then the office. Box what remains. Lock the desk. Do not stay later than you need."

He said it as any practical husband might. That did not prevent the sentence from carrying a second weight merely by existing in the room it addressed. Maryam wanted him, for one irrational second, either to say more or to say less. Instead he put on his coat and left in the correct, efficient

manner by which he always left spaces he believed managed. When his tread had gone from the landing, the flat did not transform. That would have been easier. It merely lost one species of permission and left the others standing where they already were. When the door closed behind him, both of them behaved for a minute as though his absence might still prove temporary. Tariq moved the satchel farther under the chair with his foot. From it protruded a child's exercise book, a folded pharmacy packet, and a narrow strip of paper on which someone — his mother, she guessed, from the patient angularity of the hand — had written soap, paraffin, lentils, one candle. The list shocked her more than a declaration might have done. Desire had not cleared his world any more than it had cleared hers. It had entered among lentils, school margins, the duplicate key, Huda's damp ceiling, and the dead man's labels. Nothing had become simpler. The label pencil left a grey stripe on her thumb. In the kitchen the kettle took too long to boil and clicked once before settling. The mug left a brown ring on the table.

Maryam re-tied the ribbon around the family letters although it required no help. Then rain began, not heavily, only with that mean winter insistence which makes departure seem slightly more deliberate than delay.

For a few minutes they worked harder than before, as though speed itself might still make the room respectable. Maryam wrote FAMILY on one label, PRIVATE on another, CHURCH on a third. Tariq retied the journals and checked the insurance sheet against Hanna's notes. Dust rose each time a box closed. In the back room the iron bedframe, relieved of the wardrobe's company, had become harder to ignore. The mattress remained on it only because no one had yet agreed whose duty it was to move

a dead bachelor's bed. In the narrowed room that felt indecent enough.

Tariq went into the kitchen and found the good tea by instinct or memory. He stood over the kettle with his sleeves rolled, watching the water as if tea existed in certain rooms not as hospitality but as delay made respectable. The first dangerous thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition.

Without looking at her he said, "There is one question left. If the letters go now, they go as family. If they stay, they become archive."

She leaned against the doorframe, still holding the label pencil. "You speak as though those are the only two conditions."

"There is also neglect."

"No," she said. "Neglect is merely family without self-knowledge."

He looked at her then. "That is not a third category."

"What is it, then?"

He turned off the flame under the kettle. "That is the first category in disguise."

He poured the tea into his enamel mug and the thick glass he always gave her when proper cups could not be found. They took both back into the sitting room because the kitchen had grown too small for conversation. On the cleared table lay Yusef's French notebook, the insurance sheet, three labels waiting to be written, the key ring, and the old hotel tag. The thick glass clouded in her hand before clearing.

"It looks worse in rain," she said.

"The room?"

"The whole thing. The boxes. The shelves. The fact of it."

He repeated the last phrase quietly, as if testing whether repetition might improve it. It did not. She ought then to have said something practical about the labels or the remaining books. Instead she said, "When all this is gone there will be no reason to come here."

The line hung between them with the vulgar directness of something too true to sound clever. He did not rescue her from it. Rain went on at the window. Somewhere below, a door shut in the building with the labouring finality of old wood. He set down the mug, not carelessly but with a concentration so exact it announced that he had heard the sentence not as speculation but as structure.

"There is already no reason," he said.

She did not know whether she moved first or only failed to move away in time. Later this would matter to her because afterwards every instant before the fact would acquire false dignity under examination. At the time there was only the unbearable ordinariness of standing in a half-emptied room while the one sentence that had been kept outside every room finally entered. He said her name once, not loudly, and she answered not with speech but by looking at him as one looks when the rest of one's life has supplied no usable reply. The first kiss was not a conquest, nor an eruption, nor anything so theatrically solvable. It was a mistake recognised as itself while being committed and continued because recognition had arrived too late to save either of them from truth.

In the back room the bed had become, by failing to leave with the rest of the furniture, the room's final indecency. The mattress was narrow, the iron frame complaining under even the weight of a folded blanket. There was a small washstand, a chair, the pale square where the wardrobe had stood, and nothing else by which the room might pretend to belong to any ordinary use. They still paused in the doorway like guilty visitors to their own action. She had the absurd thought that Yusef would have objected not to adultery but to the dust.

"We can still leave," he said.

It was the last honour left to them and therefore intolerable. She took off her gloves because her hands could no longer bear their own respectability. One glove slipped to the floor. Neither of them bent to retrieve it.

What happened after that retained, even in memory, the material awkwardness guilt later tried to smooth away. Her hat pin would not come loose at first. His cuff caught in her sleeve. The bed protested its years with one loud complaint which made them both stop, then laugh once in a way too broken to count as laughter. The lamp in the sitting room was left burning and sent a reduced rectangle of light through the doorway, enough to keep everything from becoming romantic shadow. He touched her as one touches something both needed and too easily damaged. She did not become another woman upon being wanted. She remained exactly herself: frightened, vain, hungry, ashamed, moved, half unwilling to see what she herself had authorised. The intensity lay not in revelation but in the complete collapse of postponement. A thing deferred through papers, errands, weather, child, church, death,

road, and ordinary cowardice had become body. That was all. That was everything.

When they lay down the mattress shifted under them and one spring made a sound so indecorous that she covered her mouth against another laugh and then, to her horror, felt tears there instead. He mistook them at first for regret and moved back, the old discipline returning to his face with such visible force that she caught his wrist before he could rise.

"No," she said, and then, because accuracy had been the language between them from the beginning, "Not no to this. No to stopping and pretending that improves anything."

The sentence was not beautiful. It was probably unwise. It was also the truest thing she had said in months. What followed was tender because both of them were afraid, awkward because fear belongs to the body as much as desire does. The iron frame, the cold room, the blanket smelling faintly of cedar and storage, the rain at the window, the dead man's flat — none of it altered.

Afterwards the first sensation was not peace but exposure. The rain had thickened. Somewhere in the building someone dragged a chair and then stopped, as if remembering the hour. The room had not changed, yet every object now seemed to know the new arrangement before they did. The chair held her dress and his coat with an intimacy clothes should never acquire in borrowed places. Her hat lay where it had fallen. The glove remained under the bed. He found it caught in the iron seam and put it into her hand with such care that the smallness of the action nearly undid her.

"I cannot go back to calling this work," he said after a silence. "Not now."

"Then do not call it anything," she answered.

"That is what has brought us here."

There was no answer to that which did not sound like argument pretending to be philosophy. She rose and crossed into the sitting room to pin up her hair at the darkened window, using the glass as a mirror because the mirror from the back room had already been wrapped for transport. Behind her she heard him fold the blanket, not because order still mattered morally but because order was the only form of mercy available to men like him after they had crossed the line between desire and damage.

They spent the next fifteen minutes committing the pathetic postscript by which adults try to restore innocence to a room that has lost it. The hat pin was found under the washstand. He rinsed the thick glass and his mug in the kitchen and set them to dry as if tea had simply concluded. She rewound the ribbon around the family letters and returned them to her bag. At no point did either of them say this is absurd, though absurdity stood in the room like a fourth presence.

On the landing they listened first for the building. No voices. Only rain and the occasional cough of an engine lower down. At the bottom of the stairs they separated without touching. The street had darkened into one of those Jerusalem evenings in which every house seemed to be husbanding its light. A cart passed between them and the lower road carrying two rolls of carpet and a brass bed knob tied absurdly on top, as if whatever household had given up the bed had still insisted on keeping one emblem

of it visible. He took the convent side because he had said he would. She turned uphill. After ten steps she heard him behind her say her name once, not loudly enough to summon, only loudly enough to exist.

"Tomorrow?" he said.

The word held no romance. It meant the flat, the papers, the intolerability of pretending nothing now required continuation. She answered, after a pause long enough to disgrace them both, "No. Not tomorrow."

He did not argue. "Very well," he said. "But not because nothing has changed."

By the time she reached home the house had entered supper. This was worse than if it had already finished. Completed domestic acts were at least mercifully closed. Ongoing ones had to receive one. In the dining room Ibrahim was reciting geography with martyrdom and error in equal parts. Leila was objecting to lentils on constitutional grounds. Her mother, still properly dressed because departure might yet call before pudding, was explaining to Huda that no sensible woman left winter wool in a trunk merely because leaving had become imaginable. Hanna sat at the near end of the table with a sheet of copied figures propped against the water jug, adding a column while eating in the efficient manner of men who believed hunger and work could be solved simultaneously.

He looked up when she entered. "Did the wardrobe go?"

"Yes."

"And the journals?"

"Boxed."

He nodded and returned to his figures, the absence of scrutiny somehow harder to bear than scrutiny would have been. Throughout the meal the house continued its new arithmetic. Huda apologised for the extra washing. Ibrahim offered to sleep in the corridor because his mother had informed him that sacrifice must begin young. Leila declared that sacrifice was easier for boys because they owned fewer ribbons. Her mother asked whether Habib still had mourning envelopes or had now surrendered to chaos. Maryam answered where required and heard her own voice with the estrangement one feels after using it differently elsewhere. Amina came from the sideboard with the soup tureen and, in passing, took Maryam's coat from her arm without ceremony. Her fingers paused once at the hem. Only once.

Later, in the pantry, she turned the coat to the back lamp and brushed the wool with the palm of her hand.

"This will need a proper brush," she said. "The dust is from an inside wall, not the road. And there is damp at the sleeve where it caught on plaster."

The sentence contained no question. It did not even contain judgment. It came from the republic of matter, where ash, flour, chalk, and cedar all preserved their separate citizenship. Maryam stood with one hand on the shelf of preserves and could think of nothing to say that was not both foolish and unworthy.

Amina reached into the pocket for the handkerchief before it creased. Her fingers found the loose button and closed over it without surprise. She placed it on the shelf between the soap and the folded napkins. "I will sew that in the morning before anyone decides your clothes are participating in politics." Then, after the slightest pause:

"The little one asked whether you were delayed by paper or by rain. I said both. It seemed efficient."

"Amina—"

"No," she said, not sharply but with the composure of one refusing a burden she had not consented to carry. "Not me. I am only telling you that cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look. Also the tea in the flat is stronger than ours. It stays in the cloth."

Upstairs the dressing table seemed indecently bright under the lamp. She put Nawal's note into the drawer, took it out again, then left it beneath the hairbrush because hiding and displaying now appeared equally theatrical. On the chair lay the shawl she had worn. It smelled faintly of paraffin, rain, and the back room's trapped cedar. She thought of the flat stripped to its dimensions — the absent wardrobe, the pale square on the wall, the blanket smelling of cedar and storage, the rain. These would outlast any vocabulary she tried to lay over them. She washed her hands twice because the second washing, like the first, served no useful purpose. From the next room came Leila's sleeping breath. From below, the sound of Hanna closing his ledger and setting down the pen in its tray.

When Hanna came in he carried the bank affidavit and Huda's surveyor note. He set a small box of family silver under the bed beside the medium case her mother had aired days before and loosened his tie with the absent precision of a man who had spent all daylight translating contingency into lists.

"The room is almost finished, then?" he said.

"The wardrobe has gone. The books are nearly done."

"And the bed?"

For one sickening second she thought he knew everything and had decided to phrase it as furniture. Then she understood that he meant only whether the cousin intended to take it as well. "Still there," she said.

"It should go too. Empty rooms become foolish if one leaves them half respectable."

He extinguished the lamp on his side before she could shape any answer. In darkness his competence always became harder to read, not easier. "Do not go tomorrow if I cannot be there," he said after a moment. "There is no point now in encouraging unnecessary lingerings around a room nearly finished."

The sentence was proper. It was also, whether he knew it or not, ruinously apt. She said only, "No." In the dark she could hear the house sounding thinner through all its correct occupations: Huda coughing beyond the wall, Ibrahim turning in the camp bed, Leila calling in sleep for a ribbon she had certainly lost herself, the small metallic complaint of pipes cooling after Amina's wash-up.

CHAPTER XIV

After

When Maryam woke the next morning the room looked ordinary first and wrong only a second later, which was perhaps the exact cruelty of it. The curtain had not been drawn fully the night before, and a strip of pale light lay across the chair where she had left her dress. For a few seconds she lay still and felt, not memory exactly, but the plain difference in her own body produced by the previous day. It was not a wound or a triumph. It was only an alteration. Then the sheet cooled against her skin, the room smelt of soap and ironed linen again, and the ordinary discomforts returned one by one.

She sat up too quickly. The shawl from the flat still lay over the chair-back where she had dropped it before undressing. Her first impulse was to hide it at once, under other things, somewhere absurd. Her second was to leave it where it was, because hiding it would admit an inspection no one had performed. She did neither for a moment. She only sat with both feet on the rug, looking at it as though the fabric itself had become indiscreet.

At last she rose, carried it to the wardrobe, and laid it on the lower shelf beneath two cardigans she had not worn since Christmas. The gesture satisfied nothing. When she turned back to the room she could still remember the exact fold of it over the chair.

From below came the sound of Hanna speaking to Huda in the dining room, his voice low and hers lower, and beneath both of them the small falling note of a spoon against a cup. Huda and Ibrahim had been in the house for three nights now. The extra camp bed in the spare room, the extra bowl at breakfast, the extra satchel in the passage: each was a manageable fact, and therefore more oppressive than any visible drama. Hanna had brought them in with the quiet inevitability with which he brought in everything he had already judged necessary. Huda had

resisted for half an hour and then submitted, which was her brother's usual effect on weaker forms of resistance.

Maryam dressed without haste and went downstairs.

The dining room had altered again. Huda's travelling case was now under the sideboard rather than in the hall, which meant she had stopped believing she would leave the next morning. Ibrahim's copybook lay open beside Leila's slate, the two children already fallen into the temporary territorial arrangements by which children accepted upheaval without ever dignifying it by explanation. Huda sat near the window in a dark dress too fine for the business of sheltering with one's brother. Her hands were small and restless; she had already folded and unfolded the same handkerchief twice. Ibrahim was drawing a cart in the margin of his arithmetic. Leila had decided his cart needed a horse and was improving it without permission.

Amina came in carrying tea and looked once, not at Maryam's face, but at the empty chair where the shawl had been when she had brought hot water the night before. If she noticed its absence, she gave no sign beyond setting the tray down with unusual care. Then she said, "I took the brush to your coat again. The damp brought the cedar up."

"I thought you had done it last night."

"I had. The sleeve wanted a second opinion." She poured without pausing. "The lower button is secure now. It was never going to survive another wall."

Her tone was level. It contained neither insolence nor mercy. She had repaired the evidence in the night and was now giving it back in the form of clothing.

"You are late," said Maryam's mother from the head of the table.

"It is not yet eight."

"It feels later."

"Everything feels later," said Huda quietly.

No one answered that. It was too near a true sentence for breakfast.

Hanna came in from the hall carrying a folded paper and his hat, though he had not yet put the hat on. "I will go first to the office and then to the registry," he said. "If the clerk

is there, we may have the duplicate by noon. If he is not there, we will have his nephew and a promise."
"Which paper?" Aunt Widad asked, appearing in the doorway with the unerring sense of timing that allowed her to enter houses only when decisions were already being made.
"The lease copy for Huda's landlord."
"Does he say he never received the original?"
"He says many things," Hanna answered. "Some are probably even true."
He sat. "And the flat. The bed men are coming tomorrow. Tariq can finish the inventory there this morning. The books may wait."
The name entered the room with no more ceremony than ribbon or tea. Her mother only frowned at the ribbon's width. Huda tore a piece of bread in half for Ibrahim. But Maryam felt the small, immediate alteration a name could bring to a sentence merely by being placed inside it.
Her mother said, "You are not going to the flat today."
It was said as information, not instruction. That made it more difficult to oppose.
Maryam lifted her cup. "Was I going?"
"No one needs to go every day merely because a room exists."
After breakfast Maryam carried spoons to the pantry and found Amina there wrapping the better ones in newspaper with kitchen string.
"Your mother wants the good cups moved to the cabinet before the parish women arrive," Amina said. "Also, if women are going to come and say they are only passing, it is better the cups are not already on display. Grief should not look prepared beyond what is tasteful."
Maryam picked up two cups. "I will take these."
"Take them where they belong, then."
That last word might have referred to the cups. It might not. Maryam carried them out without asking.
No note came from Tariq. That should have been a relief. Instead it left the morning with a shape missing from it.

Maryam spent part of the next hour helping Huda fold two more dresses into the spare-room wardrobe and listening while Huda spoke in the apologetic register of women who have accepted hospitality at exactly the moment when hospitality is most expensive.

"You know I would not stay if there were another arrangement," Huda said.

"I know."

"Hanna says the landlord only wants the registry copy and another week's patience."

"Hanna always says what men want in a sentence shorter than they use themselves."

Huda smiled faintly. "Father used to say it was because Hanna had no vanity in practical matters. He never needed to make his own errand the largest in the room."

"That is one of his gifts."

"It is also why people lean on him too hard."

The sentence sat between them. Maryam could not tell whether Huda meant herself, the landlord, the family, the quarter, or Maryam. Perhaps she meant all of them.

The bell rang. Two women from the parish stayed forty-five minutes and drank one cup of tea each, which was exactly long enough to offer concern, extract detail, and leave before any room's real fatigue could inconvenience them. One of them asked after Nawal not as though she expected comfort but as though she expected sequence: had the family been informed, had the church done this, had that cousin come? When they had gone, Huda carried the cups to the sideboard and Maryam found herself watching the marks they left: the slight turn of one chair, the napkin folded badly, the faint lip trace on one saucer. Yesterday such marks had meant condolence. Today they meant resumption.

Shortly before noon Elias's younger brother arrived with a folded note from Habib. The corrected bank draft was ready. One page still required Hanna's initials. Habib hoped the house would understand that shortages of carbon paper were now a moral trial.

Her mother said at once, "You can send the boy back."

"He will fold the papers," Aunt Widad said. "Boys fold papers as though making enemies."

"I will go," said Maryam.

Her mother's disapproval was visible before she spoke. "There is no need."

"There is every need. Hanna will want the corrected draft this afternoon."

Aunt Widad said, "Then take Huda."

Huda looked up from Ibrahim's cuff. "Why?"

"Because two women on an errand are an errand. One woman on an errand is a narrative."

Maryam wanted to say the distinction was obscene. She also knew Aunt Widad was right. Huda, who had too much gratitude in her to refuse another burden, said only, "Then let us go before the queue forms."

They walked into town with one umbrella between them though it was not raining, because neither wished to trust the sky's manners. Huda kept her pace a fraction shorter than Maryam's, as though aware she was walking on another household's rhythm. The streets felt busier than they had any right to on an ordinary errand day. A cart of coal stood half unloaded at the kerb. Three boys were arguing over a paper flag by the tram stop. Outside the butcher's two men had ceased pretending they were only discussing prices. A woman she knew slightly from church nodded and let her eyes fall to the packet under Maryam's arm, then back to her face, then away with the decent speed of a person who had seen enough to feel both informed and innocent.

Habib's shop smelt of paper, oil, and damp wool. He emerged from the back room drying his hands. "The corrected bank wording is better now. Your schoolmaster friend has a decent ear."

Maryam said, before the word schoolmaster could settle too comfortably, "Has he been here?"

"Half the quarter has been here. The machine now knows more family history than the church." He handed her the packet. "One page needs the husband's initials where the carbon slipped."

Huda paid. Maryam counted the pages there, as Hanna had instructed. In a city like theirs, counting was the only remaining flattery businesses trusted.

Outside, Huda stopped at the hardware man's window because her hooks had suddenly become urgent. Maryam waited beside the wall with the packet under her arm. She saw Tariq first in the reflection on the glass before she saw him directly. He was coming down from the upper end of the street with Khalil beside him, both carrying more paper than men ought to carry on foot if paper still belonged to a sane order of things.

The reflection gave her just enough time to compose the first line of her face and not enough to compose the second.

Khalil saw her almost at once and altered course with the public tact of a man who understood visibility too well to be careless with it. "Mrs Hanna," he said, inclining his head. "And Mrs Hanna's sister, I hope, unless Jerusalem has begun multiplying women from the same family out of administrative need."

"Huda," said Huda, emerging with her hooks wrapped in newspaper. "Widowed, unfortunately, but still singular."

Khalil accepted this without embarrassment. Tariq had stopped by then, though not in the manner of a man taking advantage of chance. He stood as one stood when a public street had suddenly become more complicated than its width suggested.

"You have been to Habib," he said, glancing once at the packet.

"For ribbon, hooks, and paper apparently heavy with morality."

"The paper is usually heavier after Habib has improved it."

The exchange was exact enough to pass for ordinary talk and too exact to feel ordinary inside her. Huda asked Khalil whether the school had reopened fully.

"Open and arguing," he said. "About flags, fathers, maps, and the English wording for temporary closure. Next week perhaps grammar again, if we are fortunate."

He said it with fatigue rather than wit. The parcel under his arm had begun slipping. Tariq took one edge of it without looking and steadied it.

Maryam said, "You look as though the school has moved into the street."

"For part of the day it has," Tariq answered. "The porter says men are less likely to shout at us if they can see shops at either end of the conversation."

A handcart passed between them. A driver at the mouth of the lane shouted at another driver for stopping where stopping had never been legal and always been common.

"The bed men will come tomorrow," Maryam said. She had not meant to tell him. The sentence left her with the plainness of information and the weight of something else.

Khalil turned slightly. "Then your afternoon is spoken for."

"Yes," said Tariq.

Then Khalil looked at Tariq more directly. "If your mother still means to see the doctor at Bab al-Sahira, do not leave it past next week. The tram men are already behaving as though timetable were a memory."

Tariq's face changed only by a degree. "She has not decided to go."

"Then help her decide before the road decides for her."

The sentence stripped the street of any remaining comfort. Maryam heard in it not merely Khalil's concern but the whole tightening city: routes closing, trams unreliable, a mother's cough and a doctor farther away each week.

They moved then, because streets required movement. But as Maryam stepped away, Tariq said, low enough not to force the others to hear, "If you come tomorrow, come before one."

She did not turn back. "Hanna is going."

"I know."

There was no pressure in the words yet. Only a stripping away of pretence so slight anyone else might have missed it. Huda said nothing until they had crossed. Then, with the restraint of women who know the uses of restraint, she said, "The schoolmaster has less patience in his face than before."

"The whole city has less," Maryam answered.
"That is not what I said."
"No."
"It may still be what I meant."
Maryam almost answered sharply and did not. Huda was not foolish, and the kindness between sisters by marriage was often made of noticing exactly how much one ought not to say.
When they reached the house, Hanna had not yet returned. The packet was placed on the sideboard. The ribbon was judged satisfactory. Ibrahim had broken the point of a pencil and was being judged for it by her mother with more moral seriousness than the district committee now gave roads.
By the time Hanna came back, mud marked one hem and the registry copy sat in his inside pocket. He took the corrected packet, looked at the altered paragraph, initialled the page, and said only, "Good."
Her mother asked whether the registry man had existed. Hanna said he had. Aunt Widad announced that one must move before offices remembered they were in Palestine and not in heaven. Huda put before her brother the lentils Amina had kept warm in the oven. He thanked her in the brief, unpatronising way that was his.
After three spoonfuls he said to Maryam, "Did Habib mention whether Tariq corrected the English himself?"
"Only that the wording was better."
"It usually is after Tariq has touched it."
The sentence, perfectly practical, entered the room like something lightly combustible. No one treated the name as private or charged. That made it harder to bear.
After luncheon Hanna went out again to see Huda's landlord. The house dropped into the suspended rhythm of early afternoon: too late for callers, too early for lamps, too tired for useful conversation. Huda slept in the spare room with one hand on Ibrahim's blanket as if widowhood had turned even sleep into custody. Her mother lay down but did not sleep. Aunt Widad went off to inspect a cousin's influenza and be seen doing so. Maryam carried the

corrected packet first to the sideboard, then to the dining table, and finally upstairs to her room, as though the proper resting place of paper might still matter. She set it beside the brush where Nawal's note still lay half-hidden. The two papers looked indecent together, one all practical correction, the other invitation. She moved the note into the drawer at last and left the packet out.

When she came down again, Amina was polishing one of the better cups before returning it to the cabinet.

"You have used the wrong cloth," Maryam said, because one says something when one enters a room and cannot say the thing one is thinking.

"Have I?" Amina changed cloths without offence. "The woman from Talbiya will come tomorrow instead. Her brother says the road near the convent is too lively today for condolences."

"Everyone is postponing."

Amina set the cup down and took up another. "Everyone is sorting. Some people call it postponing if they dislike what falls to the bottom."

At four a note came from the flat. Not from Tariq. From Elias's younger brother, sent by the bed men's foreman to say they would come the next afternoon rather than the morning.

Her mother said at once, "Then someone must go."

"Not tonight," said Aunt Widad, reappearing as though contradiction itself had summoned her.

Hanna came in almost at once and said, "Tomorrow after one. I will go."

Maryam said nothing. That, in its way, made more noise than speech.

He looked at her once, not long enough to be called a look if anyone else had been watching. "You need not come."

It was meant kindly, or as kindly as his practical manners allowed. It felt nevertheless like exclusion and reprieve together. She could not have said which part of her resented which.

Near dusk she heard Hanna in the passage speaking to Huda with the door not fully closed.

"Another week is possible," he was saying.
"You have your own household."
"I have rooms."
"That is not the same thing."
"At present it is near enough."
Huda was quiet. Then: "And if it becomes a month?"
He answered after a moment, not because he hesitated, but because he was making the answer usable. "Then we will know more in a month than we know now. There is no sense refusing a week because it may resemble another week after it."
Maryam stood in the dining room with the empty water jug in her hand and thought, not for the first time, that Hanna's form of mercy was inseparable from sequence. He did not promise safety. He promised the next manageable interval. Rooms. A week. A registry copy. Hooks for a cupboard. A bed removed before strangers handled the linen. It was perhaps the most practical form of tenderness she had ever known, and because it arrived without heat she had spent years mistaking it for merely method.
When he came back into the room and saw the empty jug in her hand, he said only, "The tap in the kitchen is running again," as if he had caught her on an errand and not listening to his kindness through a half-open door.
At supper he added, more quietly, "If things worsen and Huda needs to go to our cousins in Beirut quickly, there may be a way as far as the road south before the end of the month. Nothing comfortable. But a way."
The table fell quiet longer than soup required. Departure had been discussed before, but always in the light joking register of cousins elsewhere and temporary arrangements for other people. Tonight it had entered in Hanna's tone: clean, practical, and therefore harder to resist than alarm. Huda looked at her plate. Ibrahim, who understood tone before he understood language, stopped eating and watched his mother's hands. She put one of them over his without looking at him.
That night, after supper, after Huda and Ibrahim had gone into the spare room, after Leila had finally surrendered to

sleep and her mother had retired with the ribbon she no longer needed, Maryam went upstairs by herself. The house had narrowed after dark. Rooms held breath differently when more lives had to fit inside them.

There was a knock at the half-open door.

Not Hanna. Amina.

She held Maryam's dark coat over one arm. "This was in the front passage," she said. "If the rain comes properly, the hem will take all of it."

Maryam took the coat. "Thank you."

Amina remained where she was. "The bed men will leave dust tomorrow. If you are there, change your shoes before you come in."

"I said nothing about going."

"No."

"Then why say that?"

"Because I wash the stairs. Because cedar and mattress dust travel farther than women think. Because children put their hands on hems." She shifted the weight of the coat. "And because if there is to be more carrying in and out, it is easier to clean for it in the right order."

There was nothing to answer. The sentence had been built entirely out of household logic and yet carried more than household logic could honestly contain.

Maryam said at last, "You always speak as if everything were a matter of cleaning."

Amina looked beyond her into the room, at the brush, the packet, the folded stockings, the order that might at any moment begin lying. "In houses," she said, "most things are."

Then she went.

When Hanna came up later, he found her brushing the hem of the coat with more care than the coat required.

"You need not do that tonight," he said.

"It is only dust."

"Yes."

He loosened his tie, set down his watch, and looked once at the coat, once at her face, then away. "The bed men will come after one. I will go from the office."

"I know."

"If you want to come, come before they arrive. Not while they are carrying."

There was no reason to hear in the sentence anything except logistics. So of course she heard more.

"I may not come at all."

He nodded as if that, too, were a practical possibility to be entered beside registry copies and school fees. "Very well."

He lay down first. She remained sitting at the dressing table another minute, looking at her own face in the glass. Not guilt exactly. Not fear exactly. Only the new weight of plain objects. A coat. A packet. A note in a drawer. A room to which a bed still belonged for one more night.

When she finally came to bed, Hanna was awake. She could tell by the way his breathing waited before settling.

"If Huda must stay another week," he said into the dark, "there is room."

That was not what she had expected him to speak of. "Yes."

"Less room than before," he said after a moment. "But room."

He meant the house. He may have meant more than the house. Or he may have meant only the house, which was its own difficulty. She was too tired to know.

In the next room Leila turned in sleep and murmured something about ribbon. Huda coughed once and quieted. The pipes gave their small metallic complaint. Outside, the rain finally came properly, running down the shutters and swallowing the last sounds from the road.

Maryam lay awake longer than she admitted to herself, listening to the house hold more lives than it had been built to hold, and thinking of the flat waiting with one less wardrobe, one almost-finished inventory, and a bed that by tomorrow evening might be only boards, rope, and a pale shape on the floor.

CHAPTER XV

The Demand

By breakfast the house had already divided itself into the day's smaller campaigns.

Huda needed a letter written to the cousin in Beirut who might, or might not, still have room. Ibrahim had lost the blue pencil he insisted was indispensable to arithmetic and turned out, after ten minutes of moral inquiry, to be sitting on it. Leila wanted to know whether men who removed beds ever removed dreams as well, and whether she ought to hide hers in the wardrobe in case they took the wrong one. Maryam's mother said children had no business discussing dreams before coffee and perhaps none afterwards. Aunt Widad, who had arrived before eight and spoken since, declared that people who moved furniture for money were usually more trustworthy than people who moved opinions for free. Hanna, sitting at the head of the table with his notebook open beside the bread, translated all of it into sequence.

"The bed men after one," he said. "Elias will have the key. I have the registry copy for Huda's landlord. I will go to the office first, then to the flat. If they are late, they are late. If they arrive before me, Elias is not to let them touch the journals or the letters. The bed only."

"The bed only," said Aunt Widad. "As if beds travelled without the dust under them."

"They do not," said Amina from the sideboard, "but dust has never once waited for permission."

Hanna looked up at Maryam. "You need not go."

He said it in the same tone in which he had said it the day before, and

it carried the same double character: reprieve and exclusion, kindness
and command. In another man she might have heard only authority. In
Hanna it remained what it often was—procedure trying, within its own
narrow means, to behave like care.
“I know,” she said.
“Then let that be enough.”
Leila, who had already dipped crust into jam and had red on her cuff
because no prohibition ever reached her entirely in time, asked, “If the
bed goes, where will the room sleep?”
“In the floorboards,” said Amina.
“It cannot. Floorboards do not shut their eyes.”
“Then perhaps rooms do not need sleep.”
“That seems arrogant.”
Ibrahim laughed, and the blue pencil fell from his lap onto the tiles,
thereby proving that children and objects often disclosed the truth at
the same moment. Huda stooped to pick it up before either child could.
There was a new caution in her movements now, not frailty exactly, but
the caution of a woman who had already moved once in dependence on
another household and knew she might move again.
Hanna tore a page from the notebook and slid it across to Huda. “The
cousin’s address as I have it. If you mean to write, do it today. If it
changes, it changes. If you wait for certainty, you will write to no
one.”
“That is a cheerful doctrine for breakfast,” said Aunt Widad.
“It is a practical one.”

Huda folded the paper without reading it. “I may write after luncheon.”
“You may,” said Hanna, in the tone of a man who heard the postponement
and entered it into a mental ledger without protest because protest did
not improve facts.
Maryam buttered bread she did not want and watched the table as one
watched a railway platform on which several trains were somehow expected
to depart from the same track. Huda’s letter. Ibrahim’s pencil. Leila’s
stockings. Aunt Widad’s repeated question of whether the mattress ought
to be turned before men carried it out because one never knew what stale
shape a family bed might preserve for the street. Her mother’s
insistence that Huda’s dark dress be brushed before noon because people
in difficulty had a moral obligation not to resemble it. Hanna’s
notebook absorbing all of them without visible strain.
The bed men after one. Tariq had said, the previous day, if you come
tomorrow, come before one.
He had said it low and without flourish, as a practical sentence
requiring practical hearing. That had made it worse. A grander man would
have weighted the line with feeling and therefore made it easier to
resist. Tariq had left the sentence in the register of arrangement. Come
before one. Hanna is going. I know.
When breakfast ended the household dispersed according to need and

habit. Huda took Ibrahim upstairs to rewrite arithmetic that would have
been perfectly legible to any teacher not himself. Leila was sent with
Amina to find the second of the better dustcloths and came back carrying
instead an old postcard and a dead moth, both of which she claimed might
be useful later. Her mother retired not to rest, which she disapproved
of on principle before noon, but to sit with the account book and a
shawl across her knees in the room she insisted remained too bright for
mourning even on days without sun.

Hanna stood in the passage fastening his cufflinks. “If the bed men ask
for extra payment, tell Elias to wait for me.”

“I am not going,” said Maryam.

He glanced up. “No.”

“Then why tell me?”

“Because you are standing there.”

That answer, in another moment, might have made her laugh. Today she
only said, “You have Huda’s landlord as well.”

“And the office.”

“And the registry.”

“Yes.”

“You are overfilling the day.”

“So is everyone.”

He put on his hat. “If the Talbiya woman comes, ask Amina to check the
silver she polished last week. The forks had spots.”

He said this not because silver mattered more than beds or routes or
letters, but because in his world nothing became less itself because
history had begun behaving badly. Forks still spotted. Registry copies

still needed stamps. Sisters still required landlords to be managed. Men
still had to go where they had said they would go.
Before leaving he touched Leila's hair once, correcting the ribbon at
the back, then looked at Maryam as if there were one more item to be
named and decided against it. That too was one of the ways care failed
in him: it reached the threshold of speech and then turned back into the
list.
After he had gone the house seemed at once smaller and less organised,
as though his departure had removed not authority but the illusion that
sequence was in fact holding. The children's voices moved overhead. In
the kitchen Amina instructed someone who was not there in tones of
exhausted contempt. A cart went past outside, one wheel sounding
slightly wrong. The city had begun carrying wrong sounds more openly
now: not yet disaster, but deviations from expected rhythm one could
feel before one named.
Maryam went upstairs with no real intention except the temporary decency
of not remaining at the table after the man who had ordered the day had
left it. In the bedroom the corrected packet lay where she had set it
beside the brush and Nawal's note. She moved the note into the drawer.
She took it out again. She set it beneath the packet. She lifted the
packet and held it under her arm, then put it back because the gesture

looked like a decision and she had not yet admitted to one.
There was a knock on the half-open door, and Amina came in carrying the
mending basket and one of Leila's socks stretched over a small mushroom.
"The button is secure," she said of the coat. "The hem will not tell
tales unless it meets another wall."
"It will meet only daylight."
"In this city daylight has become a busybody."
Maryam smiled despite herself and sat at the dressing table as if she
meant to sort the tray. Amina crossed to the chair, set down the basket,
and took up the coat once more to inspect the sleeve with the
professional dissatisfaction of a woman who trusted no repair simply
because it had already been made.
"The bed men are due after one?" she said.
"So I am told."
"Hanna will go."
"Yes."
Amina nodded as if that part had already been arranged in the household
furniture and therefore did not interest her. "Then either the room will
be nearly finished tonight or the men will fail in some ordinary way and
make more work tomorrow."
Maryam looked at her in the mirror. "Is that meant to comfort me?"
"It is meant to be a fact."
Amina reattached herself to the sock. "If you go out later, use the
black shoes. The brown still carry dust at the seam."
"I said nothing about going out."
"No."

The one syllable held no insolence. It contained only the sort of
complete hearing that labour sometimes forced on people. Maryam took up
the hairbrush, put it down again, and said, “The city has made everyone
suspicious.”
“The city has made everyone observant. Suspicion is for people who have
leisure.”
There were some answers to which rank could object and some to which it
could only remain still. Maryam said, after a moment, “And do you have
leisure?”
Amina threaded the needle without looking down. “Not enough for
suspicion.”
From overhead came Leila’s shout that Ibrahim had cheated at
multiplication by using his finger where no finger should have been
permitted. Huda called something too low to be heard distinctly, then
coughed. The cough had improved a little after three nights in Hanna’s
house and then worsened again with the weather, as if the body itself
had taken to imitating the city’s indecision.
Maryam rose and crossed to the wardrobe. On the lower shelf, under two
folded cardigans, lay the shawl from the flat. She did not touch it.
Instead she took out the black shoes, set them on the rug, and returned
to the dressing table where the corrected packet still lay under the
hairbrush.
Amina said, “Those, yes.”

“What?”
“The black shoes. They tell less.”
When Amina had gone Maryam stood in the middle of the room a full minute
with the shoes at her feet and the packet in her hand. She told herself
that staying at home was still possible. That Hanna had given her that
possibility in the same tone in which he had assigned Elias the screws
and Huda the cousin and the landlord the copy. That no one had required
an answer by noon. That there was still the luncheon to consider and her
mother’s mood and Huda’s letter and the Talbiya woman’s forks and
everything else with which respectable women peopled the day until
desire had nowhere indecent to sit.
Then she wrapped the packet in plain paper, tied it, and went
downstairs.
Amina was at the sideboard shaking crumbs from the breakfast cloth into
yesterday’s newspaper. She looked up once, saw the paper-wrapped packet
under Maryam’s arm, the black shoes, the coat she had brushed, and said
only, “If anyone asks, you have gone to Habib’s for the registry
copies.”
Maryam said, “Have I?”
“You may as well. Habib exists.”
“Does that make it true?”
Amina folded the cloth. “It makes it serviceable.”
Maryam left by the side door.
The quarter between late morning and luncheon had a false look of

continuity. Women went out for bread or thread with baskets over their
arms. Boys carried parcels and shouted after one another. A cart with
paraffin tins rattled too fast round the corner and was cursed by three
unrelated men as though that kept the road moral. But under the ordinary
movement there was a second layer now, a notation laid over the day.
People looked longer at loaded vehicles. Men paused at corners over
folded papers. Women whose husbands had once conducted every errand
themselves now carried lists in more public hands. Even the children
seemed to understand, without understanding, that routes had become a
subject for adults and that this made them, like all adult subjects,
somehow more powerful than weather.
Habib's stationer's shop stood two streets over and nearer the tram road
than her mother liked, which made it useful as an alibi because any
errand that involved paper, copying, and a degree of inconvenience
seemed automatically respectable. Habib himself was behind the counter
arguing with a man over invoice books and scarcely looked at her when
she entered.
"The copies?" he asked.
"They are not ready yet?"
"Nothing is ready until someone asks for it twice." He disappeared
through the curtain to the back room. When he returned he handed her two

folded sheets and said, “If anyone asks, these were difficult.”
“I would never deprive a copy of its dignity.”
“Good. Dignity is all that remains profitable.”
He did not look at her a second time. That, too, made him useful.
The flat was as she had left it and not as she had left it. The bed
remained, but the room knew it would not remain long. The rolled carpet
stood by the wall. The chair from the bedroom had already been moved to
the sitting room because, Tariq had told her yesterday, it was easier to
take objects in sequence than in memory. His satchel lay on the round
table. The mug remained on the sill. The pile of notices Khalil had
brought was larger.
Tariq looked up when she entered and for a second his face altered with
a relief so slight it would have been invisible in another man. Then the
expression was gone.
“You came.”
“Yes.”
He took the packet from her and set it beside the letters without
unwrapping it at once. “Khalil may come.”
“For papers?”
“For me.”
He said it without flourish, and that was enough to tighten the room.
She asked what had happened. He told her: the tram line to Bab al-Sahira
was already less reliable than men who sold tickets pretended, Khalil’s
friend’s brother had found a cart on Thursday for his mother to see the

doctor and perhaps stay a night or two with the sister near the gate,
and the headmaster's brother knew of one room near the convent if a
teacher needed to move his family nearer the route. He said all this in
the tone of a man reading notices to himself and discovering they had
become personal.
"My mother may have to move for a few days," he said. "Or not. I may
have to move her myself. Or not. The school may need men nearer to it.
Or not. Your husband is already finding ways south for your sister. The
city is full of maybes pretending not to be decisions. I am tired of
living in them as if they were weather."
Before Maryam could answer there was a step on the landing and Khalil
entered carrying two notices and a rolled map. He stopped when he saw
her, recalculated, and then decided courtesy was not worth delay.
"The cart on Thursday will not wait for principles," he said to Tariq.
"If your mother means to see the doctor, tell me before dusk. Farid's
brother will not hold the space because old women prefer their own
kettles."
"My mother is not old."
"She is old enough for transport to have become political."
He set the map on the table. "And if the school needs two men nearer the
gate by Friday, I need to know whether one of them is you or whether I
am begging elsewhere."
Tariq said nothing.

Khalil looked at the stripped room. “You are not short of walls,” he
said. “You are short of time.”
Then he glanced at Maryam with a courtesy sharpened rather than softened
by fatigue, and left.
For several seconds the room contained only the old house sounds: a
board settling, the distant cart on the street, the tap in the kitchen
not fully tightened, the soft touch of newspaper under the mug on the
sill.
Maryam said, because silence had become impossible, “He dislikes me.”
“No,” said Tariq. “He dislikes delay.”
“And he thinks I am delay.”
He did not answer at once. When he did, the answer was mild enough to
wound more cleanly. “You have not been an acceleration.”
She moved to the window because objects were easier to face than him.
Outside, the lane looked no different from any lane in which women went
in and out carrying parcels and men watched lorries as if they might
confess the future if looked at correctly enough.
“You need not speak to me at all,” she said.
“That is the one thing that has stopped being possible.”
When she turned, he was standing by the table, one hand flat on the
notices Khalil had brought, the other hanging uselessly by his side as
though it had once expected to hold something and now mistrusted itself.
“I need to know,” he said, “whether I am arranging one life or another.”
There it was. Not Choose me. Not even I love you, though that had long

since ceased to require saying. The sentence was worse because it was
plain.
She felt, absurdly, not a rush of feeling but a rush of practical
images: Leila's stockings. Huda's letter. The doctor at Bab al-Sahira.
Hanna counting rooms. The blue mug on the sill. The bed men coming up
the stairs. Every object in the last fortnight seemed suddenly to turn
and look at her from its own use.
"You ask as if there were an arrangement to make," she said.
"There is always an arrangement to make. That is what your husband
understands."
"Do not use him like that."
"I am not using him. I am saying what is visible."
"What is visible?" she said. "That he counts rooms? That he plans? That
he does not wake in a room and find that yesterday has poisoned the
handle of every door?"
"You think planning saves him from that?"
"I think nothing saves anyone from anything now."
"Then say that. But do not call it not choosing."
He had moved a little closer without either of them deciding it. The
notices under his hand had begun to crumple at the edge.
"I have a child," she said.
"Yes."
"I have a house."
"Yes."
"I have Huda in the spare room and Ibrahim on the camp bed and my mother
counting teaspoons as if they were part of the frontier and a husband

who may be impossible and yet is not wrong often enough to be dismissed.
I have no sentence for what you are asking.”
“Then say there is none.”
“There is none.”
“No,” he said, and for the first time his voice sharpened in a way she
had not heard from him before. “There is no clean one. That is
different.”
He mastered that sharpness almost at once, but not entirely. “If the
answer is no, say no. If the answer is that I am to go on arranging
papers and routes and visits while pretending the rest belongs to
weather, say that. If I am moving my mother and perhaps taking a room
near the convent and making myself absent from half the city for a
fortnight, tell me whether I am doing that as one man or another.”
She heard herself say, “You should do what you must for your mother.”
He closed his eyes once. “That is not an answer.”
“It is the only one I have.”
“No,” he said. “It is the one that leaves you blameless.”
The room went very still.
She had not thought until that moment that anything he could say might
truly injure her. He had been exact, dry, impatient perhaps. But this
sentence reached the place in her she had most carefully translated into
difficulty, duty, exhaustion, the city, Leila, Huda, rooms, roads — all
the true things that had become shelter. Blameless.
She said, with more coldness than she felt and less than he deserved,

“You become ugly when you are tired.”
“And you become honest for half a second and then retreat into
furniture.”
Below them came the porter’s boy’s voice calling up that the bed men had
arrived.
Neither moved at once.
Then Tariq took his hand from the notices, straightened them with two
unnecessary motions, and said, in a tone so corrected it might have
belonged to a stranger, “Tell Elias to bring them up.”
The bed men entered with the professional indifference of people who had
seen too many thresholds to imagine significance attached only to this
one. One was older, with a dented cap and the patience of a man who
expected furniture and families to resist with equal stupidity. The
other was young enough to apologise whenever a bed leg struck plaster.
“The whole?” the older man asked.
“The whole,” said Tariq.
“Mattress too?”
“Yes.”
“Sheets?”
“They are gone.”
Business. Rope. Turn. Lift. The bed became, again, a bed: iron,
mattress, weight. The younger man apologised when one leg struck the
wall and left a fresh mark above the pale rectangle where the wardrobe
had stood. The older one told him apology did not lift corners and to
mind the door more than the plaster. The mattress bent at the middle and

released a puff of trapped dust and cold.

Then Elias said from the landing, “Khawaja Hanna is in the lane.”

For one instant Maryam thought she might not be able to breathe. Not because there was anything to see. Because there was now too little and too much in the room.

Hanna appeared exactly as he always appeared in tight conditions: hat off, coat unbuttoned, fatigue arranged into usefulness. His eyes took in the bed half-turned, the mattress bent, the pale wall, Tariq by the table, Maryam by the bedroom threshold, Elias holding the door, and the older man asking where to put the screws so no child swallowed one later. It took him perhaps two seconds.

“Wrap them in paper and mark them,” he said to the older man. To Elias: “Not on the sill. In the blue tin.” To the younger one: “Lift from that side or you will take the door with you.” To Maryam, and here his voice changed only by a grain: “You came.”

“The packet—”

“Yes,” he said, as if packet were answer enough and no dignity was gained by forcing her to enlarge it. Then to Tariq: “Did the registry copy satisfy the cousin’s man?”

“He signed. The surveyor note is in the packet.”

“Good.”

No theatre in either man. That was perhaps why the room became more dangerous, not less. Each treated the other exactly as the work

required, and nothing in the work admitted what else now stood in it.
When the bed men had gone down with the mattress and frame and the
bedroom showed floorboards where no one had seen floorboards in years,
Hanna stood in the doorway wiping plaster dust from his cuff.
“It looks larger,” he said.
“It looks ruder,” said Aunt Widad from the landing, where she had
apparently materialised from instinct for removal.
“No room was ever improved by becoming honest,” said Hanna.
The line might once have belonged to Yusef. Coming from Hanna it sounded
less like wit than a report filed under protest.
Hanna picked up his hat again. “I will go ahead to the house,” he said
to Maryam. “If you come now, we can still reach luncheon before the
children overturn order entirely.”
He did not ask whether she was coming. He assumed sequence. That, too,
was his form of mercy.
At luncheon he spoke to Huda about the cousin’s landlord, to her mother
about the price of paraffin, to Aunt Widad about the cemetery receipt,
and to Ibrahim about why a bed removed from a room did not thereby make
the room available for marbles. He did not once speak to Maryam in a
tone different from the one he would have used before breakfast. That
proved nothing and made nothing easier.
Huda had written the Beirut letter after all. It lay by her plate,

folded and refolded. After luncheon she handed it to Hanna.
“You know the better phrasing for men who think they are being
generous,” she said.
He read it at the table because she had asked him to. “The wording is
fine,” he said.
“That usually means it is not.”
“It means only that if you ask to be taken in indefinitely, they will
grow moral before they grow honest. Ask for ten days. Leave room for
extension. People are more generous with increments than with lives.”
Aunt Widad, still at the table because no household emergency had yet
successfully excluded her, said, “That is true of money as well.”
Huda looked down. “I do not wish to appear mercenary.”
“You wish to appear temporary,” said Hanna. “It is not the same thing.”
“Is it still temporary?” she asked.
The table went still. Hanna set down the letter.
“We still have rooms,” he said. “That is the only sentence I can
guarantee today.”
Her mother said, “Rooms are not plans.”
“No. They are what make plans unnecessary for one more night.”
After the meal Amina said to Maryam, without looking at her, “The black
shoes are in the passage. I left the soles outward.”
Maryam said, “I am not going out again today.”
“Then the shoes will enjoy their certainty without you.”
Later she sat upstairs, hearing Huda cough in the next room and Hanna
close a drawer below, and thought of the room at Yusef’s flat now

containing no bed and therefore no last lie of ordinary life. There were
people all over the city already arranging transport for mothers, rooms
for teachers, places in carts, copies of notices, spare corners in
cousins' houses, ways south that were not comfortable but were still
ways.
Only she, among them all, had replied to urgency with a sentence that
allowed nothing to move.
By dusk there was another thin household sitting. Her mother drank tea
and complained that the Talbiya woman had come only to say her brother's
route was now impossible after dark, which proved that people no longer
understood condolence. Aunt Widad said condolences now travelled like
contraband and ought not to be judged by old standards. Huda had sealed
the Beirut letter but not yet given it to the boy. She kept touching the
flap as though it might still open by shame.
Hanna came in with two smaller sheets tucked into the registry copy and
dust at one cuff where the bed had marked him. He washed his hands, came
back, and wrote the cousin's street more clearly beneath Huda's hand.
"Samir's driver leaves before nine," he said. "If the road south remains
open at all, it will be open then."
Then he took from his pocket a folded list and laid it beside the tea
things. It contained, in his narrow hand, the names of those for whom

there might be transport south if the month worsened: Huda and Ibrahim
first; perhaps Aunt Widad if she ceased calling every contingency
melodrama; one trunk only; linen reduced; papers in inner pocket; no
silver unless sewn into hems by someone more patient than himself.
He did not read the list aloud. He only looked at it once, added a word,
and folded it again. But Maryam saw it, and seeing it altered the room
more than if he had announced it.
At dusk Amina brought up the brushed coat and set it over the chairback
without comment. Then, as she turned to go, she said, “If you leave
shoes in the passage, leave the black ones. The brown still tell more.”
“I know,” said Maryam.
Amina rested one hand on the doorframe. “Knowing is usually the easier
half.”
Then she went downstairs.
Maryam stood looking at the coat, the dressing table, the packet on the
chair, the room that had once been merely hers and now felt already as
though it contained too many arrangements and not enough decisions.
Outside, the quarter was entering evening with the attention of a place
that expected interruption. Somewhere below a driver shouted about
sacks. Somewhere farther off a wireless was being tuned badly.
Nothing had been settled. Beds were removed, rooms measured, notes

written, places offered, routes discussed, mothers considered, cousins
accommodated. Practical life had continued in full possession of its
powers. Only the central question had remained where it was, neither
answered nor refused, simply placed between two people and left there.
She remained where she was until Amina came up again with the lamp and
said, as if remarking only on weather, “Your mother says if there is to
be more writing to Beirut, it is better done before supper than after
tears.”
Maryam turned her head. “What tears?”
Amina set down the lamp. “The ones everybody is now arranging for
later.”

CHAPTER XVI

Narrowing Streets

The first thing Maryam registered on waking was not light but occupation.

Somebody was in the passage outside her room, not trying to be quiet, simply moving with the confidence of a person who had slept under another roof and been told to make use of it. A basin touched a wall. A child coughed. A door that was not hers opened and shut with the irritated care of a house already full beyond the point at which doors wished to close properly. For a moment she lay still, looking at the chair where she had left her dress, and could not remember whether she had slept or only lain in bed until noise folded itself over her.

Then she remembered at once: Huda and Ibrahim in the spare room, Aunt Widad's insistence that a child should not sleep near a front window now, Hanna carrying the camp bed through the corridor as though it were only another piece of furniture and not an admission, the registry copy under the sugar bowl because there had been nowhere safer to keep it, Amina brushing her coat in the pantry without comment, and, behind all of that, the flat and the room and the fact which sleep had not altered.

The room was colder than it had been a week earlier. February had sharpened in the night. The window did not seal properly and the curtains moved a little at the hem though the glass was shut. On the table beside the bed lay the envelope Hanna had placed there himself: baptism certificate, marriage certificate, Leila's birth record, two bank papers, one parish note. Last week he would not have set family documents beside a lamp and called that order.

In the corridor Leila was already quarrelling.

"Why is he in my place?"

"Because it is not your place this week," came Amina's answer.

"It was my place yesterday."

"Yesterday has gone."

Maryam opened the door before the quarrel could enlarge itself. The corridor looked narrower than it ever had in daylight. Huda's travelling case stood against the wall with Ibrahim's shoes beside it. A folded blanket lay across the back of a chair because there was nowhere else to put it and no one had yet had the courage to admit that the chair now existed in order to hold blankets.

In the kitchen ordinary work had resumed in the wrong register. Amina had lit both burners. The kettle steamed. A loaf stood open on the table beside the sugar bowl beneath which Hanna's folded registry copy still sat, too important to be left anywhere safer, too temporary to deserve a drawer.

Hanna was already dressed. Not fully, but enough that the day had plainly begun for him some time before she woke. He stood at the end of the table with a cup in one hand and a sheet of paper in the other.

"You slept," he said when he saw her.

It was not a question.

"So did you, apparently."

"Enough."

He glanced at Huda and Ibrahim, then back at Maryam. "The lower road was watched again at dawn. Amina had to come by the gardens."

Amina, slicing bread with more force than the loaf required, said, "By the gardens, around the school, behind the chemist, through mud, past two men who had decided the street belonged to them before breakfast, and up the hill carrying your potatoes. But yes. By the gardens."

Huda said, "My cousin sent word at six that a family from Baq'a had already moved their children to relatives farther in."

Aunt Widad, entering at exactly that moment with her hat not yet pinned on but already disapproving of something, said, "People move children every time a tyre bursts now. It is becoming a fashion."

"It may be a sensible fashion," Hanna said.

The quietness of the answer altered the room more than a louder one would have done.

"I think one notes what people with good information begin doing before they say why they have done it," he added.
Amina put the bread basket down hard enough to make Leila jump. "Then note also that bakers are shortening their hours, which means fear and bread have at least one thing in common: they arrive earlier now."
Leila said, "Morning has facts and potatoes."
"Then respect both," Amina told her.
For a while the day continued in the cramped wrong key of temporary cohabitation. Huda folded and refolded the same three things. Aunt Widad pinned her hat and unpinned it because the first attempt failed to look mournful enough. Ibrahim asked whether he might take the smaller spoon because it made less noise. Leila asked whether he meant to stay forever and was instructed by everyone in the room to keep quiet, which naturally convinced her the question had been excellent.
Before Father Elias arrived, Huda and Maryam spent ten minutes moving linen from one cupboard to another for no reason either of them respected. Huda said, "Your house still smells like itself."
"That is not always praise."
"No. But when one has left a house in the dark it begins to seem like a luxury."
Maryam handed her another stack. Cedar and starch rose from it. "Will you go back?" she asked.
"For what?"
"The rest of your things."
Huda smoothed the top sheet though it required no smoothing. "The rest of my things are things. Ibrahim is already here."
At a quarter to noon Maryam took her coat from the peg. She had delayed long enough to know the delay for what it was. Amina appeared with a cloth parcel. "Bread, cheese, and two apples. If you stay longer than you intend, you will become foolish and call it tiredness."
She walked to the flat by way of the longer road because the shorter one had become, in the language people now

used, not impossible but unwise. A grocer stood outside his own shop door with his stock sheet in one hand and his shop key in the other, as if uncertain which object now mattered more. Two boys carried rolled mattresses between them as solemnly as altar cloth. Qatamon was not emptying, not yet. It was narrowing. Streets felt as if things were happening in them before one arrived and would continue after one had passed.

At the flat the walnut chest had not yet been moved. Elias let her in and said, "Mr al-Khatib is here."

The sitting room looked barer than it had two days earlier. On the wall behind the chest there was a pale rectangle where the wood had protected the plaster from light for years. Tariq was kneeling by the desk with the ledger open across one knee. He stood when he saw her.

"The chest is still here," he said.

"Most old furniture behaves as if it has tenancy rights."

His coat was over the chair back. The patch at the inner wrist of his shirt showed where the cuff had slipped. On the desk lay the municipal papers, the bank letters, and a second pile of pages not Yusef's. On the windowsill the chipped mug stood where it had stood since before Semiramis, rinsed and turned upright beside a folded newspaper. It was the most intimate object in the flat precisely because no one had ever decided it should be there.

They worked with the door open because the men were in the stair and because no one had to tell either of them that a shut door had become an act. The remaining papers proved less important than the first piles had promised: old parish circulars, an insurance form concerning water damage, two account books, a packet of receipts that belonged to a man dead ten years and had no business still being in Yusef's drawer.

He took one of the apples from the parcel without asking, cut it with Yusef's paper knife into uneven pieces, and set two on a folded newspaper between them.

"Have you eaten?" he asked.

"Enough."

"That is not what the parcel suggests."
In the stair the men moved the chest an inch and let it down again. The floor trembled slightly under the weight.
"Will you go?" she asked, hearing too late how the sentence might sound.
He answered the safer version. "Back to the school? After this."
"No. I mean if the roads narrow further."
He laid the knife down. "The practical answer is that I will go if my mother can be moved and if there is a road worth the risk. The other answer is that people do not leave one thing only. They leave what still clings to it."
When the men finally entered for the chest, the room surrendered itself at once to their competence. Tariq held the door wider while they angled the wood through it and one handle caught against the frame. Dust came down from the upper moulding. Maryam coughed. The chest cleared by less than an inch.
After they had gone, the room was not larger. It only looked as if something had been removed that could not be replaced by size.
"You should go," Tariq said.
It was not dismissal. It was care badly disguised as timing. He had drawn the school pages a little nearer her. Attendance lists, though attendance had become the wrong word. Beside some names were notes in his hand: gone to relatives in Jericho, mother asks for papers, to be sent ahead if possible.
"They are leaving already," she said.
"They are being sent ahead," he said. "That is the respectable phrase."
"And the unrespectable one?"
"That people are beginning to count how much of a child can be moved in advance of a household."
She put the pages down. When he spoke again the edge had left his voice, which somehow made it worse.
"I asked you a practical question," he said. "I have not asked it again. I am trying, for the present, to mistake that for patience."

Below them somebody shouted for a porter. The sound rose through the window and fell away.

Maryam said, "There is no answer that does not destroy something."

"That was true last week."

"It is truer now."

"Yes." He put the satchel on the chair beside him. "Which is why I have not asked the question again."

She wanted to say something that would alter the room irreparably. Instead she said, "Do not leave the ledger in the little room. The dust there gets into everything."

It was an absurd sentence and therefore the only one she could trust.

He answered in the same key. "Then perhaps that room is more honest than the rest of the house."

When she left, Elias was helping guide the chest on to the cart. A woman from the neighbouring building stood with a bowl in her hands and watched as if furniture had become public information.

She did not take the same road back. A cart loaded with bedsteads had jammed the turn by the school and a British lorry had chosen that exact moment to assert a right of passage no one else was in a position to refuse. She stood with three other women while the cart was angled and re-angled and the driver of the lorry performed authority through his teeth. One of the women held a birdcage under her shawl. Another had a baby tied to her back and a saucepan in her free hand. No one addressed the absurdity because absurdity had become expensive.

By the time she reached the grocer's corner the knot had dissolved into smaller purposes. The birdcage went one way, the bedsteads another, the lorry forward at last with its unnecessary certainty. What had changed was not only traffic. Every small delay now seemed to threaten the next three things in line behind it.

At home Amina opened the door with a button tin in one hand. "The chest has gone and no one has died," she called towards the back room. Then, more quietly: "Hanna has been home and out again. He left a note."

The note lay under the salt cellar. Hanna's hand, fast and clean: If I am late, do not wait supper. Keep the envelope with the certificates in your room tonight.
Not wait supper. Keep the envelope in your room. Everything was being advanced a quarter-turn from ordinary. Not enough for proclamation. Enough to make habit begin looking foolish.
In the passage Leila and Ibrahim had built a roadway marked out by books and blocks along which Ibrahim's two tin cars could travel without touching the floorboards.
"It is the long road," Leila explained. "The short road has bad men in it."
"Who told you that?"
"No one. Ibrahim did."
Ibrahim, kneeling over the cars, said without looking up, "Everyone knows."
That, Maryam thought, was how children were now being educated. Not by schoolbooks alone but by the new geography of hearsay.
A little after one Father Elias sent himself, together with a young man from the parish carrying a school exercise book and the expression of someone who had been sent to count misfortune in other people's houses and had not yet learnt the correct face for it. The young man asked how many rooms could be closed off if needed, how many beds were presently in use, and how many children were in the house.
"Two here now," Huda said. "One ours, one not."
Leila, listening from the doorway, said, "I am not not. I belong here."
Father Elias turned to her at once. "And therefore your place is the stronger one," he said. "Which means you may help by not standing in thresholds."
Maryam answered what she could and disliked the sound of her own answers, because numbers made hospitality look like stock-taking and stock-taking turned affection into available surface.

When the young man had finished counting and gone, Huda said, "It did not make me feel safer. It made me feel included."

As the light began to fail, Amina came to the pantry door holding an old pillowcase knotted at the top.

"I will leave this here tonight, if you please."

"What is in it?" Leila asked at once.

"A woman's future," Amina said. "Two aprons, one shawl, stockings, and soap."

The name Deir Yassin entered the house not through the radio first but through bread.

Amina came in one morning carrying two loaves under one arm and no expression on her face at all, which in itself was an announcement. She set the bread down, untied her scarf, and said, "The convent side is full of people who are not going where they said."

"What does that mean?" her mother asked.

"It means women from outside the quarter are carrying children and not stopping to greet. It means one cart had no bedding and three suitcases, which is never a visit."

Aunt Widad arrived fifteen minutes later without hat pin, gloves unmatched, and one button on her cuff unfastened. That was what passed in their world for running.

"It is Deir Yassin," she said from the hall before anybody had formally admitted her.

Her mother closed her eyes once. "Can one morning not arrive properly through the door?"

"No," said Aunt Widad. "Mornings no longer trust doors."

Hanna stood. "Who told you?"

"Salma's neighbour's son, who heard it from a taxi driver, which under better conditions would make the whole thing fiction. Under worse conditions it makes it early."

Leila said, "Is it another hotel?"

"No," said Hanna. He hesitated, not from softness but from accuracy. "A village."

"Not at table," her mother said.

"At table is precisely where it belongs," Aunt Widad answered. "Everything belongs at table once it has begun entering houses."

From the school a note arrived in Tariq's hand: Do not send Leila by carriage if the driver is from outside the quarter. Use the convent road. Come early.

Hanna took it from Maryam's hand before she had decided whether that movement would look guilty. He read it, gave it back, and said, "He is right about the driver."

The room altered on its hinges. A man's rightness had become, by noon, another household duty. Maryam folded the note once and placed it beneath her saucer.

Hanna left with his hat still unbrushed. That detail, more than all the names in circulation, frightened Maryam. Hanna did not neglect hats.

By afternoon Deir Yassin had stopped being merely a name and become a method of speech. People no longer said, "Have you heard?" They said, "If even that is possible..." and left the sentence open because openness itself had begun doing more damage than completion.

That evening Amina failed to go home.

It happened not grandly but by accumulation. She had stayed later because the milk boiled over, because Leila's ribbon had gone missing, because a note for Hanna had arrived after dusk. By the time she tied her scarf and reached the gate, the lower road had begun producing those sharp running clusters of men who made even sensible people walk back indoors pretending they had forgotten something.

She returned three minutes later and said, "I will sleep here."

Her mother looked up from the account book. "In the servants' room?"

"Where else?"

"There is no need to make announcements."

"There is if someone will otherwise bolt the side door."

That silenced the room in a new way. Not because Amina had been insolent. Because she had stated, in the plain grammar of labour, that a route had failed.

Aunt Widad set down her cup. "Then take the side room. Not the bench."

After supper the house held more silence than the number of people in it should have allowed. Shoes now meant departure. An envelope meant proof. A pillowcase knotted at the top meant a woman whose route home had failed. A child's road of books in the passage meant that even play had accepted the map of danger.

When the children had been got upstairs and Huda had taken her darning to the spare room, Maryam found Hanna in their bedroom with the wardrobe doors open. He was not rummaging. He was selecting.

Two changes of linen. One warm cardigan for Leila — the thicker one she disliked because it scratched her neck. One of Maryam's darker dresses folded without tenderness. The envelope of certificates. Stockings, rolled. Her small jewellery case, not the larger box.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

"Choosing the things one would not wish to choose quickly."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the whole answer."

"We are not leaving tonight," Maryam said.

"No."

"Or tomorrow."

"I have not said tomorrow."

"You have said shoes by beds and papers by lamps and now this."

He set the little case on the chair. "So that if I say we should move for two days, I do not have to stand here while you argue with me about stockings."

"Two days."

"Yes."

"And if two becomes five?"

"Then five becomes five."

She turned away because there was nowhere in the room to direct her anger that did not make it childish.

"I am not asking you to like this," he said. "Only not to leave it until liking is no longer one of the options."

Then, because he was tired and too near the truth, he added, "I think you would still be choosing a coat that made it look as if you were returning."
The accuracy of it shocked them both.
"I should not have said that," he said at once.
"No," she answered. "You should not."
But the wound lay there because it was near enough to truth to have blood in it.
He lifted the case from the bed and set it on the chair. It was not large. That was the last insult. Its size told the truth about every sentimental instinct she had not yet had time to examine: that what could be moved might not be what she thought most necessary, and what she could not imagine leaving might be asked of her without ceremony.
In the little room off the kitchen the spare mattress creaked once as Amina lay down in a house not her own because the streets between houses had begun behaving like arguments. Upstairs Leila turned in sleep. From somewhere beyond the shutters came a burst of sound too sustained to mistake and too far to fix precisely. Not thunder. Not boys. Not anything houses built for correctness could comfortably classify.
Maryam stood with one hand on the hall table. On it lay the folded list, the registry copy, the pin dish, and one of Leila's blue pencils with the point bitten off. No single object had changed. Together they had begun to look like preparation.
Hanna came out behind her, removing his cufflinks one by one.
"The lower road is finished after dusk," he said.
"For tonight?"
"For now."
He set the cufflinks in the dish beside the pencil. "Tomorrow I will fetch the last of Yusef's papers before noon. After that I am not certain the flat should remain one of our habits."
He said it as he said everything difficult: not to wound, not to reveal, but to place the next usable fact in front of whoever had to live with it.

Maryam looked at the table. "Nothing remains one of our habits."

"No," he said.

From the next room came Leila's sleeping breath. From the side room Amina's silence. From outside, men calling to one another in the short, unmusical tones that meant carrying, not conversation.

Tomorrow would arrive early again.

CHAPTER XVII

The Third Letter

The third letter arrived folded into itself so many times that the outer sheet had gone soft at the creases.

Maryam found it on the hall table beneath the saucer where Hanna now kept loose keys and under the school circular Leila had brought home the day before with jam on one corner. The address had been crossed out twice. The first hand was Nadia’s, the second not. A redirection in another hand had been squeezed along the margin so tightly that the final word bent into the stamp.

She stood with her gloves still on and looked at the envelope before she opened it. For a moment she thought absurdly that if she left it shut she might preserve the version of Nadia that still wrote as though Beirut were a temporary inconvenience arranged by cousins. Then Leila came running from the passage with only one stocking on and said, “Amina says there is no hot water because someone forgot there was a fire,” and the envelope became another object that had to be dealt with.

In the kitchen Huda was already dressed to go out, Ibrahim still in his undershirt and cross because he had lost one of his school books beneath the camp bed. The side room smelled of damp blanket and yesterday’s coal. Amina, who had now slept two nights in the side room because the lower road had not improved either morning, stood at the stove with her scarf tied badly and a spoon in one hand.

“No hot water because the kettle was put on the small burner and then your daughter asked me where her blue

ribbon was and your aunt asked whether rice had become more expensive since last week and Huda wanted pins," she said, before Maryam could speak. "So now there will be hot water in five minutes if nobody asks anything else of me."

Leila said, "Where is my blue ribbon?"

Amina closed her eyes briefly. "Exactly so."

Huda turned from the table, fastening one cuff. "I can take Ibrahim to his cousin and come back before luncheon. That would help."

"It would help if you came back," Amina said. "Going out is always generous. Returning is the useful part."

Huda laughed because she had not yet been in the house long enough to know when Amina's remarks were jokes and when they were inventory.

Maryam took the letter to the window and opened it with the bread knife because no one had put the paper knife back in the drawer after Yusef's things were sorted into smaller and smaller categories. Nadia's hand was the same and not the same. It slanted a little more now and crowded the margin less because the sheet itself had become shorter. There was no opening fuss, no report of weather, no mention of which cousin had lent which room. The first sentence was practical.

Bring papers first. Bring only what can be carried without discussion.

Then came the list that was not a list and therefore harder to bear. Milk uncertain. Two children with coughs. Too many shoes in one passage. A woman from Haifa sleeping in the dining room and apologising for her dreams. The

landlord patient for now. Another address may follow. Do not wait for everything to become clear, because clarity is now what people ask for after it has become useless.

At the end Nadia had written, more tightly as if the line had been added with the sheet already folded once, *I am telling you this without drama because there is enough of that elsewhere. Come before your reasons begin sounding respectable to you.*

Maryam read the last sentence again.

“A bad one?” Huda asked.

Maryam looked up. “A practical one.”

Huda gave the small nod of someone who had begun to understand that practical letters were now the worst kind. She tied her hat ribbon beneath her chin and said to Ibrahim, “Shoes.”

“I have them on.”

“Then try not to look as if you are being deported to school.”

“School is worse than being deported.”

No one contradicted him. That, more than the child’s words, altered the morning.

Maryam folded the letter once and put it into her pocket. She thought she would answer it at once, before breakfast, before Aunt Widad arrived, before Hanna came back from the parish office, before the house resumed its bad imitation of sequence. Instead she spent ten minutes finding Leila’s second shoe, seven more locating the blue ribbon in the drawer where Leila herself had hidden it, and another fifteen looking for the small bottle of stomach

drops her mother declared had vanished because people no longer respected drawers.

By the time she sat at the dining table with paper before her, the kitchen had become too loud and the hall too narrow for thought. Huda and Ibrahim had gone. Amina was rinsing the same pan for the third time because each interruption had added something else to it. Her mother was in the drawing room telling Aunt Widad, who had arrived without knocking, that the house no longer ran on hours but on incursions.

Maryam wrote, *My dearest Nadia,* and stopped.

The form of the sentence looked false at once. Not false in affection. Nadia was dear to her, had always been dearer than the cousins who took offence as a hobby and charity as rank. False in tone. *Dearest* belonged to a letter that still had room for weather and visits and the size of a child's appetite. She drew a line through it and began again.

Nadia,

That looked worse.

She sat with the pen lifted and listened to the house.

Aunt Widad in the next room saying that one could not expect servants to sleep in and out of a house indefinitely without confusion entering every shelf. Her mother answering that confusion had entered long before the servant stayed. Amina setting down crockery with the degree of care that meant her temper was at work beneath it. From upstairs the noise of Leila singing to herself and missing the tune by confidence rather than error.

Maryam wrote, *We received your letter this morning and were grateful for it.*

This was true and dead.

She looked at the line until the ink dried. Then she folded the paper once without tearing it, put it beneath Nadia's letter, and slid both under the account book at the end of the table. She told herself she would answer after luncheon, when the house had thinned. She did not quite believe herself, which made the gesture cleaner and uglier at once.

Hanna came in at eleven carrying a smaller bundle of Yusef's papers under one arm and two loaves of bread under the other. The papers were tied with blue string. The bread had flour on the crust from a hand not yet washed.

"The parish copy is missing," he said by way of greeting.

Aunt Widad said, "Missing or misfiled?"

"In a church office those are often theological variations on the same condition."

He set the loaves down, then the papers. "Father Elias believes he can find the burial notation if the younger clerk has not put April into March again."

Maryam said, "Did you go to the flat?"

"No. There is nothing left worth a journey except the parish ledger, and I did not want to stand in that room while being told a porter might be available in the afternoon or next week."

Aunt Widad said, "Then the room is nearly finished."

"Nearly is what everything is now," Hanna said.

Hanna untied the string and began removing the papers with the expression of a man who had already accepted

that every useful object in the house would now need to coexist on tables with every object not meant for tables at all.

There was a map among Yusef's things. Not a military map, not even a current one, but a school map of Jerusalem mounted on linen with the edges cracked. Hanna spread it beside the bread knife and weighted one corner with the sugar bowl.

"What is that doing there?" Maryam asked.

"Being useful."

"For what?"

"For seeing which roads are now stories and which are still roads."

He spoke without flourish. That was his way. A more expressive man would have turned the sentence into warning. Hanna laid it flat between loaf, sugar, and unpaid bill, and it became part of breakfast.

He marked nothing on it. He only looked. The lower road. The road by the gardens. The line towards the parish. The turn near the school. Later, she saw, the map would become the kind of object people began glancing at without admitting they were doing it.

At luncheon Amina failed to appear with the rice.

This would once have meant little: a pan late on the stove, a servant distracted, an aunt making remarks about standards. Now it altered the room at once. Huda was not yet back, Ibrahim with her, Leila whining because the lentils were touching the spoon, Maryam's mother speaking about weakness in the tones of someone accusing

fatigue of bad breeding. When Amina finally came in she had flour on one sleeve and a rip in the edge of her apron.

“What happened?” Maryam asked.

“The baker had shut,” Amina said. “Then he had opened again. Then his wife decided one must pay now and not tomorrow because tomorrow had begun speaking too loudly for her liking. Then the neighbour wanted the old jar back and could not remember which old jar she meant.”

She set down the rice. “I am telling you the whole story because I know if I say only that the baker delayed, your aunt will conclude bread has become a form of indiscipline.”

Aunt Widad said, “I am sitting here.”

“I have never relied on invisibility where you are concerned.”

Hanna, who had been dividing the smaller loaf as if bread too must now be portioned with foresight, said, “Sit down and eat.”

“I still have to go home.”

“You may not manage both.”

Amina looked at him. “I know.”

The admission passed across the table like another dish, one no one wished to be handed but each understood was there.

She did not sit long. Before the plates were cleared she had rinsed her hands, changed the torn apron for the older dark one, and tied on her scarf. From the side room she

took the knotted pillowcase she had begun leaving by the door as if it were both luggage and proof.

“If the lower road is watched,” Hanna said, not looking up from the bread knife, “go by your sister’s and send word if you can.”

“I know where my sister lives.”

“That is not the doubtful part.”

Amina tucked the pillowcase beneath her arm. “If I do not return, you will notice. That is enough system for one day.”

She went out by the upper road without further ceremony. Maryam watched from the window until the scarf disappeared beyond the Abu-Rashids’ wall. What unsettled her was not that Amina had gone but how quickly the house rearranged itself around the fact. The side room door remained half open. The folded blanket stayed where it had been. No one said whether that counted as prudence or expectation.

After luncheon Huda returned with Ibrahim and a paper parcel of thread she claimed to have found only because one shopkeeper had not yet learnt to look frightened before noon. Ibrahim brought back school copybooks and a story about two boys fighting over a map. Leila demanded to know who won. He answered, “The teacher,” which was not the sort of answer children expected and therefore impressed her.

The day then broke into the kind of bad pieces that only a house under pressure can produce. The milk turned. A button came off Ibrahim’s coat. Huda had to go back out because she had left the cousin’s house key in the cousin’s passage and the cousin had gone to visit an aunt with weak

lungs. Father Elias called and asked whether Hanna still had the older receipt book because a young man from the office had made a face at him when asked to look for the register. Maryam found herself boiling a kettle herself because no one else had the right instinct for which pot belonged on which flame once the kitchen lost the person who usually thought three movements ahead.

At half past two the chemist's delivery boy knocked for payment on a bottle her mother had ordered three days earlier and only now received. He could not have been more than twelve. His ears stuck out from his cap and his bicycle leaned against the wall with an optimism the bicycle did not deserve. Hanna, who had returned briefly for the parish receipt, asked the boy which route he meant to take back.

"Upper road first," the boy said. "Then whichever one still belongs to God."

Hanna took the grocer's circular from the sideboard, turned it over, and wrote standing up: *If the lower road is watched, do not attempt it. Go to your sister's if safer and send word by the boy. Come tomorrow by the upper way only if passable.* He folded the paper twice and gave it to the boy with the chemist's coins. "The woman who works here," he said. "Near the lower road beyond the gardens."

The boy nodded and went off up the road with the medicine parcel bumping against the carrier. Maryam watched from the window and thought, not for the first time, that the household's correspondence had begun requiring boys on bicycles and the backs of grocers' circulars because the ordinary means of reaching even one's own servant had ceased to be ordinary.

Towards four the boy returned. On the back of Hanna's note, in a square hand none of them knew, someone had written: *She is with her sister. Lower road bad after noon. She will try tomorrow by the upper way if possible. Do not send after dark.*

Hanna read it once, then placed the paper under the salt cellar. "Then that is that for today," he said.

He did not remove the blanket from the side room. Instead he told Ibrahim not to stack his copybooks on the bench there and asked Huda to leave the small lamp in place.

By four o'clock the unsent letter still lay beneath the account book.

Maryam took it out and went upstairs with it, not because there was more room in the bedroom but because there was less witness. The house could hear paper downstairs. Upstairs it heard only footsteps.

She sat on the bed with Nadia's letter open beside her and tried again.

We are managing.

She crossed that out at once. It was the sort of phrase one used when one wished not to be contradicted by fact.

The city is altered daily, though this may no longer distinguish us from anyone else.

That stayed for perhaps three seconds.

Hanna is making arrangements for eventualities that refuse to name themselves.

She stared at that until she laughed once, without amusement. It sounded like someone else.

From the window she could see the upper part of the Abu-Rashids' wall and the top of a ladder propped against it for some repair that had not progressed in two days. A dog barked below street level. Somewhere farther off a man shouted and was answered by no one she could hear.

She wrote nothing further. At last she folded the half-page, put it into the envelope without sealing it, and slid the whole thing between two books on the bedside shelf. Not hidden. Deferred. That was worse.

When she came downstairs again, the house had already changed arrangement without consulting her. Huda was winding thread on a card. Ibrahim had fallen asleep in the chair nearest the door with one shoe off. Leila was on the floor playing with the blue pencil Hanna had left by the map and was using the streets of Jerusalem as roads for a button she had declared was now a bus.

"Not on that," Hanna said.

She looked up. "Why?"

"Because it is not a toy."

"What is it then?"

He glanced at the map and then at Maryam, as if answering the child might commit him to a sentence he was not yet prepared to hear spoken by adults. "A record," he said.

Leila considered the word, then moved the button onto the edge of the chair instead. This was perhaps the greatest concession anyone had made all day.

The evening meal was later than usual and worse. Bread, olives, lentils reheated once and then again because no one

judged the timing correctly, some white cheese Huda had brought wrapped in paper from the cousin’s house. Her mother ate more than she had done the week before and then complained that no one had noticed her appetite returning. Aunt Widad, not present for once, was represented by a jar she had sent and a note reminding Hanna that clerks often lost things more completely when pressed to find them. Hanna read the note, folded it, and put it under the sugar bowl with the map.

No one said that Amina would not be back that night. No one said the opposite either. The side room door remained ajar. Through it Maryam could see the edge of the folded blanket and the lamp Huda had left on the shelf. The room looked less like a room than a place being kept ready for a sentence not yet spoken.

Only after Leila had been got upstairs, after Ibrahim had been shaken awake and pointed at the correct bed, after Huda had located her comb and her cousin’s key and her own temper, did the house briefly quiet.

Maryam found herself alone in the dining room with the lamp lowered and the map still on the table. Nadia’s letter was in her pocket again, carried there all day like a proof she had not yet answered. The string-tied packet from Yusef’s flat lay beside the salt cellar. No object in the room had been born to live with any other, yet none of them looked temporary any longer.

She could hear Hanna in the passage moving one of the chairs a few inches from the wall and then back again, because sometimes that was how his worry travelled: through furniture corrected by fractions. From the side room came nothing at all. Upstairs Leila called once in

sleep for water, then resettled herself without waking enough to want it.

In the morning room the escritoire still held Nawal's card where she had put it after Semiramis. She went to it, drew the card out, read only the hotel name and not the hand beneath it, and then returned it to the drawer without reordering the other letters there. She could not have said when the house had stopped keeping its own order. Not in broken objects. In the small failures of previous exactness.

She went upstairs with Nadia's letter still unanswered. On the bedside shelf lay the half-page she had folded that afternoon, slid between two books. Not hidden. Deferred. She did not take it out.

From the next room came Huda's cough and then Ibrahim turning over. From below, Hanna closing a drawer. From the side room, nothing at all except the fact of the room being kept ready. The house held more lives than it had been built to hold. Every one of them seemed to be waiting for a sentence someone else would have to speak first.

CHAPTER XVIII

The Note

By breakfast the house had begun measuring itself in shorter units.
Not by any declaration that one kind of life had ended and another
begun. Nothing so theatrical. It was smaller than that. The back door
was bolted after each trip to the yard instead of left on the latch. The
map remained on the dining table because Hanna had not rolled it the
night before and no one now wished to be the first to put away an object
that had lately begun telling more truth than most people. The front
windows were left only partly open because Aunt Widad said the morning
looked indecent when one could not trust a road. These were not yet the
gestures of departure. They were worse. They were the manners by which a
household tried to preserve ordinary form while admitting, in fractions,
that ordinary form had started failing.
Maryam came downstairs with Leila's cardigan over one arm and the
child's second stocking in her hand. Leila had found the first and lost
the second in the space of ten minutes, which struck Maryam as a species
of genius. It was easier to resent a stocking than to think about the
map, the side room, or the fact that later had stopped meaning what it
used to.

Amina had come by the upper way before dawn had properly declared
itself. Mud had dried in a pale line along the hem of her skirt. The
knotted pillowcase stood near the dresser and one of the black shoes she
wore when the road turned bad was drying at an angle by the stove no
shoe would have chosen for itself. She was cutting bread with more force
than the loaf required. Huda, trying to do three tasks at once and doing
only one well, was plaiting Leila's hair so tightly that the child
looked briefly like an obedient version of herself. Ibrahim sat at the
end of the table in his school shirt with a copybook open beside the
bread plate and a pencil behind one ear, as if he had already
apprenticed himself to some municipal sorrow.
"It hurts," Leila said.
"That means it will hold," said Huda.
"That is a bad principle."
"It is a common one."
Maryam moved the kettle from the smaller burner to the larger. The
gesture felt so precisely like Amina's that for a second she almost
asked where the good tea had been put. Instead she set the kettle
straight and said, "Where is Hanna?"
"Parish office," said Huda. "He said he would be back before the bread
man lost patience."
"The bread man lost patience months ago," Aunt Widad called from the
next room.

“The bread man continues anyway,” said Amina. “That is why he still has
bread.”
Her mother had not yet appeared. From behind the bedroom door had come
one cough, one request for hotter water, and one remark about how
families became barbarous the moment a servant was absent. Nobody
answered. Without Amina, or without the certainty of Amina, the house
changed key. Things still happened, but they happened without the old
confidence that someone else had already noticed them in time.
When Hanna came in he had two loaves under one arm, the school circular
folded into his pocket, and the look he wore when private preference had
become sequence. He set the bread down, took off his hat, and handed the
circular to Maryam.
“You collect Leila by two,” he said.
She read it standing. The headmaster’s notice had been corrected in
darker ink twice, as if the school itself no longer trusted a sentence
to remain accurate for the length of its own delivery. Younger children
were to be collected by family if possible. Afternoon lessons might not
continue. The lower way was discouraged. Use the convent road.
“Two is not early,” she said.
“It is now.”
Her mother entered at that moment, shawl not properly settled and one
stocking already giving up at the ankle. “If schools cannot remain

school there is little point pretending to civilisation.”
Aunt Widad appeared behind her. “Civilisation has always depended on
women believing notices written by men who do not carry children or
shopping.”
Amina put down the bread basket. “If the child is to be fetched by two,
then everyone who intends to be dramatic should finish early. I came by
the upper road. It was already behaving like an afterthought by the
gardens.”
Ibrahim, who had learnt in one week of displacement how to listen while
pretending to concern himself with spoons, asked whether he ought still
to take all his copybooks. Hanna said yes. Keep them in the satchel. Do
not leave them in the desk. Leila wanted to know whether maps had become
dangerous, since adults now discussed roads before breakfast and kept
school things on dining tables. Nobody improved the question.
Breakfast went on in the cramped wrong key that had become the house’s ordinary register. Huda forgot the salt in the eggs. Amina remembered and said nothing about having remembered. Hanna buttered his slice without reply and looked once towards the hall, as if timing departures against an inner schedule none of the others fully shared.
When the cups had been cleared, the day separated itself in the new
order. Hanna left first with the circular in his inside pocket and the
transport list beneath it, as if school policy and family contingency

now belonged under the same buttoned cloth. Huda took Ibrahim by the
convent side because it was judged marginally less disputable before
noon. Amina said she would wash up now in case water later became
argumentative. Her mother went back to the drawing room, where napkins
were being sorted not by colour but by durability for travel she still
insisted on calling hypothetical.

Maryam sat at the dining table with Nadia’s third letter in one hand and
an empty sheet in the other. The envelope itself seemed fatigued. It had
been redirected twice, and the second hand had squeezed the new address
into the margin so tightly that the final word bent into the stamp. She
looked at it, then at the blank paper, and knew before she put down the
pen that she would not answer it properly.

She tried all the same. Dear Nadia looked false. My dear Nadia looked
worse. We are managing was the sort of sentence one wrote only when one
wanted language to collude in not being contradicted by fact. She
produced three lines so bloodless they might have been drafted by a
clerk instructed to imitate sympathy, then folded the page without
tearing it and slipped both letter and half-answer beneath the account
book at the end of the table. She told herself she would return to them
after collecting Leila. The promise had the stale respectability of all
her better postponements.

At half past eleven a parish boy came with a message from Father Elias
about the missing register. The younger clerk, it appeared, had indeed
put April into March again and would need correction before supper.
Maryam laid the slip under the sugar bowl beside the map and noticed
with a weariness almost comic in its exactness that every flat surface
in the house was now either being used for paper or waiting to be.
Her mother, watching from the doorway, said, “Everything worth keeping
now lives in public.”
“Private life has become a bad investment,” said Aunt Widad.
By one o’clock Leila’s thicker cardigan had been found, folded, misplaced, and found again. Maryam changed into the black shoes because the convent road had loose paving and went downstairs.
Her mother said, “Bring back the child before three if you can. After that the light becomes argumentative.”
The road by the convent had not closed, but it had acquired the brittle
crowding of a place on which too many unrelated decisions had begun
depending. A butcher’s assistant ran past with wrapped parcels held
against his chest as if meat itself had become a document requiring
haste. Two mattresses leaned against a wall beside a trunk roped badly
enough to suggest either panic or the absence of any man willing to tie
it twice. Outside the chemist a woman argued about a receipt with the
intensity of someone defending not a sum but the old order in which a

receipt settled anything.

Maryam took Leila’s hand at the first turning and did not let go. The child compensated for the quicker pace by producing questions. Had maps become dangerous? Was Huda’s cousin really their cousin or the sort one kept for doors and soup? Maryam answered two, ignored the rest, and was spared the last by a cart turning too wide at the corner.

At the school gate the porter had been given more authority than he knew how to carry. Names were checked. Children released by class. A young teacher held a register and asked each woman twice for the family name, as if children had begun needing the double proof of belonging. When Leila emerged she had her satchel and the small blue pencil she insisted had become essential between eleven and one. “Miss said to take all school things home,” she announced. “Not the desk. Only the things in it.”

The teacher told Maryam that younger classes might not continue the next day. “Use the upper way if you can.”

The delay began on the return, and began so ordinarily that at first it hardly seemed delay at all. At the chemist the assistant insisted the cough mixture could not be released without the proper signature because yesterday the wrong bottle had gone to the wrong aunt. Maryam signed, waited, took the parcel. Halfway up the road by the gardens a handcart loaded with bedsteads had jammed against a wagon bringing sacks the opposite way. She stood with Leila flattened against the wall while the drivers argued commerce against departure and urgency against width. One of the bedsteads still had a brass finial polished to a point. The absurdity of that detail lodged in her mind long after the vehicles freed one another.

By the time they reached the house Leila had stopped talking altogether,

which was how Maryam knew the child had passed beyond ordinary complaint

into tiredness. The dining room held the look it acquired when several

people had been moving through it separately and no one had yet gathered
enough into one place to decide what sort of afternoon it had become.
Huda sat at the table winding thread on a card. Ibrahim was on the floor
with his satchel open and his copybooks spread around him like papers
awaiting judgement. Her mother lay on the drawing-room sofa with a shawl
over her knees and one of the church bulletins open on her chest,
unread. Amina was back in the kitchen, though whether by the upper road
or by stubbornness Maryam did not yet know. The map remained on the
table. Beside it, not under the sugar bowl but set apart from the other
papers, lay an envelope with her name on it.
Huda looked up first. “You took too long.”
“The roads assisted.”
“Then they assisted in the wrong direction.”
Only then did Maryam take in the paper properly. The hand on the
envelope was exact, upright, not trying to be beautiful. The lower
corner had gone grey where damp fingers or a damp pocket had handled it
too long. She knew the hand before she allowed herself to know it.
“A boy brought it,” said Huda. “School satchel, no hat. He came once and
turned back below the school, then came again by the gardens. He said he
had been sent after the midday bell.”
“When?”
“After four. Closer to five.”
Ibrahim, not looking up from his copybook, said, “He asked if you had

already gone.”
Maryam took the envelope. Her fingers felt colder than the paper. “Gone
where?”
“He did not know,” said Huda. “That was the useful part.”
Her mother lifted the bulletin and looked not at the envelope but at
Maryam’s face. Then she said only, “Take the child’s cardigan off before
she scratches a hole in herself.”
Maryam broke the fold with her thumb. The sheet inside was smaller than
the envelope and had been folded twice.
Today. Four o’clock. The flat.
If you can come, come. I will be there until dark.
T.
There was no explanation, no apology, no sentence attempting to make
need look less like itself. She looked automatically towards the window.
The light beyond the shutters had already gone from afternoon into that
stale, used colour which meant evening was not approaching but had
begun.
Leila, freed of the cardigan at last, asked whether the note was from
school and whether it meant there would be no sums tomorrow. Maryam
folded the paper before answering.
“No.”
“That would have been more useful.”
“Yes.”
The child went to wash her hands under Huda’s supervision. Maryam put
the note back into its envelope and slid it into her coat pocket. She
could feel, through the cloth, the hard line of the fold crossing

Tariq’s name.

Tariq had been in the flat since ten minutes before four.

He had not come early enough to make himself ridiculous, and not so exactly on the hour that he might be accused, even by himself, of treating the meeting like an appointment. The room had already been stripped down to the things no one had yet found a reason to move. The chipped mug stood on the sill, rinsed and turned upright beside the folded newspaper. One chair remained by the table and another nearer the wall. The air held dust, old plaster, and that peculiar stale honesty rooms acquire when they have ceased pretending to belong permanently to anyone.

He had sent the note at noon with a schoolboy who knew the house by sight and the quarter well enough, he had thought, to cross it without requiring instruction in every turning. The message had been brief because anything longer would have made it ask for a kind of answer the day itself could not be trusted to deliver. After the boy had gone, Tariq had folded the newspaper, unfolded it, and finally left it on the sill beneath the mug because reading would have turned the waiting into a performance.

At first the waiting was almost ordinary. Steps on the stair. Voices from the yard. Father Elias crossing once with a ledger under one arm

and saying only, “You are here,” to which Tariq had answered, “For now.”

The priest had nodded as if that were as much truth as either of them should expect from an afternoon and gone down again.

At half past four there were steps on the stair and Tariq rose before he had decided to rise. It was not Maryam. It was Elias again, this time with a coil of rope over one shoulder and a window latch in his hand.

“No one yet?” he asked.

“No.”

“Should I shut the back shutter? It rattles.”

“Leave it.”

The priest did leave it. The shutter went on rattling, not dramatically, merely with the persistent complaint of something that had not been fastened properly since before the week began.

By five the room had changed relation to him. The chair opposite was still empty. The mug on the sill had become too intimate. Footsteps on the stair no longer sharpened into possibility; they only proved that other lives in the building still knew where they were going. Once he went to the window and looked down into the yard, then back at once because visibility was not the same thing as information and the yard offered only the two customary humiliations: other people’s purposes and one’s own lack of them.

When Elias came up a third time, he did not pause in the doorway. He was carrying a small crate of account books and had the tired face of a man

who had started the day as a parish priest and somehow become a porter
by afternoon.
“You need not wait if the roads are bad,” he said.
Tariq answered only, “I know.”
Elias shifted the crate in his arms. “Do you?”
The question might have been insolent in another man. In Elias it
sounded merely exhausted. Tariq did not answer it. After a moment the
priest went on.
The light thinned. Somewhere below, a crate was dropped and somebody
swore with convincing fatigue. At last Tariq took his coat from the
chair, folded the empty half of the newspaper once more for no reason at
all, and left the room as it was. He did not move the mug. He did not
close the shutter. He did not ask Elias whether a boy had returned or a
message had been mislaid or a route had failed. The failure had already
happened. Questioning its method would not improve its fact.
When Hanna came in later, he had Father Elias’s recovered register under
one arm and two oranges in his pocket that made his coat hang unevenly.
He stopped when he saw Maryam still in her outdoor shoes and the
envelope no longer on the table. He set the register down on the
sideboard as if any paper entering the house now had to be made
immediately legible or it would spoil in his hand.
“You are late,” he said.
“The convent road objected to several people.”

He nodded once. His eye went, as it lately went to any place where paper
might be kept, to her pocket and then away again. “A boy came.”
“So I gather.”
“He had been turned back twice below the school.” Hanna removed his hat.
“The lower road has started deciding things for itself.”
He said nothing more, and this was either mercy or fatigue. In him the
two had become difficult to separate. He gave Leila one of the oranges,
told Ibrahim to close the copybook until after supper because no child
had ever been improved by fractions when tired, and asked Amina whether
the lentils had survived. Amina said the lentils had survived but the
second kettle had not. Aunt Widad, arriving precisely then and therefore
able to infer from air alone that some paper of consequence had altered
the room, demanded to know why everyone looked as if conversation had
just been improved beyond tolerance.
“A school message,” said Huda before Maryam could speak.
It was not true. It was not wholly false either, which was why it stood.
Supper was late because nobody had the right measure of the kitchen without Amina’s usual certainty, though Amina was there and cooking. She had stayed rather than attempt the lower road again. Huda reheated the lentils. Her mother complained that the plates were cold and then ate everything set before her. Hanna asked Maryam, without looking at her, whether the chemist had released the correct bottle. She said yes. What mattered had travelled elsewhere on the same journey.

All through the meal the note remained in her pocket. Once, reaching for the salt, she felt the corner of the paper against the inside of her coat and had the impression that if she moved too quickly the fold might declare itself at table.

Only after Leila had been got upstairs and made to say her prayers in a voice suddenly quick, as if brevity itself might protect, did Maryam go to the bedroom and take the note from her pocket.

She read it again by the weaker lamp. The words had not changed and therefore became worse. Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can come, come. I will be there until dark. There was no if possible to ease her, no if you are able to widen the field of failure until it became almost ordinary. There was only an hour, a place, and the plain statement that he would wait as long as the light allowed. She looked at the clock on the chest. It was past nine. Until dark had become a completed fact hours earlier.

There was a knock at the door, not a caller's knock but a domestic one.

"It is me," said Hanna.

She folded the note once and laid it on the coverlet beside her hand.

"Come in."

He stood in the doorway holding Leila's thicker cardigan over one arm and the smaller linen case in the other. He looked not at the note but at the shelf beside the bed where Nadia's unfinished reply still protruded between the books, and then at the open wardrobe.

“I want this filled before you sleep,” he said. “Not heavily. Child’s
things first. Two changes. One warm cardigan. Stockings.”
“For tomorrow?”
“Yes.”
“We are not leaving tomorrow.”
“I did not say leaving.”
“What did you say?”
“That I want this filled before you sleep.”
She looked at the case, then at the note on the bed. “For how long?”
“I do not know.”
“Then how am I to choose?”
“The way one chooses under bad conditions. Too little, then one thing
more.”
He came into the room, put the cardigan at the foot of the bed, and set
the case on the chair by the wardrobe. It was the same small case he had
selected against her temper the previous night, and the insult of its
size had not improved.
“The convent road may not stay passable through another afternoon,” he
said. “I want the child dressed early. Your mother’s certificates are
already in the envelope. Huda will keep Ibrahim’s satchel ready. If
nothing happens, nothing happens. But I am finished depending on if.”
He still did not look at the note. Whether he had not seen it or had
seen it too clearly to grant it shape by acknowledgement, Maryam could
not tell.
“And if I say no?”
His face altered very little. “Then I will spend ten minutes answering a

question whose answer is already occupying the chair.”

When he had gone, Maryam sat with the note in one hand and the open case on the chair beside her. From downstairs came the small decisive sound of Hanna closing a drawer. In the next room Leila turned over in sleep. Somewhere beyond the shutters men called to one another in the short, unmusical tones that meant carrying rather than conversation.

On the coverlet lay the note. On the chair sat the case. One had arrived too late. The other had arrived too early. Between them the room held exactly the width of one night.

CHAPTER XIX

Five More Minutes

When Maryam woke the note was still on the coverlet and the case still
on the chair.
The lamp had burned down badly in the night and left a rim of smoke on
the glass. Beyond the shutters a cart was already moving along the upper
road with the slow obstinacy of something that had set out before the
day had properly gathered its arguments. From the next room came one
brief sound from Leila, not yet awake but turning in sleep as if the
body had begun testing the house for change before the mind agreed to
it.
Maryam sat up and looked first at the note, then at the case. Nothing
had altered in the room. That was the first lie of the morning. The case
was no larger than it had been when Hanna set it there. The note had not
become kinder by lying one night on the bed. Yet the chair now belonged
to use and the coverlet to paper, and the wardrobe doors, left open by
fatigue rather than carelessness, had taken on the temporary look of
cupboards already being judged by departure.
She read the note once more. Today. Four o'clock. The flat. If you can
come, come. I will be there until dark.
The words had not improved by night. There was nothing in them that

could be argued with, which was perhaps why she read them each time as
if repetition might manufacture some extra clause by which failure
became less exact. At last she opened the case.
Packing in daylight was uglier than it had been in lamplight. By night
the thing had seemed like threat; by morning it was merely selection,
and selection was always a confession about value. Two of Leila's
dresses. The thicker cardigan because the lighter one kept slipping off
one shoulder and making the child look, in Hanna's phrase,
insufficiently governed in public. One of Maryam's darker dresses. A
shawl that folded small and looked poorer than it was. Stockings. The
tin of cough lozenges. She stood for a moment with her hairbrush in her
hand, then put it back because it had a cracked tooth and ought to have
been replaced months ago but had stayed simply by being tolerated.
At last she took the note from the bed and, after one ridiculous second
spent looking around the room for some place less revealing than any
other, slipped it inside the case beneath the first rolled pair of
stockings. She did it because the case was open and nearest. Only after
the paper lay there did she understand what she had done and why the
hand that followed did not retrieve it. The note had arrived too late to
be answered and too exactly to be discarded. Hidden among stockings, it

looked no less guilty than it had looked on the coverlet.
From downstairs came the sound of a drawer being opened and shut, then
opened again. Hanna did not move through the house like other people
when time was bad. He moved as if sequence itself might hold the day
together if one fed it enough decisions.
By the time Maryam had dressed and pinned up her hair, the house had
already changed key.
The map remained on the dining table. Beside it sat two loaves under a
cloth, the envelope of certificates, the school circular, the pin dish,
and a list written in Hanna's hand with three columns and no heading.
Huda stood at the dresser tying a scarf around her hair with more speed
than neatness. Ibrahim, still buttoning his cuffs, was trying to fit
three copybooks into a satchel made for two. Amina was on her knees in
the pantry taking out jars as though she meant to interrogate the
shelves one last time. Aunt Widad had arrived early enough to count
spoons before greeting anyone, which she would have denied as a point of
principle if accused. Maryam's mother sat in the drawing room in her
black dress with her hat on though no one else had yet put on a hat, as
if by dressing before the house she could force the day to take her
seriously.
"What time is it?" her mother asked as Maryam came in.
"Half past seven."
"And when does the man with the beds come?"

“After one,” said Hanna from the dining room. “Not before. I told him
not before.”
Her mother drew in breath through her nose. “One should not have to say
not before in a civilised city.”
“In this city one now has to say everything twice,” said Aunt Widad.
“The difficulty is that half the people hear it only once.”
Hanna looked up from the list and held out a cup of tea to Maryam as if
handing over a tool. “Drink this while it is hot.”
“I do not want tea.”
“You do not want most things that are still necessary.”
He did not say it harshly. He did not have to. The list under his hand
had already said enough. On one side he had written Room, on the next
Person, on the third Carried. Not left. Not saved. Carried.
Leila came in with one braid undone and the small blue pencil tucked
behind one ear in imitation of Ibrahim. “Is this the day of the men?”
she asked.
“What men?” said her grandmother.
“The ones for the beds.”
Her mother said, “Do not say beds at breakfast.”
“It is not breakfast,” said Leila. “It is when everyone is cross.”
Amina rose from the pantry with two jars in her hands. “Then it is
breakfast in this house.”
Leila went to Maryam and leaned her head against her waist for one
second only, the brief involuntary gesture by which a child renewed
possession of a mother before returning to self-government. “If the men
take the beds, where do we sleep?”

“Elsewhere,” said Hanna.
“For how long?”
“We will know more after we are elsewhere.”
Leila considered this and frowned. “That sounds like one of the answers
adults give when they know and do not like it.”
Maryam set down the tea untasted. “Go and let Huda finish your braid.”
“What if I want one braid and not two?”
“Then want it quietly.”
The child went, which was how worn she already was. On an ordinary
morning she would have fought the number of braids as if it were
theology.
Hanna folded the list once and put it in his pocket. “Father Elias has
two rooms behind the school for tonight. One for your mother, one for us
and the child. Huda and Ibrahim go first to the cousin on the upper
road. If there is room later, we see what else can be shifted there. If
not, we do not.”
Her mother said from the doorway, “I do not understand why I am being
moved like furniture when I have a front room and a roof.”
“Because your front room may not remain yours through another night,”
said Hanna.
“How dramatic.”
“No,” he said. “Practical.”
Aunt Widad said, “There is no practical reason to move the embroidered
cloths.”
“There is also no practical reason to discuss embroidered cloths at this
hour,” said Hanna.

The sentence passed through the room and lodged where no one wanted it.
After breakfast Maryam packed her mother's case with the sensation of
committing small thefts. Her mother stood by the bed not helping and not
quite hindering, which was the more difficult posture to work against.
The room still held its old arrangement with offensive persistence: the
lace cover on the dressing table, the framed photograph of Maryam's
father in his dark suit, the bottle of scent kept always on the tray
though used only on feast days and after visits from people her mother
wished to remember her by. One could, Maryam saw, lose a house more
quickly than one lost the habits by which one moved around it.
"Not that shawl," her mother said as Maryam lifted the brown wool one
first to hand. "The grey. The brown makes me look as if I have already
become somebody's aunt."
"You are somebody's aunt."
"Not in cloth."
Maryam put the brown shawl back and took the grey. Her mother objected
to the second pair of shoes because they were not decent enough, to the
first because they were too good to travel badly, to the black hat
because it would be crushed, and to leaving it because one could not be
expected to appear before priests bareheaded merely because the city had
taken leave of order.

At last Maryam said, “Then choose one thing and let the rest suffer.”
Her mother looked at her. “Do not speak to me as if I were being
difficult for sport.”
Maryam said nothing to that because the answer, though available, would
have done no good. Instead she folded the grey shawl smaller and laid it
over the nightdress and stockings already in the case. Her mother saw at
once what was missing.
“You are not taking the icon.”
“The small silver one?”
“Of course the small silver one. I am not an Armenian widow moving
through a mountain pass.”
“There is no room.”
“There is room if the lavender sachets are removed. And that bottle of
cough mixture no one will use.”
“Leila may.”
“Then let Leila cough piously.”
The sentence was ridiculous and heartless and exhausted in exactly the
right proportions to be her mother’s own. For one instant Maryam loved
her, or loved what the sentence preserved of ordinary pettiness in a
room where ordinary pettiness ought already to have been extinguished.
Then the moment passed.
“The icon can go in your handbag,” she said.
“My handbag is for money and papers.”
“There will be less money than usual and more papers than usual. They
may coexist.”
That, from her mother, counted almost as a concession.

Hanna appeared in the doorway with the folded list in one hand. “Two questions. Do you still have your father’s insurance papers among your things, and where is the smaller enamel basin?”

Her mother said at once, “The basin cracked in 1939 and your memory is theatrical.”

“It was used after Leila’s fever.”

“That was the larger one.”

“It was not.”

Maryam said, “The basin is in the upper cupboard with the travel blankets.”

He nodded once. “And the papers?”

Her mother looked at him with active injury. “If we are moving for one night, why are my father’s insurance papers relevant?”

“Because if we are moving for one night they are irrelevant and harmless, and if we are moving for longer they cease to be irrelevant.”

He left before she could answer him. His strength had always lain partly in this: saying the thing and moving on before anyone could sentimentalise it into a quarrel.

Just before noon Father Elias came himself, collar slightly askew and dust on one sleeve, younger for the disorder and less priestly than burdened. “The driver says four,” he told Hanna. “Not later. If the convent road begins misbehaving again, he will not come up twice.”

“Four is manageable,” Hanna said.

“Manageable is what people say now when they mean bad but not yet impossible.”

Aunt Widad asked whether the truck could take trunks. Her mother asked
whether it had springs. The priest answered what he could and let the
rest fall where complaint always fell when reality no longer respected
it.

At one the bed men came.

They were not bed men in any dignified trade sense. One was a porter
from the Greek club with shoulders too narrow for the work and the look
of a man who had lately discovered that other people now cried in front
of him as if he were furniture. The other was older and treated screws,
slats, and rolled mattresses with the practical indifference of someone
who had dismantled half the quarter already and seen every possible
variation on reluctance. They took off their shoes in the hall because
Amina told them to and because she looked exactly like the sort of woman
from whom even men carrying iron bedsteads accepted instruction.

The first guest-room frame came apart badly. One screw had rusted into
righteousness and would not yield either to the younger porter's narrow
shoulders or to the older man's screwdriver. Hanna fetched oil from the
kitchen. Amina returned with a rag. The older man knelt on the floor,
one knee in the dust and one hand steadying the iron upright while the
younger tried not to look defeated by furniture. Leila, who had been

told twice to stand clear and therefore remained exactly at the edge of
possible injury, watched as though the bed were a person undergoing
treatment.
“Will it break?” she asked.
“No,” said Hanna.
“It already sounds broken.”
“It sounds resisted.”
The older porter gave a short laugh through his teeth without lifting
his head. At last the screw turned with a noise at once vulgar and
intimate, the sort of sound houses usually kept to themselves. The frame
loosened. One side dipped. The mattress, already rolled and bound with
rope, leaned more heavily into the passage wall. For the first time that
day the house ceased merely to look preparatory. It began to look
dismantled.
When the second frame was lifted from the spare room the marks beneath
it showed pale on the carpet where the sun had not reached in years.
Huda stood in the doorway with the folded blanket from the camp bed and
stared at the white rectangle.
“It looks indecent,” she said.
“It looks dusty,” said Amina.
“It looks as if the bed has been lying about us.”
“Everything in this house has been lying about us,” said Aunt Widad.
Hanna had gone back to the list. He spoke without looking up. “The
smaller room first. Then the front guest room. Ours last.”
Maryam turned. “Why last?”
“Because Leila may need to sleep in it before we go.”

“We are leaving before dark.”
“If the truck is on time.”
“When has anything been on time?”
“Sometimes men with wheels are more frightened than we are. Fear improves punctuality.”
By half past one the guest room had become recognisable only by its wallpaper. The rolled mattress leaned in the hall. The truck had not yet come. The beds of a house looked ridiculous once upright against walls, like arguments no longer able to lie down.
Amina took Maryam’s black coat out to the back steps and brushed it with a violence just short of anger. When Maryam went to take it from her she saw, near the shoulder seam, a thin line of white dust.
“From the frame,” Amina said. “Stand still.”
“It does not matter.”
“Everything matters once it is visible.”
Amina brushed again, then again. “There,” she said. “Now it looks as if you still belong to your own coat.”
Maryam reached for it. Amina did not release it immediately.
“Do not stand too long wherever you go next,” she said. “People notice standing still more than walking.”
The sentence might have been about dust. It was not about dust. Maryam said nothing because to answer would have enlarged it and there was no room left in the day for enlargement.
At three the parish truck still had not come. At ten past three, when Hanna was already in the yard with the porter and the mattress ropes and

Aunt Widad had begun saying this was what came of trusting institutions
with wheels, the driver appeared at last in a vehicle that was not a
lorry and also not a carriage and therefore offended everyone equally.
It had benches at the sides and a tarpaulin rolled back for loading.
Father Elias sat beside the driver as though to certify the truck's
moral purpose by his mere presence.
"I told you four," the priest said apologetically, which was how they
knew the matter was worse than delay. "We had to drop a widow with two
grandchildren at the convent first."
"Then we are still in credit," said Hanna.
Loading the truck took less time than protesting it. Her mother's case
went first, then Leila's, then the rolled blankets Aunt Widad had
declared non-negotiable and Hanna had called excessive until the priest
quietly said the rooms behind the school held their cold without
argument. Huda and Ibrahim were sent ahead on foot with the cousin's
boy. Aunt Widad insisted she would follow in half an hour after seeing
whether the lower kitchen window had been properly barred, as though
barring a window after beds had been taken out of a house remained a
measurable contribution to order.
Through all this Maryam moved as instructed. The child's satchel. The
enamel mug for cough mixture. The bottle wrapped in paper. Her mother's

shawl. A packet of needles Amina thrust into her hand because there was
no knowing what rooms forgot to contain. She performed each act without
yet feeling departure in full. The body could do this for some time:
obey movement before the mind admitted what movement was for.
It came at last not in the truck, not in the hall, not with the blankets, but in the bedroom.
She had gone upstairs only to fetch Leila's second shoe because the
first had somehow reached the truck and the second had not. The room
stood open, diminished by its own emptied surfaces. The wardrobe doors
were open again. One drawer hung half-pulled. On the chair where the
case had stood there was now only the indent in the cane seat. On the
washstand stood the glass her mother used for teeth. Beside it, because
no one had thought to move it, lay the key to Uncle Yusef's flat.
Maryam picked it up and then did not move.
There were no speeches in her head. Only the absurdity that this piece
of metal, which opened a dead man's room containing less and less,
should now feel heavier than the packed case, the child, the mattresses,
the map, or the road.
From below came the sounds of departure rendered practical: the driver
coughing once, Father Elias asking whether there was one more case,
Leila saying she did not wish to sit on the left because the left had no

window, Amina telling someone not to lift by the handle because the
handle was decorative and decorative things lied.
Then Hanna was in the doorway.
He did not ask what she was doing. He looked once at her hand, once at
the washstand, once at the bed with the coverlet turned back from the
morning and never straightened, and said in the same even voice with
which he might have announced the bread man's arrival, "I have given you
five more minutes."
It took her a second to understand the grammar of it. Not *Take what you
need*. Not *Make it quick*. Not *We have no time*. *I have given you
five more minutes.*
As if time were not hers in that room any longer and never had been; as
if what he could offer was not understanding but measure; as if mercy
itself, in him, could only arrive through allocation.
She said nothing.
He nodded once, not to hurry her but to mark the terms, and went away
again.
The house below did not grow still for her. That was the other part of
the gift. It continued. The men lifted. Leila complained. The priest
coughed. A pan was set down in the kitchen. Amina said, "Not that one,
the other rope." All of it went on. She had not been granted a private
suspension of the day. She had been granted five minutes within it.
She put the key into her coat pocket and then took it out again because

keys in pockets made a visible line and she did not want anything
visible. She looked once around the room as if some other object might
ask to be chosen instead. The brush. The mirror. One glove left in the
drawer. The folded church bulletin on the mantel. All at once she saw
with complete clarity that selection did not honour things. It merely
created one more injury for what was not taken.
When Hanna came back he did not come faster. He came at the same pace
and stopped in the same doorway.
“Come,” he said.
She put the key into her handbag because bags were already guilty and
could absorb another form of it. Then she turned and went with him.
At the front door her mother was already seated in the truck with the
shawl up around her throat and an expression of such stern insult that,
had anyone not known better, they might have taken her for a judge
compelled to ride with petitioners. Leila sat beside Father Elias and
was at once fascinated and offended by the truck’s springs. Aunt Widad
stood in the yard giving instructions to Huda though Huda was no longer
within hearing distance. Ibrahim had gone ahead. Amina was in the
passage with the kitchen key in one hand and a wrapped parcel in the
other.
“What are you doing?” Maryam asked her.
“Shutting the stove. Barring the back door. Taking the pan your aunt

forgot she wanted. Then going by the upper way before dark becomes proud
of itself."
She held out the parcel. "Bread. Cheese. The smaller knife."
Maryam took it. "For how long?"
Amina's face altered by less than a degree. "Until there is a table
again."
Then, because the answer had gone further than either wanted, she added,
"Or until the child begins crying from hunger and your mother calls that
weakness."
Hanna came out of the house carrying the last packet of papers under one
arm and the rolled map under the other. He handed the map to Father
Elias, passed the papers to Maryam, then went back once more inside.
When he came out the second time there was nothing in his hands but the
key-ring.
He shut the front door and turned the key.
The sound was not large. Metal, wood, a resistance overcome. Yet because
the house had been full of smaller sounds all day — rope over bedsteads,
drawers, shoes, cups, stove door, cart wheel — the lock sounded almost
ceremonial by contrast. Hanna did not linger. He only checked once that
it had taken, then put the key into his pocket.
They jolted into the road.
Jerusalem moved past in the wrong register. It was still afternoon.
There was still bread in some shops, shouting at corners, boys sent on

errands, one man mending a bicycle against a wall as if all weeks
retained the right to require mended bicycles. Yet the city had also
begun exhibiting itself in sections like a house under partial clearing:
a rolled carpet against a railing, a stack of chairs in a yard, women
carrying not baskets but bundles tied in pillowcases, one mattress on a
cart with the brass knobs still attached.
“Are we going very far?” Leila asked.
“No,” said Hanna.
“Then why did we need blankets?”
“Because near is not the same as warm.”
When they turned by the convent road Maryam looked back without meaning
to. The house was already gone from sight. Not the memory of it. Only
the visible arrangement of stone and shutters and wrong curtain. The
bend in the road had taken it. She faced forward again before Leila
could ask what she had looked at.
The rooms behind the school took possession of them at once by refusing
familiarity.
The first held two narrow beds with iron rails painted a green that had
once intended cheerfulness and now looked only hygienic. The second held
one wider bed, two rush chairs, a washstand with a cracked basin, and a
stove whose black iron had been polished by generations of reluctant
temporary guests. The window looked not onto any view a person could
wish to claim but onto the upper wall of the school yard, the head of a

cypress, and a strip of sky cut thin enough to look rationed. Her mother entered first and stopped just beyond the threshold.

“There is nowhere to put flowers,” she said.

Father Elias, carrying the rolled blanket and map because priests had lately become beasts of burden by default, answered, “That is one of the room’s strengths.”

Her mother looked at him as if deciding whether piety excused wit. Then she sat on the nearest bed and put one hand on the counterpane as though to establish legal possession.

Hanna stayed long enough to test the latch, the lamp, and the water. Then he said he must go back.

“To what?” said her mother.

“To the house.”

“What remains there worth a man’s return?”

He looked at her with almost perfect patience. “You. The rest of you is still there.”

Maryam followed him into the passage before she had decided to. The plaster wall held the day’s cold. From the next room came voices through the boards in that muted communal way they had in hospitals and schools.

“When will you come back?” she asked.

“Before dark if the roads allow it.”

He looked tired enough that the skin beneath his eyes had gone almost translucent. She could smell outside air and bread flour on his coat.

“Keep the door latched after dusk,” he said. Then, because he knew that was insufficient even by his own measure, he added, “If I am delayed, it will be delay.”

It was a poor sentence. It was also, by Hanna’s standards, almost intimate.

He nodded once and went. She stood in the passage until she heard the truck start, then die, then start again.

The room grew smaller after he left. Huda opened the case and took out what was needed. Her mother chose the

mattress farthest from the window because draughts, she said, were the one political force she had never trusted. Leila lay under the desk making a house out of one blanket and the doll. The place was becoming whatever the quarter asked of it five minutes after insisting it would ask nothing. Later, when the lamp had been turned low and Leila's back was warm against her, Maryam lay still and listened to the passage settle. In the case at the foot of the mattress, beneath the stockings, the note still lay where she had put it. In her handbag lay Yusef's key. In her pocket lay Nadia's third letter. On the shelf at home lay Nawal's card.

The house was shut. The flat was bare. The note lay under the stockings, answered by nothing. She was here.

Chapter XX

The Key

By morning the room no longer looked borrowed. It looked used, which was worse.

A strip of chalk still lay in the tray beneath the blackboard, as if a teacher had left in the middle of a sum and meant to return after luncheon. Two of Leila's stockings hung from the back of a chair because they had been washed in the basin and had not yet decided whether to dry. Her mother's shawl lay folded over the desk nearest the door, too carefully placed to count as untidiness and too out of place to look like anything else. Along the wall, where the mattresses had been laid side by side, the blankets had already taken on the shapes of those who had slept badly beneath them.

Maryam had not expected sleep to come. It had, in torn shallow pockets. Each time she woke she had to remember where the room ended, which breathing belonged to whom, and why the blackboard stood where the wardrobe ought to have been. By the fourth waking she stopped hoping morning would improve anything and waited only for it to arrive and take over.

Now the room held that grey hour in which faces were still half with sleep and objects had not yet resumed their full claims. Huda sat on her mattress with her hair unpinned, sewing a button back on to Ibrahim's shirt. Ibrahim still slept, one hand above his head, younger in sleep than he ever looked when dressed and defensive. Aunt Widad, who had declared the night before that she could sleep anywhere if the linen were decent, was already upright with both hands on her knees and the expression of a

woman who had been made to camp by history and would not permit history to see her untidy. Her hat stood on the desk beside her like evidence from a better room.

From the passage came the sound of water being poured from one enamel jug to another, then Amina's voice, flat with exhaustion rather than temper.

"If you wash all four faces in one basin, I shall stop recognising any of you out of self-defence."

Leila laughed. That laugh, which the day before had seemed impossible, struck Maryam with a small pain of gratitude.

Her mother, beneath the blanket nearest the wall, said, "If there had been proper hot water when requested, none of this communal barbarism would be necessary."

No one answered. Even Aunt Widad had learnt that some remarks, repeated often enough, no longer deserved contradiction because contradiction implied novelty.

Maryam pushed herself upright. Her neck ached from having slept with Leila's heels against her ribs for part of the night. Her shoes were where she had left them, one upright, one on its side, as though even they had not agreed whether the room ought to be treated as temporary or endured as fact. She bent to right the fallen one and reached for the handbag beneath the chair. The key was there at once beneath her fingers, lying sideways against the purse. She had forgotten it only because forgetting had briefly become useful.

Yusef's key.

Not their house key. Not one of Hanna's office keys. The flat key, taken up from the washstand because it had lain there too lightly and too far behind all afternoon, then put

away without being put aside. Her fingers closed round it by instinct, as though the room were asking her to account for every hard thing she still possessed.

She left it where it was and rose.

In the passage Amina stood by the basin in her blouse and underskirt, sleeves rolled, hair twisted and pinned with less care than usual. In their own house she would already have restored herself to full propriety before the first kettle boiled. Here necessity had outrun form.

“Do not use the smaller jug,” Amina said as Maryam came out. “It pours on your shoes instead of your face.”

“Who has had the hot water?”

“Your mother, who announced last night that she would not wake into history without tea and hot water and then woke into both before I had lit anything.”

“I heard that,” her mother said from within.

Amina did not raise her voice. “You were meant to.”

On the desk near the door lay the school circular from the day before, folded under a spoon against the draft, and beside it a loaf with one end already cut. Hanna had gone out before dawn, as he had the habit of doing now. His absence had the feel of a profession with him rather than an injury. He left when sequence required it and came back carrying the next necessary fact, however unwelcome. The room, in his absence, held itself more poorly but not less honestly.

“What time is it?” Maryam asked.

“Past seven,” said Aunt Widad. “Which in these rooms means one has risen too late to do anything elegantly and too early to excuse it.”

Huda looked up from the shirt. “The widow with the grandchildren is still in the smaller room. The little one coughed all night.”

Her mother said, “That coughing came through the wall.”

“That is what walls do in schoolrooms,” Aunt Widad said. “They educate.”

Leila emerged at last with one cheek wet and the other still marked by sleep. “The basin tastes of iron,” she said.

“You are not meant to drink the basin,” Amina answered.

“How do you know I did?”

“Because children only complain in such detail about their own experiments.”

Maryam took the towel from the peg and rubbed at Leila’s hair where the water had not reached properly. The child endured this with the tragic patience of the mildly inconvenienced.

“Will we go home after breakfast?” she asked.

No one answered at once. It was Aunt Widad who spoke.

“We will go somewhere after breakfast. That is enough for now.”

“Home is a somewhere.”

“Yes,” said Aunt Widad. “It is.”

From beyond the shutters came the thin uncertain sounds of the quarter beginning a day it no longer trusted: a cart wheel striking a stone, the call of a bread seller, a burst of speech cut short rather than concluded. The school itself was not in session, yet the rooms retained enough of the old habit of instruction to make everything done inside

them seem provisional, as though at any moment someone might enter, dismiss the families, and demand copybooks.

A knock at the outer door made every head lift. Amina set down the jug and went because she still moved first in any room where labour and interruption met.

It was Father Elias, carrying two small loaves tucked under one arm and a packet wrapped in old newspaper beneath the other. His collar sat slightly askew and his shoes wore the damp of the streets.

“Only bread,” he said at once. “Nothing saintly about it. The convent had more than they required this morning.”

“That means they expect more later,” Aunt Widad said.

“At my age,” the priest answered, “one cannot bring bread into a room without it becoming prophecy.”

He set the loaves on the desk and looked around with a professional discretion that did not quite hide pity. Priests had seen too many temporary rooms to be impressed by any one of them.

“Hanna?” he asked.

“Out,” said Amina.

“Doing what?”

“What he always does when the rest of us would rather he sat down.”

Father Elias nodded once. “He stopped at the parish house first and then the office. There is talk of moving the records again if the lower windows are as exposed as they seem. He said he would return before nine.”

Maryam said, “Thank you.”

He laid the newspaper packet beside the bread. “Cheese. Unimpressive, but easier to distribute than comfort.”

Her mother, drawing the blanket more tightly round herself, said, “I have never known cheese to arrive without conditions.”

“In the convent,” said Father Elias, “everything arrives with conditions.”

Leila was already at the desk. “Will we stay here tonight?”

The priest’s eyes moved over the room and rested briefly on Maryam, on the blankets, on the children’s shoes lined beneath the desk, on Amina folding a towel that did not belong to her. He looked not saintly, not sorrowful, only accurate.

“You may remain another night,” he said. “After that I would prefer not to promise.”

“To whom?” Aunt Widad asked.

“To anyone,” he said.

After he had gone, Maryam took the key from her bag and held it openly in her hand. It looked smaller now and more useless. A key begged for a door; without one it became only a shaped insistence on what was elsewhere.

Aunt Widad glanced up from threading a needle she plainly could no longer see well enough to thread. “What key?”

“Yusef’s.”

“For the flat?”

“Yes.”

She absorbed this a moment. “Keep it.”

“Why?”

“Because if you give it to your husband now he will put it with the others and it will become one more instrument. If you keep it, it remains what it is.”

“Which is what?”

“Not yours,” said Aunt Widad. “That is sometimes the most exact category available.”

Maryam closed her hand round the key again. It warmed almost immediately.

By the time Hanna returned it was nearly dark. He had acquired flour somehow, and candles, and news that was not news but only the current shape of uncertainty: two more families gone from the upper road, a cousin from Talbiya not yet arrived where he was expected, another lorry promised for morning and distrusted already. He also brought, folded into his inside pocket, a small official slip certifying something no room any longer cared to hear certified.

He set down the flour, removed his hat, and looked once around the schoolroom. His gaze had always been assessing. Now it assessed as though each object had begun keeping time.

“They will let us have one of the convent rooms tomorrow if we choose it,” he said.

“Choose it over what?” said Aunt Widad.

“Over staying here another night and then finding the choice has been made for us.”

Her mother said, “Convents smell of boiled cabbage and supervision.”

“Then we will be morally nourished.”

“Do not joke.”

“It was not a joke.”

He sat at the desk, because sitting at the desk in these rooms had become his nearest equivalent to authority, and pulled off one glove finger by finger. His hands looked colder than his face.

Maryam said, “And the house?”

“The shutter held. Elias is there still.”

“And the flat?”

The question escaped more evenly than she expected. No one else in the room looked up.

Hanna answered as if she had asked about a file. “The building is shut before dark. Elias says no one has disturbed the door.”

That was all.

It was enough to make the room shift slightly, though not in anything anyone else could have named. The door had not been disturbed. Nothing had entered. Nothing had emerged. The room stood where it stood, unopened and unentered, while all the other decisions went on without asking her. She did not have to choose whether to go there. The day had already done without asking her. Relief came with the knowledge and at once made itself ugly.

Hanna was watching her now, not openly, only with the slight attention he gave to matters that might become urgent if ignored too long. There were many things he did not ask. It had taken Maryam years to learn that silence in him was not emptiness. Sometimes it was merely the refusal to demand a sentence from someone already carrying too many.

“You should sleep earlier tonight if we move tomorrow,” he said.

She almost answered with something sharp because sharpness would have been easier than gratitude. Instead she said, “Perhaps.”

Leila, hearing the word move, looked up from the alphabet she had been writing badly on the back of a circular. “Again?”

“Yes,” said Hanna.

“I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep the pencils.”

“Then hold on to the pencils.”

This seemed to satisfy her. She gathered the three blue pencils into her fist and sat on them as if history might otherwise take them.

Night came fully. The widow in the smaller room coughed again. A baby somewhere further down the passage began and stopped and began again. A pot was dropped in the convent kitchen. The room smelt now of flour, damp wool, and extinguished candle rather than of school. One could acclimatise to anything if given enough other people and insufficient choice.

When at last the children had been made horizontal and the blankets pulled up and the final cup drained and her mother’s complaints reduced to murmur, Maryam lay down without first removing the key from her bag. For a while she kept one hand resting against the clasp through the folded blanket beside her, fingers tracing the outline of the metal beneath the leather. It was absurd to touch it so often. It opened a flat growing emptier by the day, a room she could not decently go to, a desk nearly cleared, a life

already redistributed into files, bundles, unclaimed objects, and memory. Yet it remained more honest than most things around her. It promised only access, and even that only if the door still stood and the road allowed.

Leila's breathing deepened beside her. Across the room Hanna was not yet asleep; she could tell by the measured incompleteness of his stillness. Huda turned once and settled. Aunt Widad, astonishingly, snored for half a second and then denied it with a cough.

Maryam thought of the house. Not grandly. She thought of the hall where the stair light never fell properly, of the washstand in the bedroom, of the drawer where the glove might still lie, of the blue vase corrected first for grief and then for normalcy, of the smell of cedar in the linen cupboard. She thought too of the quarter as it had been three months earlier: not safer, perhaps, but wide enough that wasted hours still looked like waste and not privilege. The city had once let people be careless with time. Now every hour arrived with a use attached. She thought of Yusef's flat and the chipped mug on the sill, though she did not know whether the mug remained there and the not knowing had become part of it.

She thought of Tariq not as an image but as the note, the flat, the demand that had not been answered because the answer had been overtaken elsewhere. Hanna's report about the door had eased something in her at once. That was the indecency. If the flat was shut and the road already narrowing, then no one could ask her tonight to decide whether to try it. The choice had been lifted out of reach and the knowledge of that felt, for a moment, like rest. She knew what sort of feeling it was. It remained.

Somewhere in the passage someone rose to use the bucket and apologised to no one in particular. A bell from the convent marked an hour the room had no use for.

Under the blanket her hand found Leila's warm ankle and rested there a moment, as if the child's body were the only honest inventory left to her. Then she took the key out at last and laid it on the desk beside her folded gloves.

In the morning it would still be there, small and displaced, opening nothing in the room where it had come to rest.